The Sparkling Knight

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Teen And Up Audiences

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F/F

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Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Medieval, Alternate Universe - Fantasy, Glimadora - Freeform, Glimmadora - Freeform, Developing Relationship, Princess Adora (She-Ra), Knight Glimmer, Blood and Injury, Implied/Referenced Character Death, Trauma, Dreams and Nightmares, Adora and Catra are Siblings (She-Ra), Mythical Beings & Creatures, Protective Glimmer (She-Ra)

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The Sparkling Knight

by TheGlimmadoraArchives

Summary

Adora, the Princess of Grayskull, was kept inside the castle by Shadow Weaver for years. One fateful day, her new knight, Glimmer, sneaks her out of the castle.

Glimmer seeks to keep Adora safe and to help protect the kingdom. Adora wants to someday bring the kingdom of Grayskull into an era of peace when she becomes queen.

Meanwhile, an ancient evil seeks to destroy the land.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Longing For Adventure

The Kingdom of Grayskull was a land of myth and magic. Its history was steeped in tales of courageous warriors and adventurous knights. Stories of legendary rulers and fearless mages. Everyone lived in peace and harmony. In ancient times, a man of great evil sought to rule the land. With forbidden power, he shrouded the kingdom in darkness. Everyone lost hope. Out of fear, many people surrendered to the wicked man. The hour of doom seemed at hand.

As the evil man prepared to seal Grayskull's fate, a heroine led a revolt. With the help of her friends, she saved the kingdom. The sorcerers unleashed a spell to imprison the wicked one. Thus, he was trapped in a dark realm. The heroine's tale was passed down for generations.

Glimmer closed the book. The teen girl had read it from cover to cover many times. At seventeen years old, she longed for adventure. She aspired to be a powerful sorcerer like her father. A strong knight like her mother. People might dismiss it as her fantasies stemming from epic fables. It didn't matter what they said. She wouldn't let their words discourage her. However, her aunt Castaspella believed she had potential.

Glimmer placed the book onto the bookshelf. Other than sword training and magic practice, today was slow. Sighing, she walked to the fireplace. Above the mantle, she scrutinized the painting. It depicted Angella and Micah standing together. The former wore a suit of armor. The latter wore a purple tunic. Before Angella died, she was the captain of the royal guard. Micah taught young sorcerers at Mystacor Academy before his demise.

Footsteps advanced. Castaspella stood next to Glimmer, gazing at the painting. The woman's expression was somber. Then, Castaspella spoke.

"I think about them every day," Castaspella said.

Glimmer frowned. "Did you ever find out how my parents died?"

"The only information I had gathered is that they didn't make it. Their attempt at an uprising fell apart. Perhaps the Horde Clan murdered your parents. Those people had ties to Shadow Weaver. I do not consider her a queen. She could be responsible for the deaths of King Randor and Queen Marlena. The kingdom is suffering under Shadow Weaver's rule."

"There must be something we can do." Glimmer strode to the window. "You know the tale of the legendary heroine? I want to help people. It was something she did in her life."

"Glimmer, you remind me of your parents. You're brave, and you have a sense of justice. The legendary heroine had those same qualities."

After they finished talking, Castaspella left the room. Glimmer walked outside. Mystacor Village was a town in the mountains. Of the locations in Grayskull, this one was popular with sorcerers. People hurried back and forth, going about their day. Stalls lined the cobblestone paths. Some individuals were selling potions. Others were advertising herbs and plants. A few had spellbooks. There was one stall with candles and crystals.

In the town center, there was a fountain. Elegant carvings had been etched onto it. A statue stood on top of the fountain. Glimmer wandered past the buildings. Within minutes, the teenager approached the village gate. Beyond her hometown, she saw miles of trees and cragged peaks. The mountain range served as a barrier for the kingdom. Her gaze drifted to a sloped path.

Tales of heroes riding through mountain ranges and vast lands came to mind. Glimmer imagined riding a horse throughout the kingdom. A familiar voice said her name. She turned around. It was Bow, her childhood friend.

"Are you thinking about going somewhere?" Bow asked.

"Sort of. How about you? You sometimes travel," Glimmer said.

"Mostly to see the Star Siblings in Krytis Village. Otherwise, I practice archery."

"You still go to those seaside towns? And it's for a reason other than seeing Sea Hawk?"

Bow chuckled. "Yeah."

Glimmer smirked. "I remember when you had a major crush on Sea Hawk."

"Hey, I thought he was confident and good-looking!"

Glimmer shifted her weight to her other foot. "You've gone to the town surrounding Grayskull Castle, correct?"

"Gray Haven?" Bow asked.

"Yes."

"I went there a few times during my journeys. Why do you ask?"

"I was wondering." Glimmer gazed at the mountain peaks. "Perhaps we could take our horses and ride to Gray Haven."

Bow rested his hands on his hips. "Is there a reason for it? Are you going to try and investigate how your parents died?"

"Of course. Shadow Weaver and the Horde Clan shouldn't keep hurting people. The old witch overthrew King Randor and Queen Marlena twelve years ago. As for their children, who knows what happened to them? Some said the prince had disappeared. The princess hadn't left the castle in years."

"Got it. Are you sure we could take on Shadow Weaver? Everyone knows she's the most powerful sorceress in the kingdom."

"We're not going to storm the castle and fight her." Glimmer stroked her chin. She knew her mother used to work at the castle.

"I could sign up to become a knight. Under the guise of guarding the princess, I'll try to investigate things further."

Bow shrugged. "I'm not going to stop you, am I?"

"Do you want to continue living under tyranny? The kingdom cannot thrive under Shadow Weaver's reign."

"Alright, you have a point. We're going together, though." Bow glanced at the sky. "It'll be night soon. We can leave in the morning."

Glimmer peeked at the clouds. "That's fine. It'll give us time to prepare for the trip."

The two friends parted ways. Glimmer walked to her house and stepped inside. She grabbed her sword from the makeshift weapon room and strode into the garden. The training dummy idled by the stone fence. She barraged it with a series of blows. The sun glided toward the horizon. She went inside the house and grabbed the spellbook. Then, she returned to the garden and practiced new spells. Some worked. Others were tricky to pull off. Her parents would be proud of her.

Glimmer stared at the sunset. The teenager's breaths slowed and deepened. Memories of her parents surfaced. A subtle anger arose as she thought of their unexplained deaths. She hadn't forgotten the sadness in Castaspella's eyes. She retrieved the spellbook and the sword. The sun dipped below the horizon. It left behind various hues of pink and purple. Birds chirped, flying toward trees.

Upon entering the house, Glimmer put away the sword and the spellbook. An aroma of dinner wafted into the air. There was soup cooking above the fireplace. Her stomach grumbled as she occupied a seat by the table.

Castaspella carried a pair of bowls to the table and placed them on it. Both women began eating. Nearby, there was a plate of

bread. Glimmer took a slice and slathered butter on it. She bit off a piece, then chewed before swallowing.

"How's the academy?" Glimmer asked.

Castaspella looked up. "It's alright for the most part. I enjoyed watching experienced sorcerers teach young students. The head sorcerer alerted us to a financial problem. We had to cut some classes and make adjustments. We received a rather unpleasant letter. The person hadn't divulged their identity."

"Have they explained the anonymity?"

"No. The sender warned of a cursed eclipse."

"What does that mean?"

"It has something to do with dark magic. The head sorcerer has told the teachers to be alert for anything unusual."

"Who would threaten Mystacor Academy?"

Castaspella sipped her tea. "Shadow Weaver. Years ago, she taught your father under the name Light Spinner. She dabbled in dangerous magic. Norwyn and the others found out. They exiled her. In a fit of anger, she ended their lives with a deadly curse. She left."

Glimmer let go of the spoon, letting it sit in the bowl. "Did Shadow Weaver ever come back?"

"No. For a time, Shadow Weaver served as an advisor to the royal family. At the time, your mother was the captain of the royal guard. In her letters to me, she told me about Weaver's deception. The sorceress claimed to have solutions for unexplained catastrophes. King Randor and Queen Marlena believed the lies. When the prince and princess were small children, Shadow Weaver dethroned the royal couple. Your mother and father left Gray Haven. Over time, they tried to form a

resistance. But most people were afraid of Shadow Weaver's power. Then, four years ago, they attempted to fight back."

Glimmer and Castaspella ate dinner as they talked. Once they finished the meal, Glimmer ascended the stairs. She entered her room. She reclined on the bed, dwelling on the story. How did the princess feel about Shadow Weaver's presence? Where did the prince go? Did the sorceress separate the royal siblings on purpose? Had someone taken the prince to safety? If so, how did that person forget the princess?

Moonlight streamed through the window. Glimmer couldn't stop thinking about the coming adventure. The teenager couldn't wait to find the answers she sought. Her eyelids grew heavy. By midnight, she drifted to the world of dreams.

Morning dawned in Grayskull. The castle servants helped Adora change into her dress. The gown consisted of a red bodice, a white skirt, and matching gloves. A golden crown with rubies sat upon her braided hair. Earrings dangled from her earlobes. She descended the steps of the tallest tower. Then, she strode to the dining hall, where Shadow Weaver and Catra sat.

Catra wore a crimson tunic over chainmail. Her messy hair was pulled into a ponytail. As usual, the brunette wore black leggings beneath the tunic. Shadow Weaver was decked out in a black-and-maroon gown. A veil concealed her face.

"My dear, how is your sleep?" Shadow Weaver asked. "We know the potion has fogged your mind."

Adora covered her mouth, stifling a yawn. "I slept the entire night. My memories are still confusing."

"I'm aware of the unfortunate side effects, child. It will benefit you in the long run. Remember, you must stay inside the castle at all hours. The outside world is too dangerous for a delicate flower. And you know what happens to them?"

The servants rushed into the hall, arranging plates around the table. Shadow Weaver dismissed them. They gave quick nods and ran off. Adora noticed the fear in their eyes. As far as she knew, Shadow Weaver hadn't harmed anyone. The queen was a strict ruler. Shadow Weaver spoke again.

"Anything outside could crush delicate flowers. Merciless bandits. Natural disasters. Monsters and poisonous vipers. At night, they are worse. They could eat someone whole."

Adora shuddered as Shadow Weaver rattled off the list of dangers. She took a bite of her breakfast. The sorceress always said that she wasn't ready. At some point, Catra interrupted the lecture with a sarcastic comment.

"I will not accept your insolence!" Shadow Weaver spat. "Wearing that uniform is already crossing the line."

"You have double standards. According to you, Adora has to stay inside. Yet you don't say anything whenever I leave the castle," Catra said.

"You still have to follow the rules. It's different for both of you."

"Yeah, old lady. Nothing has happened to you whenever you went to meet diplomats somewhere else!"

Shadow Weaver shot up, palms pressing against the table. "I cannot stand your attitude! Why can't you be prim and proper like Princess Adora?"

Adora ate her breakfast in silence. It wasn't the first time Shadow Weaver and Catra had an argument. Sometimes, the quarrels would become violent. Shadow Weaver had used spells to torture Catra. Occasionally, Adora was on the receiving end of such magic. Once the plate was empty, she rose to her height.

"I will not apologize for yelling," Shadow Weaver said. "If you'll excuse me, I'll attend to my royal duties."

Adora sighed. "There is something I want to discuss. I turned nineteen this year. Will it be okay if I go outside today?"

"Adora! How many times must we go over this? I should be in the throne room. Instead, I'm wasting my morning on this unnecessary conversation!"

"Sorry, Shadow Weaver. Can we talk when you're not busy?"

"Keep this up, and you'll face consequences for questioning me."

Adora kept her head down as she made her way into the hallway. She didn't want to be punished. Shadow Weaver's idea of 'consequences' involved magical torture. The princess walked past the armored statues. Since she couldn't leave the castle, the least she could do was explore her home. It felt like a prison. Sometimes, a guard followed her through a corridor.

Within an hour, Adora returned to her room. Wardrobes and bookshelves filled every corner. A canopy bed took up half the bedroom. She approached the window. Outside the tower, she could see bridges connecting each spire. The white stones caught the rays of sunlight. A soft glow enveloped the structure. Beyond the towers, miles of land stretched into the distance.

Again, wanderlust flooded Adora's heart. She wanted to see the world beyond the castle. A familiar figure raced across the bridge. It was Catra. How did the brunette even earn such freedom? Adora plopped onto a chair. Would her situation ever change? The window creaked open. Catra made her way inside.

"Shadow Weaver thinks you're so special," Catra said. "You're just a sheltered damsel."

Adora rolled her eyes. "Here we go again. I don't need a constant reminder of this. You'd understand if you were the one locked up."

"Heh, sure. You're a boring princess who's desperate for validation."

"Hey, I'm the person who asked Shadow Weaver to let you live in the castle. You were an orphan ten years ago. I could tell her to kick you out."

"Come on, Adora. You wouldn't do that. You were lonely at the time."

"Still, it wouldn't hurt to show some kindness."

Catra closed the window. "Shadow Weaver's supposed to meet with the leader of the Horde Clan. We could spy on them."

"It would be improper."

"It'll be quick. Shadow Weaver won't suspect a thing."

Adora shrugged. "Fine. If we get caught, don't blame me. It was your idea, not mine."

Catra led Adora all the way to the throne room. They hid behind a stone pillar. A deep blue rug covered the polished flooring. Golden chandeliers hung from the ceiling. Shadow Weaver stood in front of the throne. A man gave a deep bow. The queen's voice filled the room. Her tone was authoritative.

"Chancellor Hordak, have our sorcerers been preventing further uprisings?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"They should," Hordak said.

"Are you still reaching out to Horde Prime?"

"Yes. The sorcerers will find a way to release him from the dark realm."

Adora and Catra exchanged glances. Adora whispered, "I didn't know he was a chancellor."

Catra leaned against the pillar. "Something's off about Hordak. I can sense it."

Shadow Weaver peeked in their direction for a brief moment. Adora's heart froze. If the queen saw them, they would be in trouble. She held her breath. So did Catra. Shadow Weaver turned her attention to Hordak. Adora and Catra snuck out of the throne room.

"Let's not do it again," Adora said, voice shaking. "Also, Horde Prime? The evil warlord from the legend?"

"What do they hope to gain from releasing Horde Prime?" Catra asked.

"I don't know."

The heavy wooden doors opened. Adora and Catra ducked behind armored statues. Shadow Weaver scrutinized the hallway, then left. The hairs on Adora's neck and arms stood. It was a close call. She rushed to her room and shut the door behind her. Would Shadow Weaver mention any of this later?

Glimmer was tying the saddlebags to her horse when a scream drilled into her ears. Unsheathing the sword, she followed the sound. The moon passed in front of the sun, blocking out its light. Darkness blanketed Mystacor Village. However, it had a sinister feeling to it. Crimson-eyed shadows infiltrated the academy. Dozens of sorcerers tried to stop the creatures. Growls and roars pierced the air. Horses galloped back and forth in a panic.

Another shout prompted Glimmer to charge into Mystacor Academy. The halls were pitch-black. Every light - candles, torches, and chandeliers - was snuffed out. Chilly air seeped into her tunic. She summoned an illumination spell.

Outlines of unconscious sorcerers came into view. A disembodied hand with claws swiped at Glimmer. She jumped back. Her senses were on high alert as she held up her sword. Fortunately, she had chainmail under her tunic. The claws would have gored her.

Glimmer took calming breaths, maintaining her composure. She crept into a spacious chamber. A cauldron idled in the center. Sorcerers had used it for advanced spells, summoning specters, and premonitions. Castaspella lay nearby, unmoving. What happened to her aunt?

"Castaspella?" Glimmer whispered as she approached the older woman. She nudged Castaspella's shoulder. "Are you okay?"

Castaspella moaned. Her eyes didn't open. Dread settled in Glimmer's heart. Would the curse end the older woman's life? How about the others? Claws scraped against the floor, accompanied by growls. Glimmer whirled around, tightening her grip on the sword. The creatures seemed to study her. Within seconds, they lunged at her. She conjured a transparent shield. It deflected the sharp claws.

Glimmer brought up the sword for a counterattack. The teenager surged her magical power into the blade. She swung it through the air, unleashing a flash of bright energy. The creatures flew backward, ramming into the wall. She barraged them with lethal spells. In unison, the beasts emitted a noise. She wouldn't call them screams. No living thing would make such a sound.

The unnatural shrieks faded to silence. Thick, black smoke escaped the creatures as they dissolved. Glimmer had read about such monsters in storybooks. Some of those beasts were illustrated in yesterday's book. According to the tale, they came from the dark realm. Didn't the ancient sorcerers cut off the bridge between two worlds? They made sure the monsters didn't invade the light world.

Glimmer glanced at Castaspella, then at the exit. The young warrior charged into the passageway. She searched for more monsters. However, they must have gone outside. Upon leaving Mystacor Academy, her footsteps halted. In the streets, people collapsed. Was it out of fear? Was it a result of the curse? She conjured the illumination spell as she looked for her horse.

"Star? Star!" Glimmer shouted.

Glimmer searched the stables. The horse wasn't here. Did the steed run away? A neigh drew her attention to the trees. She made her way to the woods.

"It's me, Glimmer," Glimmer said as she stepped over logs.

Glimmer stumbled into a clearing. A vine had wrapped around Star's back leg. The young warrior pried it off. She patted Star's mane and spoke comforting words. As the solar eclipse ended, the surroundings became clear. She mounted Star and rode into town. The creatures had dissolved into black ichor. She saw Bow riding his steed.

"At least you're okay," Glimmer said. "How's everyone else?"

"Most people awakened," Bow replied. "The others received wounds. The local healers are currently helping them."

"Alright. Nothing serious, correct?"

"I suppose."

The two friends rode out of Mystacor Village. Glimmer suspected that the curse was there to send a message. Hooves thumped against the dirt path. The horses galloped along the trail. A gust of wind rippled through Glimmer's hair. She chatted with Bow the entire time. The hours they rode together whizzed by.

As the sun glided west, Glimmer and Bow crossed an expansive field. After sunset, Gray Haven came into view. A drawbridge stretched over a moat. Guards patrolled the top of a brick wall. Torches outlined their silhouettes.

"We could book separate rooms at an inn," Glimmer said.

"Yeah," Bow replied.

In the sky, towers rose high above the town. Glimmer guessed it was Grayskull Castle. Pinpricks of light twinkled in the inky blackness. The young warrior rode Star into the city. Bow followed her.

Even at night, the cobblestone streets bustled with activity. The locals stuck to the sides of the path to make way for the visitors. Near the town center, Glimmer detected an inn and its stables. She dismounted Star and led her forward.

"Just for the night," Glimmer said.

Glimmer and Bow walked inside the building. A woman stood behind the counter. A flight of stairs led to the second floor. The two friends booked their own rooms. Then, Glimmer walked to hers and shut the door. She took off the chainmail and tunic, then slipped into bed. Within an hour, she was asleep.

Sneaking Out

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

In the morning, Glimmer and Bow left the inn. During the day, Gray Haven seemed busier - chattering locals, shouting merchants, and music. A child chased a chicken into an alley. Dogs sat by outdoor tables, begging for food. Cats wrestled with each other near the crates.

Dozens of people crowded the town square. Glimmer had assumed there would be nobles strolling around the fountain. However, there were a bunch of cobblers, farmers, and more.

Grayskull's emblem topped the fountain. It was the shape of a sun, with a diamond in the center. Glimmer and Bow made their way through the crowd. They walked under a stone arch and crossed an ornate bridge. A pair of guards stood in front of the grand doors.

"We're here to speak with the queen," Glimmer said.

The truth was that Glimmer came here for a different reason. She wanted to learn more about her parents' deaths. If possible, she could help the princess. Maybe they could search for the missing prince.

"And what do you want to discuss with her?" The tall guard asked.

"It's about Mystacor Village. The monsters attacked the town."

"Ah, you're not the first person with this report."

Glimmer straightened her spine. "Can you let us in?"

"Sure. Queen Shadow Weaver doesn't tolerate disrespect. Keep it in mind."

The guards opened the grand doors. Glimmer and Bow stepped into a vast courtyard. Servants trimmed the hedges and watered the flowers. On one side, soldiers trained together. One of them had a messy brown ponytail. Towering spires cast shadows over the ground. On the opposite side of the courtyard, soldiers shot arrows. Their targets shattered upon impact.

Soon, Glimmer and Bow entered the castle. The hallways were empty, save for patrolling guards. She expected to see nobles wandering around. Instead, she saw servants carrying baskets.

Glimmer led Bow through multiple corridors. It was a maze compared to the manors in Mystacor Village. Eventually, they reached the throne room. Several individuals talked to Shadow Weaver. The queen, despite her cold demeanor, listened to the common folk.

When Glimmer's turn came, she bowed. Then, she rose. "Your Majesty. I'm Glimmer. This is my friend, Bow."

"Your face seems familiar. The child of Angella and Micah, unless I'm mistaken," Shadow Weaver said. "What brings you here?"

"I could serve as a knight if you're okay with it. Bow could sign up, too."

Shadow Weaver steepled her fingers in front of her abdomen. "Princess Adora needs someone to protect her. The problem is that she has scared off the other knights. The half-panther girl doesn't count as one."

"Half-panther girl?"

"Adora calls her Catra. That girl is a nuisance." As Shadow Weaver spoke, there was disdain in her voice. "The two of you may serve as knights. However, you must follow the rules here. Under no circumstances will you go to forbidden areas in the castle. Do not attempt to sneak Adora out. Understand?"

"Yes."

Those rules suggested that Shadow Weaver was hiding something. Regardless, Glimmer and Bow didn't comment on them. The queen told them they could find Adora in the tallest tower. Once they finished talking, Glimmer and Bow strode into the hallway.

They proceeded through passageways. From time to time, they ascended flights of stairs. Some servants shared rumors of strange experiments in the castle dungeon. The maids mentioned human sacrifices.

A tower, bridge, and staircase later, Glimmer and Bow found the tallest spire. They went upstairs to a bedroom door. Glimmer knocked. Several minutes passed. A blonde girl answered the knock. This must be Princess Adora. The bottom of her gown brushed the polished floor.

"I'm Glimmer, your new knight," Glimmer said.

"Oh. Nice to meet you," Adora replied. "And who's your friend?"

"Bow, of course. He's a knight, too."

Adora frowned. "I thought I made it clear to Shadow Weaver that I don't need a babysitter."

"We're not going anywhere, princess."

"You'd get bored watching me in my room all day."

"Can we come in?"

Adora hesitated before stepping aside. "You may come in."

They all entered the room. Glimmer occupied a chair. Bow stood by the window. Adora seemed curious about them. The princess plopped onto the canopy bed, facing Glimmer.

Glimmer had a feeling Adora was sheltered. Staying inside the castle for years sounded isolating enough. Did Shadow Weaver

also limit Adora's interactions with visitors?

"Tell me about yourselves," Adora said.

"We came from Mystacor Village. It's a town in the mountains," Glimmer replied. "Yesterday, dark creatures attacked the village." She wasn't sure if she should describe them. The monsters were nightmarish in appearance. "They vanished after the eclipse ended."

"Did you defend the town, though?"

"Yes. I used some spells."

"How about the sword on your back?"

Glimmer unsheathed her sword. "I unleashed a flash of energy using this and my magic."

Adora glanced at the blade. "Don't you have any sword-fighting experience?"

"I do. Why are you asking? You've never touched a sword in your life, have you?"

"Shadow Weaver said it was too dangerous for me to own one." Adora sighed. "She thinks I'm a delicate flower."

Glimmer sheathed the sword. "Have you ever wondered why Shadow Weaver restricts your personal freedom?"

"She means well. As she has told me, it's for my protection. However, I want to go outside. It doesn't matter if it's just one day or a week."

Glimmer opened her mouth to speak. Instead, she pressed her lips together. Shadow Weaver had warned her against sneaking Adora out. For now, she would do whatever she could. She would get to know the princess. Maybe soon, there would be an opportunity to take Adora outside.

Adora tilted her head. "Were you going to say something?"

"I forgot what I wanted to say," Glimmer replied.

"Alright, then. I'll tell you about myself." Adora folded her gloved hands in her lap. "Obviously, I'm the Princess of Grayskull. When I was seven, my parents died. Shadow Weaver inherited the throne. I don't know what happened to my parents. Due to Shadow Weaver forbidding me from going outside, I became lonely. The servants were only there to mop floors and do other chores. The guards were boring."

Glimmer nodded as she listened. "When I came to the castle, Shadow Weaver mentioned Catra. How did you and Catra meet?"

"It was ten years ago on that night. At the time, I was nine. I was crying into my pillow. The loneliness has become too much for me to handle. I wanted a friend. As soon as the tears stopped coming, I heard a noise. It was a scratching sound. Since it was dark, I was shaking all over. I remained in bed, frozen. The scratches continued. It was like claws scraping stone. I thought it was a monster."

"How long did it last?"

Adora pointed to a wardrobe in the left corner. "See the wall behind the wardrobe? It was where the sound came from. By midnight, I started feeling annoyed. I was desperate to sleep. So, I got out of bed and stomped over there."

Glimmer smiled as she tried to imagine a younger Adora storming toward the wardrobe. The princess must have held up her nightgown while walking. Adora must have put on a brave face in that moment.

"I took a closer look at the wall and listened. I pressed my hands onto a loose stone," Adora said. "The wall gave way. The hole was pitch-black."

"Did it scare you?" Glimmer asked.

"A little. By the arch, I saw a cat on the floor. Or rather, a kitten. It was big for a kitten. Then, it transformed into a girl around my age. The revelation shocked me. I had never met a shapeshifter before. She stood up. There was uncertainty in her eyes. She seemed apprehensive. I told her she was safe. She said her name. Catra."

"How did she get into the castle?"

"Catra had been on her own for a while. She stumbled into the courtyard in panther form and slipped into a secret passage. Somewhere, she began losing her way. After what seemed like forever, she found the loose wall. Or, the hidden door. To this day, she still calls it the 'hidden door.'"

"Did Shadow Weaver know about it?"

"No. Shadow Weaver doesn't bother with secret passages." Adora toyed with her blonde strands. "The morning after, a servant found Catra sleeping in my room."

Glimmer arched her brows. "How did the servant react to Catra's presence?"

"She ran off and told Shadow Weaver about the 'strange child' in my room. Minutes later, Shadow Weaver barged in and began screeching at us. She threatened to kick Catra out. I asked her to let Catra grow up in the castle. Out of reluctance, she agreed to let Catra stay."

"Was Catra like a sister to you?"

"Yes. Sometimes, we got into arguments. Catra would accuse me of being Shadow Weaver's favorite."

Glimmer and Adora continued talking until early afternoon. The door opened, revealing a servant. The attendant said it was time for tea. Glimmer, Adora, and Bow followed her to a tearoom.

Shadow Weaver was already stirring a spoonful of sugar into her cup. The queen looked up. In the center of the table, a two-tiered stand idled. Scones, sandwiches, and small cakes filled both tiers.

Glimmer pulled out a chair for Adora. The princess sat down. Then, the knight occupied an empty seat. Bow sat next to Glimmer. A girl with a messy ponytail stepped into the room. Glimmer recognized her from the courtyard.

"Catra! It is improper to show up all sweaty and covered in dirt!" Shadow Weaver spat.

"What did you expect? The servants didn't give me time to prepare," Catra said. "I was practicing with those soldiers!"

Shadow Weaver expelled an audible sigh. "You should at least have the decency to clean yourself up."

"You know what? I didn't want to join you anyway." Catra backed out of the room. "You're a piece of work."

"Depart from our presence, you ungrateful brat!"

Catra stormed off. Glimmer took a small sandwich and began nibbling on it. Were things always tense between Shadow Weaver and Catra? If so, how often did they have shouting matches? Glimmer glanced at Adora, who was keeping her head down.

Shadow Weaver cleared her throat. "Adora, quit slouching. It is unbecoming. It is shameful behavior for a princess."

"Sorry, Shadow Weaver," Adora murmured.

"Good girl. You should always obey me."

Glimmer and Bow exchanged glances. She turned her attention to Adora. Shadow Weaver was a controlling woman. How did Adora tolerate that?

"Adora, I will meet with foreign diplomats in a neighboring kingdom. After a week, I'll return home. I don't want to hear a report of you sneaking out in the meantime," Shadow Weaver said.

"I'll stay inside and be the good little princess," Adora replied.

"You better stick to your word. And don't pout."

"Oh. Sorry again." Adora wore a forced smile. "I'll try to smile more."

"While I'm gone, you will take a daily dose of the potion in your drinks. It'll help with your delusions and hysteria."

Glimmer bit into a scone as she observed the conversation. The queen was a horrible person, as usual. Adora seemed to accept whatever Shadow Weaver told her. Would the potion have adverse effects?

Once everyone finished sipping tea and eating snacks, they left the room. Shadow Weaver walked out of the castle. A group of guards accompanied her. Glimmer, Adora, and Bow returned to the blonde's room.

"Is there something you enjoy doing?" Glimmer asked.

"Writing in my journal, I guess." Adora approached an easel. "I also paint. I read books."

"What books do you read the most?"

"The one with the legendary heroine." Adora grabbed a wooden palette and a paintbrush. "She had quite the adventure."

"True."

"Anyway, did you ever have dreams about the tale?"

Glimmer shrugged. "Maybe? Most of the time, I don't remember my dreams."

Adora moved the paintbrush along the blank paper. "Mine is a recurring one. It was jumbled, although part of it is clear. In the nightmare, I saw monsters roaming the kingdom. Dark, churning clouds obscured the sky. Toward the end, a creature with green eyes rampaged through a battlefield. It crushed many soldiers."

"That is quite the nightmare."

"Yeah. I wonder if it's telling me something."

"So..." Glimmer stepped closer. "Did Shadow Weaver ever mention your parents?"

Adora shook her head. "Shadow Weaver said she didn't like talking about them."

Bow crossed his arms. "Adora, she could be lying to you. Glimmer and I believe she usurped your parents. You have a missing brother."

Adora's hands halted. "It can't be true. And the only sibling I have is Catra. We're not related by blood. Shadow Weaver is the closest I have to a mother. Speaking of usurping, she wouldn't take power by force. She wouldn't harm Grayskull."

Glimmer scoffed. "The kingdom is suffering under Shadow Weaver's rule! You're the Princess of Grayskull. Shouldn't you be concerned? Shadow Weaver is friends with the Horde Clan. A group of ruthless bandits. They ruin people's lives." She watched Adora draw some silhouettes on the canvas. "Do you ever fear what Shadow Weaver could do to you? She cursed people in the past. Some individuals died from the spell."

"Glimmer, I'm not scared. I'm fine." Adora dropped the palette and paintbrushes onto her desk. "Did you sign up to be a knight just to lecture me about Shadow Weaver?"

"You want the truth? Here it is. I was here to figure out how my parents died. They led an uprising four years ago. The resistance fell apart. Shadow Weaver had ties to the Horde Clan. Are you aware of that?"

Adora narrowed her eyes. "Weren't they trying to make Grayskull better?"

Glimmer jammed her fists against her hips. "You heard what I said. Those bandits are up to no good. Shadow Weaver is a tyrannical ruler. Name one good thing she has done for the kingdom."

"I... I don't think I can." Adora rubbed her arms. "The potion must have messed with my memories."

Glimmer figured Adora would mention the potion. Shadow Weaver would do anything to keep the princess in line. There had to be something Glimmer could do. She could snoop around in forbidden parts of the castle. Such an action would draw suspicion. For all she knew, they could be loyal to Shadow Weaver.

"Has Shadow Weaver told you that some rooms in the castle were off-limits?" Glimmer asked.

"Yes," Adora said.

"Which ones?"

"The royal chamber. My parents once slept there. It's currently Shadow Weaver's bedroom. There's also the dungeon."

"Let's start with the bedroom."

After an hour of wandering through hallways and secret passages, Adora and Glimmer entered Shadow Weaver's room. It was as spacious as she remembered. The decorations, however, were ominous. There were gargoyle statues in each corner.

On one side of the chamber, dozens of papers and tomes cluttered a desk. Potions lined the shelves. Adora could see a cauldron by the nightstand. On the opposite side, there was a wooden trunk.

"Where do we start?" Adora whispered.

"I don't know," Glimmer replied.

"You could search the desk. I'll look through the trunk."

They proceeded to check the papers and the trunk. Adora rummaged through the items inside the chest. She retrieved a box and a journal. The princess opened the book and began reading.

Adora scrutinized the entries. Apparently, the writer was someone named Marlena. The woman's husband was Randor. The couple had two children - a boy and a girl.

The latest entry made Adora pause. She saw her name on it. The boy, Adam, was her twin. She continued reading. Marlena had written about Shadow Weaver. The last paragraph carried a sense of urgency.

Adora turned the page. Many papers that followed were blank. She shut the journal. Shadow Weaver had lied to her for years. The princess opened the box. Tons of envelopes took up space. Many were meant for Adora and her brother.

Adora pored over the letters. As sweet as they were, none offered a clue regarding Adam's whereabouts. She stashed them into the box and closed it. Footsteps approached. She rose to her height and turned around.

"I found information on the potion. It can make someone forget things," Glimmer said. She showed Adora a paper.

Adora read the list of adverse effects. Whenever she drank the potion, her mind would become foggy. There had been occasional

bouts of dizziness. Other symptoms were headaches and sleeplessness.

"That's what Shadow Weaver has been giving me?" Adora asked.

"I suppose," Glimmer said. "Anyway, I gathered some notes regarding my parents. Mainly my mother. There were unfinished letters. In them, I discovered clues. The Horde Clan fought against the uprising. Their leader, Hordak, led the attack. Their sorcerers killed my father. The ones without magic distracted my mother. They prevented her from seeing what happened to my father. She lost her life, too."

"Who were you with at the time?"

"My aunt Castaspella."

Adora thought of her brother. "Speaking of family, has anyone known where my brother went? Is he alive or dead? How did we get separated?"

Glimmer glanced at the desk, then at Adora. "There weren't any written records of him."

"A journal mentioned Adam." Adora retrieved the book. She flipped the pages and pointed to an entry. "Here. Read it."

They pored over the words. A clicking noise in the door garnered their attention. Someone was coming. Did Shadow Weaver trust a few servants to access this room? Adora and Glimmer dove behind a sofa. A guard entered the room, inspecting the chamber.

Adora held her breath. Heart thrashing against her ribs, she peeked out from her hiding spot. She hoped he would consider it a false alarm. Her gaze swept across the wall to the tapestry. It concealed a hidden door they used to enter this room.

They could make a run for it. Adora watched the guard again. He hadn't looked in their direction yet. She turned her attention to Glimmer. The knight's hands glowed with magic. Footsteps

advanced. Within seconds, Glimmer unleashed a rune. Its magic rendered the guard unconscious.

"We gotta go," Glimmer whispered. "More of them could come."

They raced through the hidden door. Glimmer grabbed Adora's trembling hand. Both women rounded every corner and picked up the pace. At some point, a rat skittered over Adora's feet. The sensation startled her. It wasn't the rodents that scared her. Her mind was on the close call in Shadow Weaver's room. If the guard had seen them, he would have reported them to Shadow Weaver.

They made their way to Adora's bedroom. Heaving a sigh of relief, she sat on the bed. If Shadow Weaver had been present... Adora shuddered at the notion. It wasn't the first time she snuck in there. A memory of Shadow Weaver's shout surfaced. The queen had been furious to see her and Catra snooping around.

"Adora, are you alright? Your face is pale," Glimmer said.

Adora let out a nervous chuckle. "Yeah. It was risky. Shadow Weaver would be angry to know about it. The last time I was in there, she caught me. I still remember the tone in her voice as she lectured me."

Bow sat in the chair. He wore a concerned expression. "Adora, did Shadow Weaver make you feel like you had to walk on eggshells?"

Adora tugged at the fabric of her long skirt. "She did. I knew what she would do if I stepped out of line. When it came to Catra, the abuse was more physical."

Glimmer's eyes darkened with anger for a moment. "Shadow Weaver has been cruel to you. I'm not letting her get away with it. You deserve better." She placed a hand on Adora's knee. "We could leave."

Adora shrugged. "Shadow Weaver would hate it if I'm gone."

"I won't let anything happen to you. You're safe with me."

"You would protect me from her?"

"Of course."

Night surrounded the land as the trio prepared themselves to sneak out. Adora changed into a different outfit. A red tunic with elbow-length bell sleeves and white undersleeves. A pair of gray trousers tucked into leather boots. She completed the outfit with a long cloak.

"Ready to go?" Glimmer asked.

"Yes," Adora said.

Adora followed Glimmer and Bow into the dark passageway. The knight conjured a light orb. Its glow illuminated the damp stone wall. The group descended the steps. They moved through the narrow tunnel.

Adora swore she could feel something brush her shoulder. It could be a cobweb or an insect. It could be disembodied fingers. Perhaps it was her imagination.

"We're getting somewhere," Glimmer whispered. "See the door ahead of us?"

Adora peeked at the door. "I see it."

They hurried forward. Bow twisted the knob and opened the door. Adora and Glimmer proceeded into an adjacent corridor. More stairs, corners, and tunnels. Sooner or later, a guard could notice their absence. Subtle voices drifted into the cold air.

They crept into the dungeon. The voices became louder. A pained wail pierced the silence. Adora, Glimmer, and Bow froze. What was going on? The unseen strangers began chanting. Glimmer unsheathed her sword.

The sound led them to a slightly open door. They peered inside. A group of cloaked individuals surrounded an altar. Adora could see

someone struggling to break free. The leader of the coven plunged a dagger into the victim's abdomen. Blood poured down the altar.

Adora, Glimmer, and Bow backed away. She felt sick to her stomach. Someone approached the door from inside. Glimmer held up an arm in front of Adora, shielding her.

"Someone was watching us," a cold voice said.

Glimmer took Adora's hand and led her away. Bow took out an arrow. Adora expected the threat to lunge at them. A woman emerged from the room, hands gleaming with magic.

"How much did you see of the ritual?" The woman demanded. She hurled lightning bolts at the group.

"Run!" Bow shrieked.

Glimmer shot a fireball at the woman. She escorted Adora and Bow through the dungeon. They ran as fast as their legs could carry them. Once they realized they'd successfully outran the woman, they slowed. However, they remained on high alert. Soon, they found the exit and stepped into the night air. More guards patrolled the courtyard.

Chapter End Notes

Comments / Kudos appreciated 🥲

Close Calls

Chapter Notes

I may post twice a week, so expect two updates each week.

From this chapter on, there would be POVs other than just Adora's and Glimmer's.

After evading the guards, Adora and her companions rushed to Gray Haven. The dangerous encounter in the dungeon had shaken her. She was glad Glimmer was there to protect her. The trio strode to the stables by an inn.

Glimmer and Bow began debating where they could sleep tonight. The locals made way for a group of soldiers. Catra led the way, hand resting on her hilt. The brunette noticed Adora and closed the distance between them.

"Where are they taking you, princess?" Catra asked.

"We haven't decided on a destination," Adora replied. "You don't have to stay with Shadow Weaver."

"Shadow Weaver will be upset over you leaving the castle. Let's go back." Catra gripped Adora's wrist. "You heard me."

Glimmer unsheathed her sword. "Release Adora's wrist."

Catra drew her weapon. "Shadow Weaver's orders."

"After how she treated you and Adora, you're staying in the castle? Are you serious?"

"Why does my choice matter to you?" Catra invaded Glimmer's personal space. Her spine straightened. "Do you think you can

take on me? I'm a few inches taller. I can transform into a panther."

"Heh. I've fought scarier things than a mere shapeshifter. I have magical powers, and I can use the sword."

Catra snickered as she held up her hands. "Oh, no, I'm scared!" Her voice was mocking as she spoke. Then, she exhaled. "On a serious note, you don't intimidate me. You'd scream at my panther form. You seem the type of person to do so."

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Oh, please. At Mystacor Academy, I killed dark creatures. It was pitch-black in the building. I didn't run away screaming!"

The two women began exchanging blows. They parried each other's swords. Both blades clanged together, the warriors struggling to gain the upper hand. Glimmer redirected Catra's weapon to the right. The knight targeted the opening.

Taken by surprise, Catra staggered backward and fell. The brunette's sword slid across the cobblestone street. Catra rolled to her front. She transformed into a panther, growling. She lunged at Glimmer.

Glimmer dodged the attack. Adora watched the rest of the fight play out. The element of surprise was on Glimmer's side. She defeated Catra. The brunette reverted to her human form and stormed off. Glimmer dusted herself off and approached a horse in the stables. Adora and Bow followed her.

"Are you hurt?" Adora asked. "The scuffle seemed intense."

"It's nothing major," Glimmer said. "There are some light scratches here and there. Otherwise, nothing to worry about."

"I know how Catra can be." Adora glanced at the horses. "Are we leaving Gray Haven?"

"Yes."

Bow mounted his steed. He unfurled a map in his hands. "If we reach the nearest village before midnight, we could find an inn. I hope we don't run into monsters on the way there."

Glimmer climbed onto her horse. "By the way, our horses are Star and Artemis. You can sit behind me if you want."

Adora shrugged. "I've never ridden a horse before."

Glimmer extended a hand. "I can help you up."

Adora took Glimmer's hand. After a few minutes of trying, she mounted Star. The trio rode out of Gray Haven. The moon rose higher into the sky. Adora peeked at Bow, who was scrutinizing the map. His free hand gripped the reins. She stared at the sky. The coolness of night enveloped her.

Adora's gaze swept over her shoulder. Gray Haven and the castle faded out of view. Now, they were mere silhouettes against the sky. There was no turning back.

It was Adora's first time outside the castle. She never thought this day would come. And the fact that she went on an adventure with her knight... Last year, if anyone had told her a knight would sneak her out of the castle, she would laugh. This was exciting. A thought occurred to her. What if she enjoyed the outside world too much to return?

An hour before midnight, Adora and her companions arrived in a village. Houses and shops sat by the river. A few guards patrolled the town. The trio dismounted the horses. They led Star and Artemis to the stables.

Adora, Glimmer, and Bow entered an inn. They ordered a room for three people. The innkeeper handed them a key. Their room was on the second floor. Once inside the bedroom, the group dropped their bags and gear by the window. Glimmer removed her chainmail and tunic, revealing an undershirt.

"Two beds?" Glimmer asked. She gestured at the beds.

"Is anyone sleeping on the floor? I'm not doing it," Adora said.

Bow chose the bed near the dated dresser. Adora and Glimmer would sleep by the window. Raindrops drummed the window as the trio reclined. Adora rolled to her side, looking into Glimmer's eyes. She was aware of the proximity. However, she didn't mind.

Moonlight trickled into the room. Adora noticed the subtle tone on Glimmer's upper arm. It made her wonder if it was from the knight's training. Glimmer's hair swept over part of her face.

Try as she might, Adora couldn't sleep. She tossed back and forth. As happy as she was to explore Grayskull, she feared what Shadow Weaver could do. Would the wicked queen have someone chase her? What would Shadow Weaver do to Catra? Adora slapped her palms over her face. A firm, soft hand wrapped around her wrist. Her arms dropped to her sides.

"Adora..." Glimmer whispered.

Adora made eye contact. "Am I keeping you up?"

"No. I was awake the whole time."

"Sorry. I'm just nervous." Adora pulled the blanket to her chin. "Shadow Weaver would do anything to take me back to the castle. I couldn't convince Catra to come with us."

"Shadow Weaver won't snatch you away. I'll make sure of it."

"You promise?"

"Absolutely."

Adora's eyes fluttered shut. Heaviness blanketed her body, and her breaths slowed. She listened to Glimmer's snoring. There was something reassuring about the knight's presence. In some way, it made her think everything would be alright. She slipped into the world of dreams...

Adora was running through the forest. All she saw were miles of trees. Twisted faces materialized on them. Leaves crunched under her feet. Twigs snapped. The bushes rustled. A growl penetrated the woods. A roar came soon after.

The fog obscured every path, churning. Shadows emerged, clawed hands reaching for Adora. She glimpsed their distorted features. Their fangs glinted in the darkness.

Whispers hissed into Adora's ears. Tendrils snaked around her legs, climbing up to her chest. Panic rose within her as she attempted to break free. She blinked. She found herself sitting on a chair inside the castle's living room.

Only the area around Adora's seat was lit. Thick shadows concealed everything else. She could feel goosebumps pebbling on her skin. How did she wind up here? Wasn't she traveling with her companions? She swore she could see her breath in front of her.

Wait... Adora examined her clothes. Why was she wearing a nightshirt and a pair of leggings? Where was the lace-lined nightgown? The blonde felt different as well. The shadows swirled and morphed. They stretched high above Adora until Shadow Weaver's shape took form.

"Hello, my dear," Shadow Weaver said.

"H-Hello," Adora replied, shaking.

"Why are you here, Princess Adora?"

"Can you explain it to me?"

"You disobeyed me. I took you in when your parents died. I did whatever I could to ensure your safety. And this is how you repay me?"

Adora flinched at the harsh words. Her fingers dug into her leggings. She braced herself for the coming punishment. However,

the wicked queen didn't slap her. The older woman stood there. Adora held back tears that threatened to spill.

Shadow Weaver placed an icy palm on Adora's shoulder. "I allowed you to have a sister. Catra dragged you down often. Do you know how special you are? Someday, you'll be a great queen. Still, you better listen. And you should. You're too naive to know what you want. I know what is best for you."

"I'm sorry, Shadow Weaver," Adora said.

"Good girl. It will be a shame if you continue breaking the rules."

Flashes of images surfaced. No, they were memories. Adora had either suppressed or forgotten them. A scream came from her parents' room. A young boy's eyes widened. His mouth moved, but no words came out. The tear-filled nights followed.

Then, the moment Adora met Catra at nine years old. Everything blurred into one single entity. A creature with green eyes glowered at her. Something - or someone - grabbed her neck from behind.

Adora jolted awake, a shout trapped inside her throat. Blackness met her eyes. The eerie sensation of the hand on her neck lingered. The fight-or-flight response kicked in. Her entire body remained frozen. Her mind took a minute to catch up. Thunder boomed in the distance, startling her. It reminded her of her childhood when she couldn't sleep during stormy nights. Each flash of lightning had elongated the shadows in her room.

Adora ran her fingers through her hair. Her fingertips met the braids. A bolt of lightning flooded the room in a bright light. Another crack of thunder spiked her adrenaline. She inhaled deeply. She shouldn't be scared.

Adora slipped out of bed and stepped toward the window. White zig-zags streaked across the starless sky. It revealed the river and a cluster of buildings. It could be a few hours left until sunrise. Yawning, she returned to bed.

Glimmer tapped her ankles against Star's sides, urging the horse forward. It had been an hour since the trio left the village. The morning sunlight warmed her face and neck. Like last night, Adora sat behind her. The blonde wrapped her arms around Glimmer's waist.

"I think we're going to the correct destination," Bow said. He folded the map and stashed it into the saddlebag.

Glimmer glanced at the dirt trail. The breeze blew through Star's mane. In the distance, mountain peaks rose into the sky. Star and Artemis trotted faster. Adora rested her chin on Glimmer's shoulder. The trio proceeded even when monsters attacked.

Glimmer and Bow made short work of the creatures. They made their way to the eastern province. The path led them away from the grassy fields. The hours whizzed by before they knew it.

They rode into a winding ravine. Trees dotted the cliffs. Figures slipped between them. Glimmer unsheathed her sword. Would the group encounter more monsters? The hoofbeats halted. Someone barked orders.

Several bandits emerged from their hiding spots. Some wielded spiky sickles. Others brandished either daggers or other weapons. Glimmer recognized the Horde Clan's emblem on their capes.

Three jumped down, aiming for the trio. One of the bandits knocked Glimmer to the ground. Pain flooded her spine from the fall. Gritting her teeth, she brought up her sword to shield herself. The other two grabbed Adora.

Adora begged the bandits to release her. Glimmer shoved her attacker off. Bow shot arrows at their enemies. Glimmer parried her foes' weapons. Clashes of steel rang through the air.

Glimmer unleashed spells at the bandits, rendering them unconscious. The others still held Adora, pointing a sickle at her throat. Glimmer tightened her grip on the sword. Her knuckles blanched.

"Let her go," Glimmer said.

"If you drop the sword, we'll release the girl," the female bandit with dreadlocks said.

"This better not be a trick." Glimmer placed the sword on the ground. "Get your mitts off of Adora. Now."

The other bandit with messy blonde hair glanced at the female. "Lonnie, she seems serious."

Lonnie rolled her eyes. "We're following Hordak's orders, Kyle!"

Glimmer scowled. "Are you going to waste our time? Adora is the Princess of Grayskull. You're trying to abduct her."

"I don't care if she's the princess!"

"Well, Hordak is okay with Shadow Weaver being an usurper. You're living under her tyrannical reign. How can you be okay with that?"

"They're bringing order to Grayskull."

Glimmer snorted. "The deaths of innocent people? You call it order?"

Adora struggled against Lonnie's grip. "My parents were the true rulers of the land. Now they're gone. And my brother is missing!"

Lonnie shoved Adora to the ground. "Enough!"

Adora yelped. She lifted an arm to shield herself. Glimmer retrieved the sword and charged at Lonnie. The knight blocked blows left and right. She pushed Lonnie closer to the river. Her enemy fell into the water.

"And don't touch Adora!" Glimmer spat.

Lonnie ordered the bandits to retreat. Once they were gone, Glimmer helped Adora up. She examined the blonde's body for

wounds. There were streaks of dirt and some scratches. Adora was trembling.

"I thought they would kill me," Adora said. "You saved my life."

"It's what knights do," Glimmer replied. "I won't let the Horde Clan kill you."

"Where are we going, exactly?"

"Alwyn Village. It's close to a vast forest."

"Oh. Does the village have an inn?"

"It could."

Glimmer and Adora climbed onto Star's back. The horse began trotting. Bow and his steed followed them. A journey through a forest later, the group approached a village. Something was off about the town. Glimmer peeked at the buildings. Every door and window were left ajar. The sun dipped into the horizon. A wind howled.

"No one told us Alwyn Village got abandoned," Bow said.

"Remember what happened in Mystacor Village?" Glimmer replied. She narrowed her eyes. "Stay alert. We don't know what's here. The former residents must have fled after encountering those creatures."

"Do you think they could be here?"

A faint growl halted their conversation. Glimmer drew the sword and dismounted Star. The knight glimpsed a silhouette lurking in the alley. Its gaze studied the trio. She straightened her spine. The creature emitted an unnatural shriek. More of them advanced. They flashed their claws.

"What are they?" Adora exclaimed.

The beasts lunged at Glimmer and Bow. The knight slashed them with her sword. Bow shot multiple arrows, landing several hits. Star and Artemis neighed. The former reared back as if panicking. Adora fell off the horse.

Both horses bolted back and forth in an attempt to dodge the beasts. Adora forced herself up, groaning. The monsters charged at her. Some landed a hit. Again, she fell. Glimmer swung the sword horizontally, slicing multiple creatures at once. She held them off and shielded Adora. She conjured a fireball, prompting the beasts to recoil. They made strange noises that sounded like distorted shouts.

Apparently, those things had an aversion to fire. Not just sunlight. Glimmer barraged them with fireballs. One by one, the beasts fled. Within minutes, Star and Artemis calmed down. Adora rose to her height, clutching her wounded side.

"Are you alright?" Glimmer asked. She summoned an illumination spell. She noticed the blood on Adora's waist. "You're bleeding."

"How bad is it?" Adora asked, staggering.

"I'm not sure. We have brought the supplies in case of an injury."

Bow pulled the bandages from Artemis' saddlebag. He walked over to Adora and began tending to the injury. Glimmer checked the village for more threats. However, she didn't see anything suspicious. As a precaution, she cast a fire spell on the torches. It could do for now. She returned to Adora and Bow. The princess was leaning on the archer. Did the injury worsen?

The trio entered the nearest house. Cobwebs hung from the ceiling. A thick layer of dust blanketed every surface. Glimmer swore she saw insects lurking in a dark corner. This wasn't the ideal place to spend the night. She conjured a light orb and allowed its glow to fill the room. Adora leaned against the wall. Her breathing was heavy, and she looked pale.

"She doesn't look good," Bow said.

"Was there something in those monsters' claws?" Glimmer asked.

"Perhaps. We've got to find another town. Alwyn Village doesn't have anyone who could help."

"So, we search for another one? We don't know if the next town also got attacked like this one." Glimmer sat next to Adora and cradled her in her arms. "Adora, stay awake."

"Let's go," Bow said.

They carried Adora outside and placed her on Star's back. Glimmer mounted the horse. She held Adora with her free hand. Bow led them out of Alwyn Village. The entire time the horses were trotting, Glimmer listened to Adora's breaths.

Was there an unseen injury? Did the dark beasts infect the princess? The trees swayed in the wind. The forest ceiling blocked out the moonlight. Glimmer thought each breath Adora took would be her last. She could only hope they would find someone as soon as possible.

A series of huts and treehouses came into view. Could this be a fairy village? Pixies flitted over patches of flowers. Water sylphs danced above a pond. Elves patrolled the outskirts of town. A woman with platinum blonde hair approached the trio.

"Miss, do you know of any healers?" Bow asked. "Or at least, healing potions? Is there another village nearby?"

"There aren't many other than Plumeria Woods and Alwyn Village," the woman said. "I'm Perfuma. What are your names?"

"I'm Bow. My friends are Adora and Glimmer. A monster attacked Adora. It must have affected her. It could be an unseen injury or an infection."

There was concern etched into Perfuma's features. "I'll see what I can do. I can make a potion from healing plants. Follow me."

Perfuma led them to a cottage. Once inside, Glimmer and Bow helped Adora recline on a bed. Perfuma gathered the herbs and began making a potion. Glimmer sat next to Adora, stroking her hair. There was a mixture of fear and pain in Adora's eyes.

"Perfuma's going to help you," Glimmer said. "Everything will be alright, I promise."

"I hope you're right," Adora whispered.

Within a half hour, Perfuma carried the vial to the bed. Glimmer helped Adora sit up. She took the potion and pressed it against Adora's lips. The blonde sipped the red liquid. Slowly, color returned to Adora's face and lips. Still, she seemed tired. She rested her head on the pillow.

"Usually, the humans don't come to our home," Perfuma said. "Some sorcerers did, though."

Glimmer made eye contact. "Which sorcerer?"

"She's a woman from the Horde Clan. The woman hasn't told us her name. She cursed the forest because we refused to acknowledge Shadow Weaver as the Queen of Grayskull."

"What are the effects of the curse?"

"We've seen vines climb up trees so far. They emit a poisonous vapor."

"Is there anything else?"

"The plants age quicker. Some fairies have become sick. None of it happened before."

Glimmer nodded. "Is there any way we could break the curse?"

Perfuma fiddled with her curls. "I've tried every potion. None of them worked. The witch's magic was too strong. We'll talk more

tomorrow. I need to check on the fairies and elves." She left the cottage.

Glimmer glanced down at a sleeping Adora. The princess seemed vulnerable. Adora had a rough day. The Horde Clan had ambushed the trio. Some monsters had tried to kill Adora. Glimmer scrutinized the bed. It could fit two people. This begged the question. Where would Bow sleep? Would Glimmer accidentally disturb Adora while lying down?

Glimmer turned her attention to Bow. "Would you be okay sleeping on the floor?"

"Yes," Bow said.

"I'll sleep next to Adora." Glimmer reclined.

Catra figured Shadow Weaver would return to the castle early. As she expected, the queen was furious over Adora's absence. She occupied a chair in Shadow Weaver's office. The older woman ranted and raved about the recent events. At some point, she shoved the papers off the desk.

"Of course, the 'knight' had to be the daughter of Micah and Angella!" Shadow Weaver spat. "Her parents once defied my rule! The apple doesn't fall far from the tree."

"I could track them down," Catra said.

"If they discovered the truth, they'll tell the rest of the kingdom. And they'll try to dethrone me!" Shadow Weaver massaged her temples. "I don't trust you to bring back the princess."

"I could follow their scent using my panther senses."

"Oh, that again? A location spell could reveal Adora's location faster."

Catra sighed. "All you do is waste time on paperwork."

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes. "I'm the queen. You can't expect me to do whatever I want. Someone has to run the kingdom."

"You know what?" Catra shot up. "Maybe Adora shouldn't come back after all. All you did was play favorites and yell at us."

"I raised you girls to be strong."

"You're excusing your cruelty as usual. It's a wonder most people in the kingdom let you rule."

"Leave."

Catra crossed her arms. "Done with me already? It's not surprising. I was-"

"I said, go!"

"Gladly!"

Catra stormed into the hallway. She gathered her clothes, stashed them into a bag, and left the castle. Was there anyone else she could go to? She had lost her family at a young age. A suppressed memory threatened to rear its ugly head. An image managed to slip through. The stench of fire came out of nowhere.

"Catra, run!"

Catra shook her head. The stench faded away, along with the image. She gripped her forearm and hastened her pace. Fortunately, the streets of Gray Haven were peaceful. There wouldn't be a chance of bumping into someone. She made her way out of Gray Haven. There was no one in the vicinity. She transformed into her panther form. A whiff of a familiar scent wafted into her nose. *Adora and her friends.* Catra began running.

The Cursed Forest

Glimmer, Adora, and Bow walked with Perfuma as they discussed the curse. The morning sunlight emphasized the colors of the greenery. Glimmer held Adora's hand. Adora had a good night's sleep despite last night's scare. The princess watched the fairies. Somehow, the pixies fascinated Adora. Sure, they were interesting to observe. But the group was here for a different reason. A thorny vine snaked around Perfuma's ankle.

"The curse is getting worse," Perfuma said. She attempted to yank her foot away. The vine held on. "A little help here?"

Glimmer removed the vine. "Here you go."

The tendril emitted a stomach-churning stench. Glimmer released it. The knight covered her nose. Bile climbed up her throat. Its smell reminded her of rotting corpses. A translucent vapor appeared. The group instinctively backed away.

"That's the poisonous vapor. Be careful," Perfuma said.

"We'll keep it in mind," Glimmer said.

They followed the vines to the outskirts of town. A trail awaited them. Piles of leaves idled on the ground. Glimmer saw a bulb in the center of each pile. The knight took out her sword. She had no idea what they were. Were they regular plants? Or were they plant monsters?

Upon closer inspection, Glimmer saw that they had sharp teeth. One of them suddenly lunged at her. She jumped back. The other plant monsters joined.

"I love and honor all plants. However, those are part of the curse!" Perfuma exclaimed.

"Stand behind me," Glimmer said.

Glimmer fought the plant monsters. Each strike brought them to the ground. Within minutes, they were no more. The knight beckoned the group into the forest. The trail twisted and turned. They avoided the vines and poisonous vapor.

"What do you expect to find at the end?" Bow asked. "Isn't it dangerous out here?"

"We're helping Perfuma save Plumeria Woods," Glimmer said.

"At the risk of inhaling the toxic fumes?"

Adora cleared her throat. "I don't want to get sick again. Last night, I thought I would die."

Glimmer approached a bridge. On the opposite end, a giant tree rose above the forest. The knight could see an opening in the bark. More vines snaked around the tree. There was a heap of them below the bridge.

Glimmer planted a foot on the overpass. It creaked beneath her boot. How old was it? Had anyone ever maintained it? Adora and the others stepped closer.

"The bridge has been around for years. Perhaps a century, even," Perfuma said. "I hope it holds."

"How about one person crosses it at a time?" Glimmer suggested.

Bow shot a worried glance. "Has anyone heard of bridge safety?"

Adora furrowed her brows. "Falling into the heap of vines would be unpleasant."

Perfuma stepped onto the bridge. "I'll go first." She made her way to the halfway point. "Plumeria Sanctuary flows with unlimited magic. A type of magic reserved for forest-dwellers like me. Fairies, elves, you name it. It gives life to the woods. If a curse infects it, well, it'll end horribly. We will lose our powers. The healing plants will wither and die." She reached the other side.

"The rest of Plumeria Woods will follow. Our home will lose its beauty."

The others crossed the overpass. They entered the tree. Glimmer took in the surroundings. Greenery hung from platforms. Vines of the same color stretched along the wooden walls. There were some ladders and stairs.

"It's the sanctuary?" Glimmer asked.

"Of course. It has many rooms. My forest friends have been avoiding the sanctuary after dealing with monsters," Perfuma explained.

Glimmer peeked at the thick webs in holes. "What sorts of monsters?"

"Oversized insects, scary versions of venus flytraps, and others."

The group proceeded toward a ladder. They climbed it. Judging by Perfuma's description of the inhabitants, Glimmer was sure they'd encounter something scary soon. The knight glanced at Adora, who seemed unsettled.

They followed Bow and Perfuma up a slight slope. The presence of evil in the sanctuary was palpable. It felt as though something was anticipating their arrival.

"This is spooky," Adora commented.

"Still, we're not backing out." Glimmer's fingers wrapped around her hilt. "We'll break the curse, one way or another."

"As long as we make it out alive, yeah."

Several ledge jumps later, they discovered a door. It was shaped like a circle. Glimmer searched the barrier for a knob. The knight applied pressure to the door. She felt it budge. At first, she tried to push it forward. Then, she nudged the barrier to the side.

It rolled away, unveiling a corridor. There was more than one door. A plant monster emerged from a pile of leaves, baring its teeth.

Bow shot an arrow at the creature. It hissed as it lunged at him. Glimmer blocked the attack with an air spell. She swung her sword and connected. The monster dissolved into dark ichor. The wooden bars on the left door vanished.

"There could be more the deeper we go," Perfuma said.

"I bet there would be," Adora replied.

Glimmer opened the door a crack and peered into the adjacent room. On the other side, something could be lurking in wait. Adora, Bow, and Perfuma fell into step behind the knight.

"Did you see anything?" Adora asked.

"No. Keep your eyes peeled, though," Glimmer said. She pushed the door into the wall.

A staircase spiraled into the darkness. Everyone descended the steps. It led them deeper. Glimmer's light spell penetrated the blackness. The knight and her companions reached the bottom. The temperature dropped.

Glimmer glimpsed a silhouette in the corner. Adora gripped her hand. The figure floated closer, carrying a scimitar. The light revealed its skull. It let out a high-pitched shriek. Glimmer and her companions flinched at the sound.

"Never mind what I said before. I believe this is what scared off my friends," Perfuma said.

"I'd run in the other direction if I saw this, too," Adora said.

The wraith levitated upward, lifting its sword arm. It swooped down, charging at Glimmer. In an instant, she blocked the blow. She parried its scimitar.

Bow unleashed arrows at the phantom. Unnatural shrieks echoed off the walls. Glimmer sidestepped, redirected her enemy's scimitar, and plunged the blade into its chest. The skeletal apparition collapsed to the ground.

"Is it faking?" Adora asked.

"One way to find out," Glimmer said. Her foot nudged the skeleton's skull.

A shadowy mist surged into the phantom. It ascended toward the ceiling, eyes glowing red. Eerie whispers drifted into Glimmer's ears. A chill ran up and down her spine. Despite the unease, she stood her ground.

"Adora!" A familiar voice exclaimed.

It sounded like Shadow Weaver. The wicked queen wasn't here. Was she using magic to speak through the skeleton? Glimmer positioned her sword so that it was blocking her body.

"Princess Adora, your rebellion will end," Shadow Weaver said. "You must come home. You aren't ready for the real world. Those people won't protect you the way I do."

Adora hugged herself, whimpering. She squeezed her eyes shut. The skeleton approached her. She shrunk away. Again, Shadow Weaver spoke.

The skeletal hand brushed Adora's cheek. "How much longer will you resist me? Your disobedience is shameful. They'll never understand you. Your so-called friends must find it tiring to let a sheltered princess tag along."

"Leave us alone. Glimmer and Bow are my true friends. They care about me."

"Why should you trust them? They'll dispose of you once they finish their little adventure."

Glimmer stood in front of Adora, glowering into the phantom's eyes. "Shadow Weaver, I'm not using her. And neither is Bow. We're keeping Adora safe. If you touch her, there will be hell to pay."

The phantom's scimitar sliced the air. Glimmer parried the weapon. An arrow glided through the air and plunged into the apparition. The shadowy mist morphed into dark tendrils. The black tentacles snaked around the group's bodies.

"Darkness will not overcome light!" Glimmer shouted.

"Shadow Weaver, you won't keep the throne forever," Adora said. "I will find my brother. There will be an uprising. We'll rise up and take back Grayskull. As for Horde Prime? We won't let your sorcerers release him."

Bow glared at the phantom. "Shadow Weaver, nothing you do will hinder us."

Perfuma narrowed her eyes. "Plumeria Woods will not succumb to the curse. We'll make sure of it!"

Glimmer bombarded the phantom with her magic. "Shadow Weaver, Grayskull isn't your kingdom! It's Adora's! She will be queen someday!"

The apparition shattered. A dark specter emerged, hissing at the group before vanishing. The tendrils and black mist disappeared. Glimmer sheathed the sword. Adora grabbed Glimmer's hands. The princess wore a shaky smile.

"She left," Adora said. "I was so terrified."

"I know she frightened you. On a positive note, you stood up to Shadow Weaver," Glimmer said.

"You used magic on her to protect us. I don't have any powers. Shadow Weaver would have hurt me."

"Still, you sounded confident when you mentioned an uprising."

Adora chuckled. "I was nervous at the moment. You're so brave."

Glimmer led the others across the room. "Perfuma, don't you have a map of this place?"

Perfuma caught up to Glimmer. "Perhaps I could guide the group."

Shadow Weaver glowered at the crystal ball on her desk. She couldn't believe that girl destroyed the apparition. Glimmer wasn't the only one who carried such power. Micah did.

Those brats were getting on Shadow Weaver's nerves. She didn't expect Adora to be a little assertive. The dark-skinned archer would prove to be a problem, too. And the other blonde? The guardian of Plumeria Woods would rely heavily on plant magic.

Shadow Weaver sipped her wine. Today was slow for her royal duties. People were avoiding her. The Horde Clan was busy. At some point, someone handed her a written report of Mystacor Village. Its sorcerers had recovered, much to her annoyance. She figured it was due to Glimmer's interference.

Something about the girl reminded Shadow Weaver of Micah. A little too much. She snorted. Micah used to be her favorite student at Mystacor Academy...

Light Spinner was walking through the academy when footsteps approached her. It was Micah, a student who was special to her. He carried so much potential. He started speaking. She could tell he was excited.

"Miss Spinner, I got that spell right! Teach me more! You're so amazing!" Micah exclaimed.

"Micah, you are talented. However, you lack dedication," Light Spinner said.

"Let me show you how much I've improved." Micah's index finger traced a rune. "Watch."

"Your form is still sloppy." Light Spinner nudged Micah's hand. "To master your magic, you must do as I say."

"Yes, Miss Spinner."

For several weeks, Light Spinner spent time mentoring Micah. She saw an improvement in his magic. It wasn't as flawed and weak as it once was. Whenever she wasn't training him, she dabbled in the forbidden arts. Over time, the other sorcerers caught on. One day, Norwyn confronted her in the meeting room.

"Is this what you've been teaching your students?" Norwyn asked.

"I'm practicing forbidden magic. You consider it an abomination. However, think of the good it'll do," Light Spinner said.

"It isn't meant for any of us. It'll corrupt the user."

Light Spinner scoffed. She sensed her temper rising. At first, the sorceress maintained her composure. She forced herself to listen to differing opinions. Asimati, Serena, and Maxia agreed with Norwyn. Light Spinner glared at the sorcerers.

"Why don't you understand my perspective?" Light Spinner spat.

"Resorting to twisted spells is foolish," Norwyn said.

"You're all blind."

"Starting this day forward, you will no longer teach at Mystacor Academy."

Light Spinner shot up to her height. "I've heard enough, you weaklings!" Without thinking, she expelled dark runes at the sorcerers.

The others attempted to defend themselves. Their efforts were futile. Light Spinner killed them with a curse. A terrified voice said her name, drawing her attention to the door. Micah gawked at the scene in utter horror.

"They brought it upon themselves," Light Spinner said.

"You... You murdered them!" Micah replied.

"Get a new teacher. I'm leaving."

Within seconds, Light Spinner began transforming. Her skin blanched to a deathly color. Scars zig-zagged along her face. The dark magic aged her appearance.

"Light... Spinner..." Micah whispered. His eyes widened.

"I am now Shadow Weaver," Light Spinner said. She pushed past Micah. "Don't chase me."

Shadow Weaver gritted her teeth. She had never forgotten the day her former student became her enemy. He got what was coming for him. His wife deserved her fate, too. Now, their daughter was running around trying to 'save' Grayskull. Who did Glimmer think she was? The kingdom's only hope?

Shadow Weaver recalled the bold look in Adora's eyes. As far as she knew, there wouldn't be an uprising. The resemblance to Marlena's determined expression was undeniable. Like Adora, Marlena and Randor believed they were protecting Grayskull.

Shadow Weaver slammed her fists against the desk, making the goblet jitter. The wine spilled onto a stack of papers. Swearing under her breath, she tore the ruined papers into pieces. Time to start over. Her temper got the best of her.

Shadow Weaver copied the words onto blank pages. The queen continued stewing in her anger. A headache pierced her skull. Her heart palpitated. Not again.

Shadow Weaver felt ready to explode at any moment. She took calming breaths. It worked for a brief time. Dark magic certainly had a way of latching onto her emotions. She called a servant to her office. The maid cleaned up the stained papers and spilled wine.

As soon as the frightened individual came, they left. Shadow Weaver's spell seeped into the crystal ball. It showed Adora and the others exploring Plumeria Sanctuary.

Had Adora already recruited the other blonde to her feeble rebellion? It wouldn't surprise Shadow Weaver. She observed those teenagers. They entered a spacious chamber. There was something ahead of them. Was it a sleeping monster? Shadow Weaver traced a glyph on the crystal ball.

"Let's see if it'll make Adora consider running home," Shadow Weaver murmured. The spell was about to take effect.

The tip of Glimmer's sword brushed the restraints. Adora, Bow, and Perfuma stared in anticipation. Behind them, the exit was closed off. A black tentacle descended from the ceiling. It split into five tendrils and severed the restraints.

The creature awakened, revealing its pincers and barbed tail. White armor covered its top and spine. Beady eyes dotted its head. Underneath its natural shield, Glimmer could see a dark body. The insect-like beast emitted a growl. It resembled a deathstalker.

A gust extinguished the torches. Glimmer backed away, watching the monster. It charged at the group. Glimmer shoved Adora and Perfuma out of the way.

Bow shot an arrow at a ledge. The missile transformed into a rope and wrapped around a pillar. He climbed onto the ledge. Then, he fired a series of arrows at the deathstalker. The creature's armor deflected the projectiles.

Glimmer expelled an air spell. Upon impact, the monster flew across the room. It slammed into the wall and fell to its back. The knight lunged at the creature. Her sword gashed its underbelly. She repeated the movement, wasting no time.

The monstrous insect rolled to its legs. It reared back. Glimmer sidestepped, then dodged a blow. Its left pincer enveloped the knight's body and chucked her across the room. Her spine met the ground. Pain flooded her body. Groaning, she forced herself up. Adora rushed to her side.

"Are you okay?" Adora asked.

"Yes," Glimmer said.

They heard a shout. Perfuma had summoned her plant magic. Green vines restrained the deathstalker. It yanked its pincers away, dragging Perfuma along the ground. Bow expelled more arrows. The deathstalker crawled along the wall and approached him.

Glimmer hurled fireballs at the beast. The sixth fireball knocked the deathstalker to the ground. Bow jumped down from the ledge and continued shooting arrows.

Glimmer closed the distance between herself and the deathstalker. The knight sliced its tail, dismembering the stinger. She plunged her sword into its underbelly. The creature disintegrated into black smoke. Perfuma rushed to hug Glimmer and Bow. Adora joined in.

"Let's find the dust chamber. I will communicate with the forest spirits," Perfuma said as she pulled away.

"What about the curse?" Glimmer asked.

"The forest spirits will tell us."

Perfuma led everyone to a nearby room. Golden dust gleamed in the wooden cauldron. In front of it stood an empty display. Glimmer could see inscriptions on it.

Perfuma summoned a rose and placed it on the display. Then, she bowed her head and spoke in a foreign language. Was she paying respects to the forest spirits? A translucent silhouette materialized by the cauldron. Their hair flowed in an invisible breeze.

"Guardian of Plumeria Woods, we have heard your question. The heroine has lifted the curse," the spirit said. "She has slayed the dark beast."

"How about the vines?" Perfuma asked.

"They will vanish. The forest folk are healing."

"Can I use a handful of dust to speed up the healing?"

"You may." The spirit vanished.

Perfuma scooped a handful of golden dust from the cauldron. She chanted in the foreign language. Then, she released the glowing powder into the air. Its particles floated to the walls and the ground. The rest glided to the exit.

"Let's return to the village," Perfuma said.

Glimmer, Adora, Bow, and Perfuma made their way out of Plumeria Sanctuary. The poisonous vines had disappeared. The monsters were nowhere to be found. As they walked to the village, Adora held Glimmer's hand.

"The injuries weren't bad, right?" Adora asked. She wrinkled her brows. "I mean, the landing back there was rough."

Now that Adora pointed it out, Glimmer became aware of the pain in her body. Agony pierced her spine. She bit her bottom lip. She was lucky the deathstalker didn't sting her.

"We could get the healing potions. And we could rest for a bit," Adora suggested. "Maybe there's a spring around here."

"Sounds like a good idea," Glimmer said. "We could take a break for a while."

The birds chirped as they flew around branches. Some landed in nests. The forest boundary came into view. Upon entering the village, fairies and elves gathered around Perfuma.

"Yes, we broke the curse," Perfuma said. She gestured to Glimmer and their companions. "They helped."

Glimmer and Adora strode to a body of water. A small waterfall poured into the spring. They took in the aroma of many flowers. Both women sat on the ground. In the distance, the fairies chattered about the heroes. They mentioned an evening celebration.

"We could spend another night here," Glimmer said. She leaned against Adora. "Did exploring the sanctuary tire you out?"

Adora yawned. "It did. We had some scary encounters. You, Bow, and Perfuma slayed the deathstalker."

"It was an intense battle." Glimmer rolled her shoulders. "But we did it."

"I couldn't help but be amazed by your fighting skills. I'm not a sorcerer. However, I'd love to have a sword of my own. You could teach me. We'll spar together."

Glimmer considered the idea for a moment. Then... "We'll buy a sword for you. We'll practice. It'll be perfect for self-defense." She wrapped an arm around Adora's waist. "Still, I'm your knight."

Adora's heart fluttered. "That's true. I'm thankful to have you in my life. Without you, I wouldn't have left the castle." She glanced at her lap. "What if we don't find my brother? What if we fail the kingdom?"

"Adora, don't start. Even if things go wrong, we'll figure it out. I'll stay by your side."

Adora looked up. "Thanks. However, I don't have experience in leadership. How will I perform as queen someday?"

Glimmer rested a palm on Adora's hand. "Maybe it'll come to you."

"You don't know what it involves. You have to speak to subjects in the throne room. There's paperwork to be done. And there are meetings with diplomats. What if I mess it up?"

"Hey, it's going to be alright. For now, focus on the sound the waterfall makes."

For the rest of the afternoon, they remained silent. There were times when Glimmer fell asleep leaning against Adora. The trickle of water in the waterfall was soothing. It lulled both women into a sense of serenity.

To the Ocean

After staying in Plumeria Woods, Adora and her friends left the forest. Once again, they were riding through a vast field. She wrapped her arms around Glimmer from behind. It would be nice to have her own horse. At the same time, she didn't mind being this close to Glimmer. It felt nice. She caught a whiff of lavender. They only knew each other for a few days. Yet, she suspected she was harboring feelings for the knight.

It could be a temporal crush. Something fleeting. It might go away in a matter of weeks. Adora gazed at the clouds in the sky. Hoofbeats drummed the trail. The sun glided westward as everyone continued their journey. Afternoon came.

They stopped by a river. A few feet away, Adora glimpsed a series of waterfalls. The trio dismounted the horses. Star and Artemis walked to the water and began drinking.

"There should be a village nearby," Bow said.

"We could ask people over there if they know where Adam went," Adora said. "I hope they give us the answers I'm seeking."

Glimmer bit into her apple and chewed off a piece. "The village is an hour's ride away. After sunset, people would most likely hurry into their homes."

"We could still ask around." Adora plunged her hands into the water and cupped a handful. "Adam had to be out there somewhere."

"Yeah."

Glimmer finished eating the apple. She pulled a spellbook from Star's saddlebag. The knight cracked the tome open. Adora walked over to Star and patted her neck. In response, the horse let out a soft nicker.

"Looks like they're done. We must find the village before sundown," Glimmer said.

"I agree," Adora replied. "Were you practicing magic?"

"Of course. I learned a new spell."

"Wow. Anyway, which do you prefer when it comes to combat? Magic or the sword?"

"I suppose it depends." Glimmer stashed the spellbook into the saddlebag. "I may cast spells if the opponent has powers. Enemies without magic? I use the sword on them."

"I've seen you use both on monsters. The deathstalker is one example."

Glimmer shuddered. "Right. That thing was terrifying. The armor on top made it worse."

Adora mounted Star. While seated, she made way for Glimmer to sit in front. "No wonder you and Bow worked together. Perfuma helped a little."

Glimmer sat in front of Adora. The knight peeked over her shoulder. "Do you think we'd explore more places similar to Plumeria Sanctuary?"

"The buildings with maze-like structures?"

"Yes. What else would those places be?"

Star and Artemis began trotting along the path. Adora glanced at the horizon. "Maybe there were more. We haven't seen the rest of Grayskull yet."

The sun inched closer to the horizon. Adora and Glimmer continued talking. It seemed to speed up the time. Perhaps it was due to enjoying the conversation. Adora felt at ease around Glimmer. It was a stark contrast to her interactions with Shadow

Weaver. The village gate came into view. The sign said: "Elberon Village."

The trio rode to an inn. They dismounted Star and Artemis. Bow led the horses to the stables. Adora and Glimmer booked separate rooms. One for Bow and the other for the girls.

Adora and Glimmer carried their bags to their room. They dropped the items by the bed. She glanced out the window. The setting sun painted the hills and trees in a soft orange light. On the streets, people were rushing to their homes. She turned her attention to Glimmer, who leaned against the door.

"So, should we shop for a sword tonight or tomorrow?" Adora asked.

"We could do it in the morning," Glimmer said. "There's a tavern connected to the inn if you want to get something to eat."

"Let's go there."

Glimmer extended a hand. "Shall I lead the way, princess?"

Adora smiled as she performed a mock curtsy. "Sure, my knight." She took Glimmer's hand.

They descended the stairs and strode to a tavern next door. A delicious scent greeted them as they chose a table. Some tables were occupied. They chose an empty one. Adora peeked at the menu on their table. A waitress came to take the order. Adora and Glimmer told her what they wanted.

The waitress hurried off. Adora's gaze swept across the room. For a moment, she made eye contact with a redheaded woman. The redhead gave her a curious stare. What was the woman thinking?

Adora averted her gaze. She didn't want to make the stranger feel uncomfortable. The princess looked into Glimmer's eyes. How was she still pining after the knight? Was it due to Glimmer saving her life several times?

"Is that woman going to talk to us?" Glimmer asked.

"The one with red hair?" Adora's fingers drummed the table. "I doubt she would. Maybe she mistook me for someone else. It happens sometimes." She exhaled audibly. "Anyway, what spell did you learn?"

"A stasis spell. A sorcerer can use it to freeze a target. Some variations of it use ice and the delay of movement."

"Can you show me?"

Glimmer nodded. "See those people on the neighboring table? Watch."

The knight squeezed her eyes shut and unfurled her fingers. Within seconds, her targets froze. They were motionless. With a snap of her thumb and index finger, Glimmer ended the spell. Adora thought it was interesting. Glimmer seemed to notice Adora's mesmerized expression.

"The stasis spell would be useful in the future," Glimmer said.

"For freezing enemies?"

"Yeah."

The waitress returned with two bowls of soup. She walked away. Adora and Glimmer proceeded to eat their dinner. Curls of steam wafted into the air. Adora blew on a spoonful before taking a bite. The tavern's food was delicious. She set down the spoon.

"Which one of us is paying?" Adora asked.

"I'll do it," Glimmer replied, smiling.

"Will they serve any dessert?"

"Dessert?"

Adora rested her elbows on the table. "I wonder if they serve pie here."

Glimmer leaned back in her chair. "I could ask the waitress."

After talking to the waitress, the duo continued their conversation. While they waited for the pie, someone approached the table. It was the redheaded woman from earlier. The stranger was wearing a suit of armor. A longsword rested on her hip. Under her beige tunic, the chainmail glistened.

"Miss, your face reminds me of someone I know," the woman said.

"Who did I remind you of? And what's your name?" Adora replied.

"You bear a faint resemblance to Adam. By the way, call me Teela."

"I'm Adora, Princess of Grayskull. Are you staying at the inn?"

"Yes. I have been traveling for a while."

Adora's fingers intertwined. "Do you know where this 'Adam' is?"

Teela nodded. "He's on Seaworthy Island. The isle is inhabited by a mix of humans and merfolk."

"Has he lived there for years?"

"Yes. A woman named Shakra raised him."

"Did you grow up on the island?"

"Of course." Teela gestured at an empty chair. "Can I sit here?"

Adora patted the seat. "Sure." She peeked at Glimmer, who had been watching the exchange. Then, she glanced at Teela. "I got a little carried away, Teela. This is my friend, Glimmer. She's my knight."

Teela sat down. "Did you grow up in the castle?"

"I did. A few days ago, Glimmer snuck me out. We've been searching for my missing brother. How long does it take to reach Seaworthy Island?"

"It depends on the sea conditions. We have to consider the weather and other factors. Lately, though, there were reports of monsters lurking in the ocean. The turbulences became frequent. We'd have to be careful."

"Okay."

During the rest of the evening, the trio of women discussed travel plans. They ate dessert. As soon as they finished eating, Teela left. Adora and Glimmer walked to their room, yawning.

Adora couldn't wait to meet her brother after all those years apart. Still, the mention of monsters in the ocean unnerved her. Would they hinder the journey over water? What if there were storms on the sea? The questions kept her awake. Finally, in the wee hours, she succumbed to slumber.

Morning came. Teela and Bow were tying the horses to a carriage. Glimmer and Adora visited a weapon store. Each display held a variety of weapons. Swords, spears, maces, and many others. Adora was browsing a rack of blades when the duo heard the door creak behind them. Footsteps approached them. A familiar voice spoke.

"Hey, Adora."

Glimmer and Adora whirled around. It was Catra. The brunette wore an unreadable expression. How did Catra find them? Did Shadow Weaver send her here? Glimmer wrapped a hand around her hilt. The knight scowled. She stepped in front of Adora in case Catra tried anything. To her surprise, the latter didn't react negatively.

"Did Shadow Weaver tell you to follow us?" Glimmer demanded.

"No. I left because I was done with the old queen," Catra said.

Glimmer examined Catra's body language. The brief explanation didn't convince her. She had seen how Catra reacted to Adora leaving the castle. She pressed her lips into a thin line. Narrowing her eyes, she waited for Catra to pull a dirty trick.

"Are you here to trick us?" Glimmer asked.

"No. I followed your scent to this village," Catra said.

"What do you mean? Did you seriously come all the way over here?" Glimmer drew her sword. They could take the fight outside. Right now, she remained alert. "Tell me the truth. Did you sneak onto people's wagons while they traveled? Don't tell me you've been working with the Horde Clan."

"I did ride wagons while tracking the scent. And no, I didn't work with the Horde Clan. It wouldn't feel right to side with the group that seeks to free Horde Prime."

"You're forgetting a word. One word. It starts with 's.' If you refuse to say it, don't bother us anymore. You underestimated my fighting skills. By the way, I slayed a deathstalker in Plumeria Sanctuary."

A ghost of a smirk tugged at Catra's mouth. She crossed her arms. "Still, an overgrown scorpion? Are you exaggerating? Apparently, the armor gave you a reason to share tall tales."

Adora placed a hand on Glimmer's shoulder. "I saw the battle with my eyes. My knight is brave. She helped Perfuma break the curse on Plumeria Woods. So, why do you look down on her?"

"I didn't think she would be good at keeping you safe," Catra said.

"I'm still alive. You weren't there when Glimmer protected me from the Horde Clan. And you didn't see what she did in Alwyn

Village. She's a fighter." Adora sighed. "Also, I thought you didn't care about my safety."

"Maybe I do care. We're like sisters, after all."

"We're not related by blood. Adam is my biological sibling, and I'm searching for him. It's unlikely you'd be able to catch his scent. I mean, it's been years!" Adora grabbed a sword from a rack. "We're wasting time here. I'll buy this weapon, and we'll go."

Adora stormed to the counter. She slammed a handful of coins onto the surface. The shopkeeper flinched, witnessing the sudden movement. Adora's face softened upon seeing their body language.

"I'm sorry. My sister made me mad," Adora said. "I couldn't stand the way she spoke to my knight."

"Okay. Ever wielded a sword before?" The shopkeeper replied.

"I'm taking lessons."

"Good luck with the training."

Glimmer, Adora, and Catra left the store. For the journey ahead, Teela and Bow would ride the carriage. Catra would be with them. A pair of horses, Kali and Artemis, would pull it. Glimmer and Adora would ride Star as usual.

The horses trotted nonstop. Glimmer kept an eye on her surroundings. The knight made sure there weren't any attacks. Part of her expected Catra to try something funny. However, Catra didn't do much other than talk.

Within four days and a half, the group arrived at their destination. The seaside town bustled with activity. Sea captains tied their ships to the marina. In the town square, musicians played their instruments.

In the southern district, pirates told wild tales of ocean adventures. Several individuals stopped to listen. Peasant women covered their children's ears. They voiced their complaints about some men being too boisterous.

Adora, Glimmer, Catra, and Bow followed Teela to a tavern. Some visitors played chess. Others arm-wrestled, gossiped, and drank gallons of ale. A bartender served beer to drunk customers. To the right, Adora saw some men waiting in line to arm-wrestle a pirate. Was the tavern always chaotic?

"I bet this place gets noisy every day," Catra commented.

"It's a common occurrence in seaside taverns," Teela said. "The pirates and their crews enjoy relaxing after long voyages."

"I thought the pirates enjoyed roaming the seas."

Teela approached the bartender. "Hey. Is Sea Hawk here?"

As Teela chatted with the bartender, a man walked up to Adora. He attempted to invade her personal space. His rough palms brushed her abdomen before caressing her hips. She looked over at Glimmer. She tried to ignore the stranger's disgusting breath.

Glimmer stepped between Adora and the man. She glowered at him. He staggered backward, holding up his hands. He leaned against the wall and began swearing. Glimmer led Adora away.

"Thanks, Glimmer," Adora said.

"I'd do anything for you," Glimmer replied. "Are you okay now?"

"Yes."

Teela led Adora, Glimmer, Catra, and Bow to Sea Hawk's table. The line had dispersed. People either finished arm-wrestling or got bored waiting. The dark-haired man leaned back in his seat. He rested his feet on the table.

"Do you think you could take us to Seaworthy Island?" Teela asked.

"Oh. I thought you were here to listen to my adventurous tales," Sea Hawk said. "People love my stories and shanties."

"Well, Mermista doesn't."

"The Princess of Salineas? I could sing tons of shanties about her. But alas, we have a complicated past."

Teela cleared her throat. "We're not here to discuss relationship drama. Adora, the Princess of Grayskull, is traveling with her friends. She's searching for her brother. He happens to be someone I know."

Sea Hawk moved his feet off the table. "Anyway, when do you plan to begin the journey to Seaworthy Island?"

"Today."

"You're aware of the monsters in the ocean, right?"

"It won't stop us from going. Don't you have a ship with cannons?"

Sea Hawk shrugged. "That was the Dragon's Daughter One."

Teela tilted her head. "What happened to it?"

"A fearsome Kraken destroyed the ship. I managed to plunge the sword into it. I was underwater, and its tentacles wrapped around my legs. Due to my determination, I won the fight. To this day, the survivors of the attack still share the tale. They know I'm the legendary Sea Hawk!"

Adora and Glimmer exchanged glances. The pirate could be exaggerating. According to records of the sea, the Krakens were giant beasts. No one could slay a single Kraken alone. Within one paragraph, Sea Hawk sounded full of himself.

"That is quite the story if it's genuine. However, I suspect you hadn't faced a genuine threat when sailing," Teela said. "Are there any more ships with cannons?"

"Sure!" Sea Hawk emphasized the word.

If there was one word to describe him, it would be 'egotistical.' How did Sea Hawk's crew tolerate that? Had someone ever knocked Sea Hawk off his high horse? Adora wouldn't be surprised if someone did. The group followed him to the marina. The ocean's surface glittered in the sunlight. It was calm and serene. Adora inhaled the salty smell.

"I hope the voyage will be quick," Catra said.

Adora caught up to Glimmer and the others. "Catra, I know you don't like the water. But could you try to tolerate it for a few weeks?"

"Whatever, princess. I'm not staying on the deck. I'll ride it out in a cabin beneath it."

"Are you being snarky again?"

"I bet you'd reconsider riding the ship if we encounter sea monsters."

Adora rolled her eyes. "You think you're strong. Your panther abilities weren't a match for Glimmer's magic. Also, you're aquaphobic."

It didn't take long for everyone to board the ship. The vessel began gliding over the water. Adora and Glimmer began sparring together. Glimmer taught Adora how to use the sword. At first, the movements were clumsy.

Adora refused to give up, even when she made mistakes. Teela and Bow leaned against the rail while watching them spar. Catra must have descended into the cabin at some point.

Adora fell onto her spine. Glimmer helped her up. Sweat drenched their bodies. It could have been from the heat. Or perhaps the sparring session made them sweat. The duo strode to the rail and gazed at the shimmering water. A mermaid's tail emerged. They watched closely. A woman's head replaced it. Her teal hair flowed to her shoulders. She had dark skin.

"Are you a mermaid?" Adora asked.

Adora didn't think she would meet one in person. In her favorite childhood stories, mermaids were prominent. So were fairies and elves. The woman opened her mouth to speak. As soon as the words came out, Sea Hawk interrupted.

"Mermista!" Sea Hawk greeted.

Mermista pinched the bridge of her nose. "I was about to answer the blonde girl's question!"

The pirate raced to the rail. "How is everything going, princess?"

"Good, as usual. Kingdom stuff. Nothing new."

"Didn't you say Salineas is dealing with monsters?"

Mermista scoffed. "I can handle them just fine."

Sea Hawk placed his palms on the rail. "How about the caverns? Isn't there a curse on Salineas?"

Another curse? Adora listened to the conversation. Would exploring the caverns be anything like Plumeria Sanctuary? Mermista mentioned dark creatures lurking in the cave. The description of some made Adora shudder. Shell-like creatures? Underwater snakes? Monster fish? That would be the stuff of nightmares.

"The curse has affected the rest of Salineas. Not just the caverns," Mermista was saying.

"Is there anything we can do to help?" Glimmer asked. "Where's the entrance?"

Adora tapped Glimmer's shoulder. "Are you sure we could risk our lives underwater?"

Glimmer made eye contact. "I know you want to see your brother. I doubt we are in a hurry, though. Still, I'll tell you this. The legendary heroine helped everyone in the kingdom. Not a select few individuals. We broke the curse on Plumeria Woods. Surely we could do the same for Salineas."

"Good point, I guess."

Suddenly, something collided with the ship. Adora and Glimmer looked up. A vessel was heading toward them. The sails and flags displayed the Horde Clan's emblem. Sea Hawk, Bow, and Teela filled the cannons. The missiles rammed into the enemy vessel. The other ship closed the distance. Some clan members jumped from their craft to this one.

A fight broke out between Adora's group and the Horde Clan. Catra joined in, attacking their enemies in panther form. Adora attempted to put her sword-fighting skills to good use. Her inexperience proved to be a drawback. One of the enemies outsmarted her. Another one grabbed her from behind.

Adora stomped on her captor's foot. He didn't budge. Dark storm clouds blotted out the sunlight. They churned in the sky. Lightning zig-zagged across the gray expanse.

Ocean waves swelled, rocking the ship on every side. Rain pelted everything in the vicinity. As the battle continued, Adora's captor dragged her toward the water.

"Glimmer!" Adora shouted. She gripped her captor's arm with both hands. She attempted to pry the arm away, but he was too strong.

"Let Adora go!" Glimmer spat. She unleashed the stasis spell upon Adora's captor.

He froze. Glimmer yanked Adora out of his grasp. Their companions forced the Horde Clan members off the ship. Bow and Teela lowered the sails. Sea Hawk tried to steer the vessel. The downpour kept descending, with no indication of stopping.

"Watch out! A wave!" Bow shouted.

Everyone looked up. A towering wave knocked the ship over. The next thing Adora knew, she was underwater. Darkness flooded her vision. The air escaped her lungs. She began to panic. Where was everyone else? Would they all drown? As her eyes fluttered shut, someone gripped her wrist. Was someone rescuing her and the group?

Stuck

Upon awakening, Adora became aware of the sand beneath her back. She shielded her eyes from bright sunlight. The princess scrutinized her surroundings. Glimmer lay next to her, unconscious. Catra, Bow, Sea Hawk, and Teela were present. Behind her, a foreboding forest awaited the group.

Skeletons cluttered the trail. One of them hung from a tree. Did Adora and her companions wind up on a creepy island? How did it happen?

The realization dawned on Adora. The battle on Sea Hawk's ship. A stormy ocean. And the last thing before passing out? A towering wave. Someone brought Adora and the others here. But who? Glimmer stirred awake, then sat up. The knight seemed as confused as Adora felt.

"How are you feeling?" Adora asked.

"I don't know. Is everyone else alright?" Glimmer replied.

"They're still breathing, which means they're fine. Do you know who saved us from drowning?"

"I remember a blur of teal hair. It could have been Mermista."

"She couldn't have done it alone. Some merpeople probably helped her."

Bow, Teela, and Sea Hawk awakened, too. Catra was the last to awaken. Sea Hawk mentioned pieces of the broken ship floating by the shore. Would he try to rebuild it?

Adora rose to her height. There had to be something that would get everyone off the island. She had been excited to meet Adam after all those years of separation. The Horde Clan ruined the journey, and the storm topped it off.

Adora's gaze swept over the sand. Vines hung from twisted trees. She detected a hill in the distance. Something caught her attention. Was it movement? Her pulse accelerated, and all she could do was stare.

"Why did I tag along anyway?" Catra asked.

"Did you figure out your reason for doing so?" Adora asked. There was a slight tremor in her voice. She couldn't tell if it was subtle anger or her unease. It could be both. "Why didn't you go solo? Don't remind me of the 'sister' thing."

"I was referring to the ocean adventure, which ended horribly."

"Hey, someone rescued us. It's a good thing we're still alive. If it wasn't for whatever the person did, we would have drowned."

Catra snickered. "Ever the optimist, aren't you?"

Adora sighed. "I'm just pointing out the fact."

"It was sheer luck."

Adora wandered toward a palm tree and sat on the boulder. Sea Hawk, Teela, and Bow gathered the broken pieces. They discussed the ship and its parts. They began working on it. By evening, they built a shelter and collected firewood.

Rebuilding the vessel must have worn them out. How many days would it take to complete it? Would it be weeks? Adora propped her face against her palms. Glimmer walked over to her and sat.

"Is something the matter?" Glimmer asked.

"We're going to be here for weeks, aren't we?" Adora replied. "I'd rather not be here."

"You're not the only one who feels this way. Catra had spiraled into a rant about dangerous oceans and spooky islands."

"Is it where the yelling came from?"

"Yeah."

"What did Catra do after that?"

"She transformed into a panther and reclined in a shaded area."

Adora peeked at the stars. "We could have told Catra not to tag along. What did the others say about the island?"

Glimmer rested her head on Adora's shoulder. "Sea Hawk sang sea shanties. If he intended to boost morale, he did a poor job of it. Bow didn't mind the singing. Teela said it was annoying."

Adora chuckled. "Let me guess. Sea Hawk sang about himself."

"Yes. Makes me wonder if the other pirates have high egos."

"We'll have to tolerate the exaggerated tales and sea shanties for several weeks. So, what do we do?"

A shout interrupted their conversation. No, several voices. One of them said: "Evelyn, don't even dare." Adora and Glimmer observed an alabaster-haired woman. The stranger in question wore a cloak. The woman narrowed her eyes at Teela.

"You're aiding a runaway princess in her rebellion," the woman said.

"We're helping Adora find her brother. Get out of our way, Evelyn," Teela replied.

"You dare defy the servant of Hordak?" Evelyn summoned a magical orb. "By doing this, you're opposing Queen Shadow Weaver." The orb split into three tendrils. Each tendril morphed into dark chains. "You shall be prisoners."

The chains wrapped around Teela, Bow, Catra, and Sea Hawk. Catra bared her fangs, snarling. In panther form, she seemed

dangerous. However, Evelyn was unfazed. Before Adora and Glimmer could act, the sorceress teleported their friends away. The magical glow faded. Glimmer scowled at the empty spot where the others were.

"Great. Evelyn kidnapped them," Glimmer said. "They were fixing the ship. How would we get off the island?" She ran her fingers through her hair. "I haven't learned the teleportation spell!"

Adora stroked Glimmer's arms. "We'll figure it out. If we stay by the shore, Mermista could see us. She could help us."

"I suppose. Let's watch out for each other. I have no idea what we'll face on the island."

"Me either."

They walked to the shelter and stepped inside. The lantern emitted a dim light, illuminating a few bags. A spellbook stuck out from one of them. Glimmer took it and began turning the pages.

Adora stared outside, keeping watch. Darkness surrounded the shelter. She glimpsed an outline of the ship's remains. Where did Evelyn take the others? Would Adora and Glimmer ever find Seaworthy Island? Would they break the curse on Salineas?

"Should we take turns guarding the shelter?" Adora asked. "It's dark out."

"Are you saying we could alternate between sleeping and waking?" Glimmer replied.

Adora shrugged. "Something like that. Hey, which spell are you practicing next?"

"The location spell."

"I thought you wanted to learn to teleport."

"Our friends need us to save them."

"True." Adora smoothed her braided hair. There was leftover sand in her locks. "Shadow Weaver must have ordered Evelyn to track us down."

Glimmer nodded. "That's what I thought, too. Evelyn could have taken us, too. However, she left us alone." She stroked her chin. "Could they be setting up a trap for us?"

"I wouldn't put it past Shadow Weaver and those loyal to her." Adora drew her knees to her chest. "I hope she doesn't hurt our friends." She hugged her knees.

Glimmer moved closer. The knight wrapped her arms around Adora. Silence penetrated the air. There was no need for speech. The comforting embrace was enough.

Adora inhaled the scent of lavender. She began thinking about her life. The princess had gone from a sheltered girl to someone who encountered danger many times. No one expected sheltered royals to embark on perilous journeys. A yawn interrupted her thoughts.

"You can sleep for a bit. I'll watch," Glimmer said.

"Okay," Adora murmured. She proceeded to use some bags as pillows.

Adora closed her eyes. As she drifted toward dreamland, images of her friends surfaced. Their captors could torture them. Horrifying outcomes flashed through her mind. Some were worse than others. Would an enemy torment them with weapons? Would they attempt to break her friends' spirits? What would happen to Bow, Sea Hawk, and Teela? How did Catra respond to the captivity?

Questions about Adora's brother arose. Then came the thoughts about her parents. They all blurred together and began manifesting as images...

A seven-year-old Adora raced through the halls of Grayskull Castle. The hem of her dress swept across the floor with each step. She held up the skirt to avoid tripping. Her brother was lucky he didn't have to wear this.

Adora rounded several corners and entered the throne room. Her parents stood in front of their thrones. Their spooky advisor was talking. Someone yanked her behind a stone pillar. It was Adam. He wore an embellished pink tunic with white sleeves.

"The scary lady will see us spying on her," Adam said as he peeked out. His tiny hands brushed against the stone. "Don't talk."

Adora pressed her lips together. The two siblings eavesdropped on the discussion. Their parents and the advisor spoke of unexplained catastrophes.

Off to the side of the throne room, Adora noticed the captain of the royal guard. The woman was tall and slender. She wore a single braid. Wisps of hair framed her face.

"Yes, we have halted the chaos in the village," the advisor said.

"That's great to hear," Queen Marlena replied. "Shadow Weaver, you have been helpful so far."

"I always have solutions, my queen. Never forget that." Shadow Weaver steepled her fingers. "Everyone wants to live in peace, don't they? Some of us should know what's best for the kingdom."

Adora swore she saw the captain giving Shadow Weaver an icy glare. However, the woman didn't move an inch. Shadow Weaver turned her head in the twins' direction. It seemed as if the advisor sensed them.

"Are you sure you're keeping those children under control?" Shadow Weaver asked the royal couple.

Adora and Adam exchanged glances. The spooky woman saw them. The twins rushed into an adjacent hallway. A gust extinguished the torches along the wall. Shadows stretched upward. Icy air enveloped Adora.

Adam vanished, leaving no trace. Shadow Weaver materialized in front of Adora. Dark fog obscured the doors, arches, and armored statues. She could make out vague faces in the blackness.

"How are you handling the detour, my dear?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"The what?" Adora replied. Her voice sounded small.

The hallway transitioned into an eerie island. Adora glimpsed a shelter. She saw the broken ship. It was familiar. She tried to remember something, yet the memory didn't come. Still, it held some significance to her. Frigid hands gripped her shoulders. She sensed someone standing behind her.

"When will you reconsider?" A sinister voice asked.

"Reconsider?" Adora repeated.

"If you hadn't fled the castle, your friends would be safe. They view you as a burden to drag around. Running away isn't worth endangering others. What would your parents think? Someday, you'll be queen. But you're not ready. All you cared about was your desire to go outside. There's a reason I'm the queen. The title isn't meant for you to carry."

"Shut up, Shadow Weaver." Adora jerked away from the unwanted touches. "You can't tell me what to do. I didn't endanger my friends. Evelyn took them. You will not speak of my parents."

A chuckle echoed. "You're still defending your friends at this point?"

"Why shouldn't I? You have no regard for the lives of others."

"Heh. Enjoy deluding yourself."

Everything went black. All Adora heard was silence.

Adora sat up, trembling as she struggled to control her breathing. Sweat poured down her forehead. Fragments of the nightmare arose in her mind. Her gaze flitted from the shelter walls to the exit. Glimmer remained awake.

"How late is it?" Adora asked with a yawn.

"Probably an hour past midnight," Glimmer said. "You were mumbling in your sleep. Did you have a nightmare?"

"Yes. At first, it was a memory dream. Soon, Shadow Weaver showed up. She said it was my fault for what happened to our companions. She called me a burden."

"Are you saying she entered your dream?"

Adora nodded. "Shadow Weaver has used such spells in the past."

Glimmer sighed. "Shadow Weaver is the worst. How did the nightmare make you feel?"

"It was unpleasant. I didn't want Shadow Weaver to bother me. She did it anyway." Adora folded her arms. "Whenever she talks to me, she says things to make me feel bad about myself. She's been that way for years. Nothing I did was ever good enough for her. She only considered me special when I obeyed."

"Other than being forced to stay inside, was the abuse the reason you wanted to leave?"

"I think so." Adora made eye contact. "Glimmer, I feel safe with you."

Glimmer smiled. "I'm glad I could make you feel safe. I care about you. Nothing bad will happen as long as I'm here. I'll stick to my promise."

Adora grinned. "I know I could count on you."

"You have my word, princess."

Adora thought of the knights in her favorite stories. Those heroes were always there to protect a royal. Usually, that royal was the romantic interest. Wait a minute. Why was she letting her mind wander like that? Was it related to her lingering feelings?

Catra hissed, awakening to a headache. A grunt escaped her snout as she tried to move her limbs. The chains no longer enveloped her. However, they restricted her legs.

The cold metal was like fire against Catra's fur. Judging by her surroundings, she could tell she was in a makeshift cell. Ears flattening against her head, she peeked at Bow and the others. At least Adora and Glimmer weren't here. Footsteps strode past the wooden bars.

A whiff of urine and dried blood rushed into Catra's nose. She attempted to step forward. The chains held her back. She growled. Their captors thought of everything, didn't they? Good thing she could see through the bars. That way, she would know what was going on.

Then, Catra saw *her*. The sorceress who abducted her, Sea Hawk, Bow, and Teela. Catra's entire body tensed. Her ears pinned back, and she bared her fangs. Her fur bristled. Evelyn snickered at her misfortune.

"My, my, the cougar still wants to fight," Evelyn remarked.

I'm a panther, for goodness sake! Catra wanted to tear Evelyn apart. If she could talk, she would say whatever came to mind. The sorceress wore an infuriating smirk. *As soon as I break free, I'll end you.* She waited for Evelyn to approach.

Then, Catra considered transforming. She focused her energy on shapeshifting. Nothing came. Not even bones changing shape, the

shifting of her insides, and the tearing of muscles. Was she stuck in this form?

"Looks like the kitty is angry." Evelyn giggled. "She can't transform anymore."

Catra emitted a threatening growl. *What did you do to me?* Her tail flicked to the side, stiffening. Her paw swiped at the air. In response, Evelyn laughed. An urge to rip Evelyn apart overwhelmed her, yet she couldn't do anything. Evelyn left, still chuckling.

Catra glanced at Teela, Bow, and Sea Hawk. They were chatting. She wished she could talk. Instead, all she could do was watch. And so she did.

"There's got to be a way to escape," Teela said.

"Yeah, but how?" Bow asked.

Teela looked around. "We still have chains on our wrists. And we need to figure this out."

Sea Hawk cleared his throat. "How about a morale-boosting sea shanty?"

Catra's snort came out as a hiss. *What does singing have to do with escape plans?* She waited for Sea Hawk to belt out those ridiculous songs. However, he didn't. He settled on something more infuriating - exaggerated tales. She focused her attention on the wooden bars. Her ears couldn't block out whatever Sea Hawk was saying.

"...then, I met this secret society of vampire pirates. Dangerous creatures of the night, I tell ya. They took out their scythes, flashed their fangs, and began attacking my crew! While my seafaring companions trembled in fear, I fought the vampires..."

Catra was sure the tale was far-fetched. Wouldn't someone have to use a wooden stake or something? Weren't vampires superior

in strength? Speed and agility were also factors.

Somehow, Bow seemed to believe the story. Had he always been gullible? Catra saw someone approach the wooden bars. It was a tall woman with white hair.

"Sea Hawk, I've heard enough," Teela said. "It doesn't sound believable."

"I'm a better sea captain than the others I know," Sea Hawk replied.

"It doesn't make you the best at everything."

Catra glared at the tall, white-haired woman, baring her teeth. The stranger didn't react. Why didn't the woman jump back? Anyone would. Catra pulled against the chains. A growl rumbled in her throat. She didn't trust the people keeping her group prisoner.

"So, uh, I heard you were the shapeshifter?" The woman said.

You're talking to one. The best I could do now is use body language. Catra waited for the woman to say something else. She turned her attention to Teela, Sea Hawk, and Bow. The trio was observing the woman.

"Alright, what's your name?" Teela asked.

"Scorpia," the woman replied.

"Do you work with the Horde Clan?"

"Yes." Scorpia looked to the side as if watching for someone. "Their methods aren't always, uh, the best. I'm aware of what they're capable of."

Bow frowned. "Have you considered leaving?"

"I'm supposed to be loyal. It runs in my family."

Catra's tail flicked around. And look where it got Scorpia. She listened to the conversation. Sometimes, Scorpia would get defensive, saying the clan was like family to her.

"Yet you know what they've done," Bow was saying.

Scorpia stepped away. "I'd like to keep talking, but I have things to do." She left.

Glimmer's eyes fluttered open. The knight yawned as she sat up and looked around. Her gaze went to Adora's sleeping form. The princess seemed so peaceful - lips slightly parted, slow breathing, and a lack of movement.

Glimmer tucked a strand behind Adora's ear. A distant sound stopped her movements. She picked up her sword and crept toward the tent flap. A growl drifted into her ears.

"Glimmer, what-" Adora began, her voice sounding tired.

"Shh!" Glimmer holds out a hand in front of Adora. "Something's out there."

"Oh."

Glimmer listened for more noises. Something - perhaps a creature - paced near the tent. Adora, meanwhile, was shaking behind Glimmer. They held their breaths, waiting for an attack. Another growl. The knight prepared herself.

"Glimmer... what was that?" Adora whispered.

"Could be a dangerous beast. Stick by me," Glimmer replied.

"Are we getting out? I'm still not good with the sword."

"I'll lead the way."

They stepped outside. A chimera noticed their presence, advancing. It had a goat head and a lion head. Its tail was a snake. The creature charged at Glimmer and Adora. The knight and the princess jumped out of the way. Glimmer acted quickly, attempting to find the weak spot. At the same time, she tried her hardest to defend Adora.

The chimera roared, lunging. Glimmer evaded the attack and slashed its body. She continued hitting with the sword. After several minutes, the beast fell to its side, defeated. Glimmer was panting. This one put up quite a fight.

"Glimmer, you did great," Adora said. "I was worried the chimera would hurt you."

"Your safety's important," Glimmer replied.

"Still, I want to be able to help." Adora looked down at her sword. "Despite the inexperience."

"With enough practice, using the sword will feel like second nature." Glimmer sheathed her weapon. "The creature I fought? It saw our tent. More of those monsters could show up. We don't know how many we'll see on the island."

Adora peeked at the ocean. "Could we send a message to Mermista somehow? She hasn't come for us."

"I'll see if I have the stuff for that."

They walked into the tent. Glimmer rummaged through the bags. Adora sat by the tent flap. She was saying something about the island. Glimmer pulled out a glass bottle and a blank scroll from a bag. The knight began writing.

"Are we ever gonna leave?" Adora asked.

"We should be able to," Glimmer said. "Mermista could send for someone." She pushed the scroll into the glass bottle.

"I hope so. That monster we saw earlier was scary."

"Yeah."

"It even has the creepy snake tail."

Glimmer rose to her height. "Hopefully, the letter reaches Mermista."

Adora smiled. "I think she'll receive it."

They walked to the shore. Glimmer placed the bottle into the water. The knight watched as it floated away. She held Adora's hand, staring out in silence. There was one thing she was sure of - they wouldn't be stuck here.

The Royal Twins Meet

Two weeks passed. Adora and Glimmer stuck close to each other on the dangerous island. They waited for Mermista to come, refusing to give up despite the challenges. One morning, a ship came into view, albeit at a distance.

Adora's heart skipped a beat. Someone would help them leave the creepy island. She led Glimmer to the shore, excitement settling in her heart.

"I'm so ready to go," Adora said.

"Same," Glimmer replied.

The minutes transitioned into an hour. By the time the sun rose higher into the sky, the ship approached the deck. Adora followed Glimmer onto the vessel. The salty air blew through her blonde hair.

A sea captain introduced himself as Falcon, Sea Hawk's father. He told them that Mermista had spoken to him on Seaworthy Island regarding what happened. Adora thanked Falcon for finding them, then followed Glimmer into the cabin.

They sat on a bench. Adora leaned against Glimmer. She hoped it was real. In some way, it felt like a dream. However, it wasn't. For once, the monsters weren't chasing the duo. Their time on the island gave her nightmares.

"We'll have to thank Mermista once we find her. She sent help to us," Adora said.

"I agree," Glimmer replied. "Speaking of her, we could discuss the curse on her kingdom."

"I've seen enough scary monsters in my lifetime." Adora tried to keep the tone light as she spoke. The idea of exploring an underwater cave after the ordeal unnerved her.

"Mermista and I will be with you, so you don't have to be afraid."

"Still..." Adora sighed. "I know I sound weak, but-"

"You're not weak. It's normal to get scared sometimes," Glimmer said. Her eyes lit up with an idea. "We could spar together in a few minutes. That'll make you feel better. You enjoyed it last time."

"I won't deny that I did." Adora picked up her sword. "Let's start."

They proceeded to practice. Both weapons clanged, emitting sparks each time they connected. Of the two, Glimmer was faster and more skilled. At times, she taught Adora some moves. Within an hour, Glimmer included spells. Adora wasn't expecting it. One of them made her stagger toward the wall.

"Whoa!" Adora exclaimed as she caught herself, standing upright. "How about we stick with swordplay?"

"We will." Glimmer sheathed her sword. "In a battle, I could defend you against magical attacks."

"Makes sense. I don't possess magical powers."

"Want to spar again? Or do you want to take a break?"

"We could take a break."

They sat down, weary from training. Silence hung between them. Adora couldn't help but peek at Glimmer. She enjoyed her friend's company. She didn't mind the feeling of security. The princess rested her head on the knight's shoulder. Time seemed to trickle by without them realizing it.

Adora walked to the window and sat. She could see the setting sun and the vast ocean. The water glittered in the fading light. A shuffling sound reached her ears.

Glimmer had just opened the spellbook. The knight began practicing spells. Adora observed her the entire time. Some of them fascinated her, such as ice appearing out of nowhere. One spell made Glimmer disappear. The knight reappeared by Adora. Glimmer tried it again.

"Now you can teleport?" Adora asked.

"Yes," Glimmer replied. "You saw it, didn't you?" She wore a knowing smile.

"I did. You could use it to your advantage, along with the sword skills."

"Right. An enemy wouldn't see it coming."

"They definitely wouldn't."

Glimmer closed the spellbook. "Most sorcerers say that teleportation is one of the most useful abilities. You get someone out of danger. You have the element of surprise on your side. Those are just some examples." She walked toward the bedroom. "Anyway..." Her voice trailed off.

Glimmer's expression was unreadable. Was the knight deep in thought? She opened the door and stepped inside. Adora strode into the room with her. They sat on a bed.

"Is something wrong?" Adora asked.

"They could still be in danger. Who knows what Evelyn is doing?" Glimmer replied.

"Are you talking about Bow, Catra, and the others?"

"Yes. I could have been quicker. Evelyn wouldn't have taken them."

Adora placed a hand on Glimmer's shoulder. "Don't blame yourself. If anyone's at fault, it's Evelyn. We'll save our friends."

Glimmer looked up, a hint of tears in her eyes. "You think we'll find them?"

"Glimmer, we didn't lose hope while on the island. And you didn't seem the type to give up. You're brave, also. Shadow Weaver was insistent on me staying inside the castle. And despite what she said, you helped me sneak out. You knew she wouldn't be happy, but you didn't let it stop you from doing it."

A grin tugged at the corners of Glimmer's mouth. "Are you saying those words for real? Do you think I'm amazing?"

Adora pulled Glimmer into a hug. "I know so. Your courage inspired me."

"I inspire you?"

"Of course."

They continued holding each other. Glimmer's hair tickled Adora's chin. The proximity, as usual, reminded her of those feelings. She assumed it would be fleeting. However, it stuck with her. The lingering eye contact, the soft touches, and the fluttering pulse.

The way the knight smiled - no, it could be politeness. Nothing more. However, Adora couldn't deny how genuine it was. And the fondness in Glimmer's eyes? Was something there? Or were the women just friends?

The minutes turned into hours. By then, Adora and Glimmer reclined on the bed. The latter was the first to fall asleep. For some reason, Adora's thoughts drifted to the kingdom's fate. How were the citizens doing at this point? Did things continue to worsen for them?

Adora's brows drew together. She tugged at the blanket's fabric. A subtle anger arose as she recalled Shadow Weaver's lies regarding her parents.

The same woman lied about everything else. Ruined people's lives. There was no low for Shadow Weaver, it seemed. Adora had been so young when she fell for the manipulation and gaslighting.

Adora hated how gullible she was back then. At the same time, she reminded herself that she was a child. Did it matter either way? Shadow Weaver was desperate for power. And look what happened to King Randor and Queen Marlena.

Adora told herself to focus on the positives. She had met some wonderful friends. She was learning to defend herself. The adventure had given her confidence. Her mind began running out of positive thoughts. Perhaps she could think of more later? Without realizing it, sleep blanketed her body.

Catra didn't know what to make of Scorpia. Teela, Bow, and Sea Hawk seemed to tolerate Scorpia. The woman was acting so friendly, it could be fake. The ever-present smile, the mention of being a hugger, and the annoying voice. Despite the armor giving Scorpia the appearance of a stern, capable woman, she was the opposite. It was a wonder the Horde Clan kept her around.

As the morning light penetrated the cell, Catra stretched her limbs. Even in panther form, she didn't want stiff muscles. A part of her missed the ability to talk. She glowered at Scorpia, who was talking to Sea Hawk.

"There's not as many guards here, it seems," Sea Hawk said.

"True. But Hordak will get mad if I do something against his orders," Scorpia replied.

Sea Hawk leaned against the bars. "Anyway, where is this place exactly?"

"A Horde Clan hideout. It's in the middle of the Crimson Desert."

"Oh, the desert?" Sea Hawk put on the tone he often used when telling stories. "They say the Crimson Desert is vast, stretching for

miles. Voices in sandstorms. Giant quicksands. Monsters in abandoned structures. Not many people survive!"

Scorpia flashed an amused grin. "And yet we're still alive. The Horde Clan has tough people. Your group? You're just captives."

Bow joined the conversation, standing by Sea Hawk. "Scorpia, you said Hordak would get mad if you don't obey orders. What does he do when he's angry with a clan member?"

Scorpia frowned. "He loses his temper. He yells about giving punishments. Usually, it's because we messed up. I can't go back on my loyalty. Besides, the footsoldiers chase people who leave the Horde Clan."

"What happens to those who flee?"

"They either lost their lives or went into hiding."

Catra watched the expressions on their faces as they spoke. Was Bow trying to convince Scorpia to leave the clan? Or was he hoping to trick her into letting the group escape? Then, as Scorpia took out the keys, Catra growled.

"I'm not going to hurt you guys," Scorpia said, sounding startled.

Catra continued snarling as Scorpia opened the cell door. Bow placed a hand on Catra's back, making her bristle. However, she refused to attack. Scorpia removed the chains from everyone's limbs. The armored woman led them into a passageway.

Catra eyed Scorpia closely, ensuring she didn't try anything funny. Everyone evaded the guards, remaining silent. At times, Scorpia seemed nervous. Yet the woman didn't stop helping them. Thirty minutes of sneaking later, they walked outside. The desert sun heated the air around them. Puffs of sand wafted in the wind.

"You're not coming with us?" Bow asked.

"I'll stay behind," Scorpia said.

"You know Hordak could hurt you either way, right?"

"I'll make up an explanation. It'll be okay."

"What if something happens?"

Scorpia opened her mouth, then closed it. "I... I'm not sure." She folded her arms. "The guards will be investigating by now. Go before they catch you."

Catra, Bow, Sea Hawk, and Teela began running. Once they reached a shelter within an hour, they stepped inside. The heat had worn them out. There should be water somewhere. Catra hoped there would. Her human form wouldn't heat up as quick.

The fur was like wearing a thick blanket on a hot day. Catra went to the shaded area of the shelter. A subtle squeak made her ears perk up. Was it a mouse or a small animal? Her gaze flitted over the walls and floor. The noise transported her mind to the past...

The preteen brunette was racing through the hallway when she heard Adora shouting. Curious, Catra followed the voice to an adjacent corridor. The blonde princess was pointing to a mouse. It wasn't a hissing rat, but still... Catra walked to Adora's side. The rodent looked up at them, then ran.

Catra transformed into a panther and began chasing the mouse. Its scent led her to a secret passageway. She sniffed the air and cantered to a small hole in the wall. The rodents sure loved those passageways. Last week, she encountered a rat in the passage. She slipped back into the ornate castle halls. Adora stood by the archway.

"Did you get the mouse?" Adora asked.

Catra shifted into her human form. "It must have gone inside the hole in the wall."

"It's like you're a cat." Adora giggled. "Chasing those things away."

Catra crossed her arms. "It's in my name." Her tone was light-hearted. "And I can turn into a panther, also."

"Yeah. I could say, 'Is that a mouse?' and you'd start looking for it." Adora chuckled. "It's as if your instinct kicks in within seconds."

"Are you ever going to let it go?"

"Are you ever going to stop being a cat?"

Both girls laughed as they bantered. Adora's face became serious as she stepped closer. Catra searched the young royal's eyes. The princess leaned in, whispering.

"I'm not allowed to go outside. I find it boring. Do you think we can sneak around?" Adora asked.

Catra flashed a mischievous smile. "Of course."

"Let's do it."

They darted into the secret passageway, exploring tunnels and corridors. Giggling, they ascended the stairs. Then, a familiar voice halted their footsteps.

No one else was here. Catra placed a finger to her lips as she tip-toed toward the exit. On the other side of the hidden door, she heard ranting.

"Is it Shadow Weaver?" Adora whispered.

Catra nodded. She pressed her ear against the door. The footsteps receded, followed by a slam. She placed her palm on the door. It budged, revealing a bedroom. The brunette motioned the princess into the room. Piles of papers cluttered the desk. She glimpsed potions on the shelves. The gargoyle statues creeped her out.

"It could be Shadow Weaver's room," Adora said in a shaky voice. "She won't be happy seeing us in here."

"We'll make it quick," Catra replied, eyeing the desk.

"You want to touch the papers?"

"Yeah. You keep watch. Go to the door."

Adora raced to the door. Catra began rummaging through piles of papers. Some stood out to her. There was information about a group of bandits. The Horde Clan. Shadow Weaver knew the leader on some level.

Catra was so focused on reading. As a result, she didn't register someone else's presence. Until a bony hand snatched the papers away. And another one grabbed her wrist.

"What are you two doing in my room?" Shadow Weaver shouted. She loomed over Catra.

Adora rushed to Catra. Her face was pale, and her body trembled. "Shadow Weaver, we were playing, and-"

Shadow Weaver glared at Adora. "I had the guards searching the entire castle for you! Did you think we wouldn't notice? Did you go outside?"

"N-No. I... I was in the passageway with Catra. And-"

"Why are you letting the half-moggy drag you down?" Shadow Weaver interrupted. "How could you be so disobedient? I told you to do as I say. The only reason you're alive is because I've been raising you. Your parents are gone. Even in their graves, they expect you to respect authority figures!"

Tears streamed down Adora's face. Something in Catra wanted to tell Shadow Weaver to back off. Yet every muscle in her body was frozen, including her mouth.

In the next minute, Shadow Weaver's demeanor changed. The older woman stroked Adora's cheek.

"You are a special girl. You're destined to be a queen someday. First, you must obey," Shadow Weaver said.

"Y-Yes... I'm so sorry..." Adora replied.

"Good girl." Shadow Weaver glanced at Catra. "As for you, you need to behave. Learn from Princess Adora's example and be a proper lady."

A scowl tugged at Catra's mouth. "So, I should start wearing dresses and acting like a royal doormat? Curtsying at every opportunity?"

"You would be wise to keep your mouth shut. Now, girls, depart from my room!"

Later that night, Catra ascended the stairs to Adora's room. She was ready to say something when she heard sniffling. Why did she care? Why did it give her pause? She crept into the room. The princess didn't notice her presence. Instead, Adora mumbled something between sobs.

"Mommy... daddy..."

Catra could relate to the pain of losing her family. She hadn't forgotten how it felt to lose them. It had been devastating. Now, the girls had an abusive guardian. She made her way to Adora and sat by her. The princess made eye contact. Adora's eyes glistened, and her nose was runny.

"Catra... Why is Shadow Weaver so awful?" Adora murmured.

"I was thinking the same question. I hate it, too," Catra replied.

"She wouldn't be doing it if I acted better."

Catra exhaled. "She'll be bitter and manipulative regardless. No matter what happens, you and I stick together. We'll have each other's backs."

Adora rested her hands in her lap. "Promise?"

Catra hugged Adora. "I promise. We'll look out for each other."

The memory faded. Catra heard the door open. Teela was carrying several waterskins. Bow and Seahawk grabbed some. Did the time pass while Catra dwelled on the memory? Did the group ever find the source of the squeaking sound?

"Are we sure we should go to the Village of the Lost?" Bow asked.

"We could ask people there for directions," Teela said. "What alternative do we have? Die from heatstroke?"

"You have a point there. But its residents can be trouble."

"Trouble or none, we're still returning to the Kingdom of Grayskull."

Bow leaned against the wall. "What about Adora and Glimmer?"

Sea Hawk shrugged. "Mermista could be helping them."

Catra listened to the exchange. A few ideas made sense. The others didn't. She had heard stories of the Village of the Lost. According to Shadow Weaver, the Horde Clan went there one time.

After arriving at Seaworthy Island, Glimmer and Adora left the ship. Dozens of houses lined the cobblestone paths. Some sat along the shores and cliffs. Glimmer could see a jungle a few feet away. She led Adora to the town center.

"What do you want to do first? Visit the tavern and ask people? Or seek out Mermista?" Glimmer asked.

"We could go to a tavern first," Adora said.

"I figured you would say that."

They wandered to a tavern and entered. A blonde man sat by the window by himself. His facial features reminded Glimmer of Adora. He wore a pink tunic over a white shirt. There was a sword attached to his belt. Adora approached the table. Glimmer sat next to her.

"Hi. I'm Adora, Princess of Grayskull," Adora said. "And your name is?"

The man looked up. "I'm Adam. Your name sounds familiar."

"So does yours. I have a twin brother named Adam."

"As in the prince? My adoptive mother told me a bit about the royal family."

"Has she told you how the twins got separated?"

"Pretty much."

Adora tugged at her sleeve. "Do you remember anything about your childhood? I had dreams about a little boy who wore pink and white. They often took place in the castle."

Adam rested his forearms on the table. "Usually, I don't discuss dreams or nightmares with people I just met. This one, however, got my attention. Did you ever see the royal couple in your dreams?"

"I did."

"Same. I'd see the little blonde girl in the hallway. There's Randor and Marlena."

"What did the girl wear?"

"A red dress with some sort of apron or sash in the front."

"That's what I wore."

Adam's face lit up with realization. "Adora, I'm the lost prince. And you're my sister."

Adora nodded. "Yeah."

Glimmer stood, then walked to the bar to order some drinks. The twins would be catching up. On the opposite side of the bar from her, a familiar woman sat. It clicked in her mind. This was Mermista. Glimmer closed the distance between herself and her.

"Hello, Mermista," Glimmer said.

"Hi," Mermista replied.

"Adora and I appreciate that you sent help to us. We wouldn't have left the creepy island otherwise."

"How was the sea journey after Falcon found you?"

"It was smooth." Glimmer gathered the drinks. "Tell me about the underwater caverns."

Mermista sipped her drink. "The merfolk thought sealing off the entrance would hinder the sea serpent. The monster was part of the curse. Its tentacles would reach through the cave walls and grab the merfolk. Some had winded up in the beast's clutches."

"That must have been scary."

"It is."

"Where's the entrance, by the way?"

Mermista set her drink on the bar. "I could lead you and Adora to it. I must warn you, though - the Seabed Caverns is a dangerous cave."

"Is there a way to help the non-merfolk breathe underwater?"

"There is."

"Good to know. Anyway, I'll go talk to Adora and Adam."

Glimmer carried the drinks to where Adora and Adam sat. She occupied a chair and handed them the drinks. The blondes seemed to enjoy the conversation.

Glimmer noticed the way Adora's face lit up whenever laughing. The cute smile, the happiness in Adora's eyes, and the relaxed expression. Her laughter was delightful to listen to. It was a sound Glimmer would never forget. Then, the laughter faded. Adora glanced down.

"Adam, I remember what happened that day," Adora whispered. "The day we lost our parents and got separated."

The Twins Remember

Adora mentally prepared herself to bring up the memory. Glimmer's hand on her shoulder did little to ease her nerves. Adam said he would talk about some parts from his perspective. At least it would fill in the blanks. Adora clasped her hands together. She took deep breaths. Her heartbeat slowed.

"It all started in the morning. We were running through the castle hallway..." Adam said.

Laughter echoed off the walls as the twins raced. Portraits of the royal family covered the walls. The glow of chandeliers penetrated the hallway. Curtains concealed the windows.

On any other morning, Adora and Adam would be taking etiquette lessons. This one was different. They were free to be themselves. They didn't have to worry about the dos and don'ts. The king and queen might have emphasized the importance of etiquette.

However, Adora and Adam wanted to have fun. After all, they were children. They made their way to the dining hall, where their parents sat. The servants had arranged food around the table. As usual, King Randor and Queen Marlena flirted. The young prince and princess giggled at the sight.

"Oh, get a room!" Adam joked.

Adora snorted. "Mommy and Daddy, you're so in love! Are you gonna kiss?"

Randor and Marlena smiled at their children. Adora and Adam wore mischievous grins. Then...

"Can we play outside?" Adora asked.

"After you eat your breakfast," Marlena said. "And try not to get yourselves dirty when playing."

The family ate their meal. The food made by servants was the best. Adora and Adam always looked forward to meal times. Finishing up their plates was a game. Everything else was, too. At seven years old, they were competitive. Once they were done wolfing down their breakfast, they rushed out the door.

It didn't take long for the twins to reach the courtyard. The cool morning air greeted them. Adora and Adam played tag, giggling. They would hurry over small paths and jump into bushes. The servants could bathe them later.

Adora's feet met a puddle of mud. She didn't care that her skirt got soaked. Yesterday was rainy, so it made sense that she and her brother would run outside the first chance they got.

A butterfly flitted past Adora. It was orange and black, with white dots. She chased it, stepping on twigs and leaves as she tried to keep the pace. The butterfly outran her. It was fun while it lasted. She looked at her grinning brother. Both siblings laughed as they maintained eye contact. They started playing hide-and-seek.

"...nine, ten... Here I come!" Adora said as she darted across the courtyard.

They took turns finding each other. At times, they imitated their favorite storybook characters. By noon, they were breathless. Their lungs ached from all the laughter.

As they walked into the castle, a tall woman greeted them. The sinister advisor. Shadow Weaver. Adora and Adam shrunk back, staring up at her. The chandelier lights emphasized the woman's pale complexion. Her eyes narrowed.

"You little brats! What will your parents think about you getting all dirty out there?" Shadow Weaver spat. Her voice dripped with disdain.

"Sh-Shadow Weaver, we... we're just... having-" Adora began.

"What, little girl? What? You know it's improper!"

Adora squeaked. She hated the way Shadow Weaver talked to her. Footsteps approached, garnering the woman's attention. Another adult led Shadow Weaver away. Adora let out a relieved sigh. Still, her body remained tense.

"I wish the scary lady would go away," Adora said.

"I agree," Adam replied. "She's so mean and evil."

"You know who she reminds me of? The evil witch from the storybook. She cursed the main character one time."

"Yeah."

They strode into a corridor. Adora considered the amount of times she attempted to convince her parents. How often had she complained about Shadow Weaver? She lost count at this point. They wouldn't listen to the captain of the royal guard, either. She recalled Angella expressing her concerns.

The way Randor and Marlena responded said everything. They told Angella to be more trusting. The royal couple had fallen for Shadow Weaver's deception.

Adora wished her parents weren't so gullible. How could they be so brainless? She saw firsthand how cruel Shadow Weaver was. Once, she watched the woman threaten a servant for snooping around. No wonder people were afraid of Shadow Weaver.

The king and queen wouldn't believe the story. Perhaps it was because they wanted someone to solve unexplained catastrophes in Grayskull. Why couldn't it be anyone else?

Adora and Adam ascended the stairs. An angry shout prompted them to hide behind statues. The argument wasn't far from their parents' bedroom.

Adora peeked out into the hallway. Randor and Marlena were yelling at Shadow Weaver. The wicked woman flashed a menacing smile. Her hands emitted dark magic.

"What are you doing?" Marlena asked.

"Why are you doing this?" Randor asked.

They backed into the bedroom. Shadow Weaver cackled, unleashing a spell. Adora's body began shaking. It wasn't like when something startled her.

The fear went right into Adora's core. Her lungs tightened, and she wanted to cling to something. Or someone. Any attempt to move her limbs failed. Never before had she been so terrified. It made the nightmares seem like a walk in the garden.

"Shadow Weaver, don't hurt us!"

"You have proven yourself to be a threat to our kingdom!"

The next thing Adora knew, her parents screamed in agony. All she could do was remain frozen and cry. Tears blurred her vision. It was a living nightmare. The captain of the royal guard stepped forward. She glanced at Adora and Adam with concern.

"What happened?" Adora asked.

"Stand behind me. Shadow Weaver is dangerous," Angella said.

Adora and Adam did as they were told. Shadow Weaver emerged from the room. The sorceress glowered at Angella. Silence fell between both women. Adora held her breath. Would Shadow Weaver hurt Angella, too?

"Protecting the brats from me? I bet you're doing this because they remind you of your little girl," Shadow Weaver said. She summoned a dark orb. "Your king and queen are gone. What will you do about it? I will be queen."

"No, you usurper!" Angella charged at Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver blocked the attack. With a wave of her hand, she flung Angella to the wall. Angella rose, grunting. Adora turned her

attention to Adam.

"You run!" Adora shouted. "I'll see Mommy and Daddy!"

"No. We're escaping together," Adam said. He grabbed Adora's hand. "We'll look out for each other."

"Please go." Adora pulled away. "I'll meet you outside."

Adora raced into the bedroom. What she found horrified her. The king and queen lay on the floor, unmoving. They weren't breathing. She crouched next to them and checked their pulses. Nothing. A scream clawed its way out of her throat.

Adora buried her face in her mother's chest. She wanted it to be just a dream. Instead, it was real. Everything in her became numb. Her mind flashed to what she told Adam. He must be waiting by now. The news would devastate him.

Adora made her way into the hallway. A dark mist obscured both sides of the corridor. Dread gripped her heart. She was on the verge of panicking. No one was here to make everything alright. No one came for her. Even Angella didn't save her and Adam. Shadow Weaver loomed over Adora and grabbed her chin. Adora felt so small.

"Hello, dear. I will take care of you. Your parents were weak, and they couldn't stand a chance. They couldn't protect you," Shadow Weaver said. "It's best to forget about them."

"No... I want Mommy and Daddy..." Adora's voice trailed off.

Adora felt as though she relived the memory. Every emotion - fear, grief, loneliness - flooded her body. Similar to a puzzle, the pieces came together. A ball of anger enveloped her heart. She buried her face in her palms. What would life be like if Shadow Weaver never murdered her parents?

Randor and Marlena had tried to keep the kingdom safe. They would do anything for their people. In the end, Shadow Weaver

stole the throne.

If it hadn't happened, would they have punished Shadow Weaver? How far would the royal couple have gone to keep everyone safe? Adora couldn't help but wonder. As Adam spoke, she heard the guilt in his voice. He blamed himself for not taking Adora out of the castle. His voice cracked, and his eyes were watery. Adora rested her palms on his hands.

"Don't blame yourself. Your safety was what mattered," Adora said. "Did Angella... did she help you flee?"

"Yes," Adam said. "She told my adoptive mother to take me somewhere far away."

"Did she try to come back for me?"

"She tried. Shadow Weaver wouldn't let her."

Adora blinked back the tears. "What did Angella do after that?"

"Angella helped my adoptive mother and I escape Gray Haven. Then, we parted ways."

"What's the name of your adoptive mother?"

"Her name's Shakra."

Adora nodded. "Was she loving?"

Adam smiled. "Of course. She was nurturing and kind."

"She took you all the way to Seaworthy Island, didn't she?"

"She did."

Adora's emotions warred within her, fighting to be at the forefront. She knew she could rest easy at night. The answers had come to her. She peeked into Glimmer's eyes. The knight's expression was a mix of concern and anger. Adam's face, on the other hand, was stained with tears. Both individuals waited for Adora to speak.

"This is overwhelming..." Adora whispered. "Almost two decades apart, all because Shadow Weaver desired power..." She made eye contact. "Adam, how did you feel on the way to Seaworthy Island?"

Adam shrugged. "I had nightmares. I'd dream about reaching for your hand and grasping air. Shadow Weaver would show up and drag you into the darkness. I often asked Shakra to find you. She gave me the same answer every time. The pain was too much for me, so I stayed in bed every day. I'd cry until my voice was hoarse."

"How did you handle things as you get older?"

"It became distant in my mind. Still, there were occasional dreams surrounding that day."

"We were so young, weren't we?" Adora swallowed a lump in her throat. "Shadow Weaver tried to make me forget. She used a potion that messed with my memories. Her manipulation and gaslighting added to the mess within my head."

"It's not surprising that she would do it to you."

Glimmer cleared her throat. "I'll make Shadow Weaver pay for what she did."

Adora managed to smile despite her heavy emotions. "Anyway, Glimmer snuck me out of the castle a while ago. She's so protective."

Adam chuckled. "I'm sure she is. And how did she sneak you out?"

"Glimmer signed up to be a knight. We got to know each other. While Shadow Weaver was gone, she led me outside."

"Sounds like a bold move, considering."

"It is." Adora's fingers drummed the table. "Since the escape, Glimmer and I have been on an adventure. We still are. Her childhood friend, Bow, traveled with us. Now he's with Sea Hawk, Teela, and Catra."

"Catra?"

"She's my adoptive sister. One night, Catra entered a secret passage in panther form. I was nine at the time. She found the hidden door to my room. We spent our childhood together."

Adam nodded. "Were you close?"

Adora frowned. "Pretty much. Shadow Weaver favored me over her. Catra hated it. She would confront me over it. After I fled the castle, she tracked my scent. She found us in a village. We argued while I was shopping for a sword. When we got stuck on a dangerous island, she spiraled into a rant."

Glimmer crossed her arms. "Hopefully, Catra's captivity will teach her a lesson."

The Village of the Lost was a desert town. Its residents were rough in terms of personality. Catra was on alert, observing her surroundings.

Teela, Bow, and Sea Hawk tried to interact with some locals. Most of the time, they received a rude word in response. In her human form, she could easily fight multiple at once. She followed the trio to a tavern on the outskirts.

"So far, we got threatened, almost robbed, and cussed at," Bow said. "I'm starting to think it's a bad idea."

"We're not going to give up," Teela said.

Sea Hawk swaggered to the door. "Besides, no one could resist talking to brave pirates!"

"You're the only pirate here."

They all entered the tavern. Groups of people occupied the tables. Some arm-wrestled. Others played board games. A muscular woman rubbed the stains off a cup. A stench wafted into Catra's nose. Was it dried blood or something? She couldn't tell. Sea Hawk stopped in front of the counter. He rested an elbow against the surface.

"Hey, Sea Hawk here. I'm a cool pirate. Searching for a way back to Grayskull," Sea Hawk said.

The woman rubbed the cup harder, scowling. "Why don't you shut up? Your voice is irritating!"

"Usually, women find me charming. Heck, even a mermaid princess fell in love with me!"

"Go away and take your little friends with you."

The bystanders turned to glare at the group. A few advanced. Teela straightened her spine. Catra's fur bristled. Sea Hawk and Bow seemed nervous. A tall woman pushed through the crowd. She wore leather armor and carried a sword. Her white hair was pulled into a tight braid.

"Is this who's causing trouble?" The woman asked. She pointed at Sea Hawk. "I'm Huntara. You don't mess with my gang. The strong makes the rules."

"All I did was talk to the bartender," Sea Hawk said. "We wanted directions."

Teela stepped forward. "We escaped the Horde Clan's clutches. Also, I apologize on Sea Hawk's behalf. He can be arrogant. Do you know how we can get to Grayskull?"

Huntara sheathed her sword. "Yes. I'll be your guide. We'll go to a mountain range."

The warrior led the group out of the Village of the Lost. The desert heat enveloped them as they walked across the sand. Catra hoped they'd find a wagon, which would make the journey quicker.

The Crimson Desert was a harsh landscape, but it was a fitting location for its residents. Sea Hawk began telling stories of an abandoned prison in the desert. According to him, the royal family of Grayskull sent ruthless criminals to that dungeon. Such people awaited trials and executions.

"Vengeful ghosts are haunting the dungeon," Sea Hawk said at some point. "A few could be demons."

"I swear, you always have a story to tell," Teela said.

Bow chuckled. "That's how Sea Hawk is."

Catra paced ahead. She could have added a sarcastic remark in response. Being stuck in panther form prevented that. Throughout her life, she always said whatever came to mind. She didn't care about how her words could affect others.

Maybe the inability to speak was a lesson in disguise. If so, what was there to learn? Although her companions enjoyed bantering, they didn't say hurtful things.

Everyone continued along the path. Later on, the group borrowed a horse-drawn wagon. Its roof offered a much-needed shade. It beat walking across the sunlit desert. Catra peeked out of the wagon. The air shimmered with heat. In the distance, a round structure with arches rose above the sand dunes.

Grayskull's emblem sat atop the spires. Was this what Sea Hawk talked about? Where did he hear stories of most places? Did someone tell him? Regardless, his tales were dramatic.

Catra scrutinized the winding sand dunes. Rocks, cacti, and tumbleweeds dotted the ground. Birds hovered in the cloudless

sky, flying in circles. Hoofbeats met the sand. Catra's ears twitched as she listened to the chatter.

Bow mentioned seeing Glimmer's aunt in Mystacor Village. He said a woman named Castaspella would figure out Evelyn's curse. The spell had prevented Catra from shapeshifting. Would Castaspella's magic be helpful?

Shadow Weaver fumed with anger. She paced back and forth, muttering. An uprising could begin if she didn't quash all opposition. Catra's group was returning to Grayskull.

Adora had met Adam, the lost prince. Glimmer was planning to break the curse on Salineas. The three girls thought they were clever, didn't they? As for Scorpia, a member of the Horde Clan? What was the warrior thinking?

Shadow Weaver chucked the goblet at the door. It shattered upon impact. But she didn't care enough to react. She wanted to keep her grip tight on political power. It didn't matter how desperate she would become. Letting out a bitter laugh, she stormed into the hallway.

The guards were quick to bow. They probably did it out of fear. Shadow Weaver's cape swished behind her as she entered the throne room. Dozens of subjects waited to have an audience with the queen.

Glaring at them, Shadow Weaver occupied the throne. The people bowed and curtsied in response. Some whispered about how they had it better under Queen Marlena's reign. They also discussed King Randor being a good ruler. A woman approached the steps to the throne and curtsied.

"Your Majesty, can you please lower the taxes?" The woman asked.

"Why should I?" Shadow Weaver replied. Then, she huffed out a mirthless chortle. "Oh, I see why. You assumed everything was

perfect before I took over. Well, guess what? The late king and queen never cared about anything but ancient legends. They wanted a hero to rise up and save the kingdom."

"Queen Shadow Weaver, take my request into consideration. My spouse had to work hard to make ends meet. A single loaf of cheap bread won't satisfy us."

"You're one of the peasants, aren't you? Be content with your place. And don't question my reign. After all, you're not dying."

"You're cruel."

The woman left the throne room in a rush. Shadow Weaver beckoned a farmer forward. He wore a dirt-covered tunic. Those who questioned her rule wouldn't receive help. Were people getting sick of her? Should she put the citizens in their place again? They should know better.

"Your Majesty-" The farmer began.

"What?" Shadow Weaver interrupted.

"I couldn't afford to buy more cows and sheep. Why must everything go up in price?"

"You want an answer? Because the kingdom has forgotten to submit to my rule. Everyone needs to obey."

Shadow Weaver rehashed the explanation to everyone else. Many of them left, acting disappointed. A few discussed unrest in their villages. Of course, there was conflict in Grayskull. It wasn't surprising. The peasants would beg, and she would ignore them. They brought it upon themselves. By evening, she strode to the war room.

A map of Grayskull blanketed the table. It included the kingdom's boundary, marked by mountains. Beyond the boundary, there was a desert and an ocean.

The islands were distant from Grayskull's shores. The Isle of Beasts, Seaworthy Island, and others. Outside the kingdom, there were independent communities.

Shadow Weaver pored over the map. Those societies wouldn't be independent for long. A door swung open, revealing Hordak.

"Any more reports from the Horde Clan?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"I have dismissed Scorpia for letting the captives escape," Hordak said.

"Is it temporary or permanent?"

"It's temporary, with a warning. Though, I doubt Scorpia will learn from her shortcomings." Hordak moved a small figurine over the map. "The clan may set up another fortress. Currently, it's near the size of an army. New recruits have joined us."

"I agree with what you said about Scorpia." Shadow Weaver picked up a figurine. "We could start a war within the kingdom. We've seen how people react to civil unrest. They become afraid, stressed, and paranoid. They question the loyalties of others. In the end, they will learn to rely on me."

"You mean us."

"I am the ruler, not you." Shadow Weaver cocked her head. Her eye contact was direct and probing. "You will be wise to let me handle kingdom matters."

"Still, every kingdom needs armies."

Shadow Weaver shook her head. "The chance of an uprising within Grayskull is too high. This isn't the time for half-measures."

Hordak balled his hands into fists. "What will be the best course of action, then?"

"There are options. We could order the clan's sorcerers to curse the citizens. Or, we could instigate panic over a disease. We'll quarantine the peasants and separate them. As for the rich, we'll order them to avoid the lower classes. Any resistance shall be met with swift punishment."

"The citizens will use it as another reason to defy us. Are you sure about it?"

"Every village has guards that will enforce the regulations."

"How about self-governed towns?"

"I'll have the soldiers take care of the issue." Shadow Weaver rested her palms against the table. "Soon, we'll make our move. Once the kingdom descends into chaos, we'll remind them to look to us."

"Yes, Queen Shadow Weaver."

Hordak strode out of the room. Shadow Weaver smirked, imagining the plan and its results. She would manipulate the people into living in fear. A question lingered. How would Adora and the rebels react to this? Would they remain stubborn?

Sea Serpents and Strategies

Glimmer and Adora followed Mermista to the shore. The mermaid gave them seashell necklaces. Mermista said they would help the duo breathe and see underwater. The three women waded into the water. Mermista's legs transformed into a tail.

Glimmer and Adora exchanged glances before diving underwater. Delicate corals waved as fish swam around them. Faint rays of light spilled through the water's surface. Patches of colorful plants dotted the sea floor.

A silhouette of a castle came into view. Unlike the one in Grayskull, it seemed to be made for merfolk. Mermista led Glimmer and Adora past the castle.

Spires lined the deepest part of the ocean. Several merpeople spoke to Mermista. They were carrying spears. Were they guards? Mermista told them she would explore the Seabed Caverns with Glimmer and Adora.

"Be careful," one of the guards said.

"We will," Mermista replied.

"There is a darkness infecting the Seabed Caverns."

"I'm aware of that, sheesh."

Glimmer grabbed Adora's hand and followed Mermista to the cave's entrance. A pile of boulders blocked it. Mermista extended a hand, palm facing the rocks.

One by one, Mermista removed the rocks with telekinesis. The trio swam to the opening and entered. The tunnel wound around. Sometimes, they encountered octopus-like monsters. Other creatures resembled shells the size of tables. There were one-eyed snakes and skeleton fish.

They made their way into a den that wasn't underwater. Stalactites hung from the ceiling. Glimmer conjured a light spell, illuminating the area. Her footsteps echoed off the walls.

Adora and Mermista caught up to Glimmer. Were there similar chambers? Or was this the only one? The trio approached a circular door. Glimmer rolled it to the side, revealing an adjacent room.

"It's no different than exploring Plumeria Sanctuary," Adora commented.

"This one has water," Glimmer said.

"Yeah. Maybe it's a maze, too."

They descended the steps from the ledge to the puddle of water. Snakes slithered across the puddle, creating ripples. One of them leaped at Glimmer. On instinct, she swung the sword, slicing it. The sight of venomous fangs lingered in her mind. At least the snakes were easy to slay. She led Mermista and Adora to a walkway along the wall.

"If the cave is underwater, why are some parts not?" Adora asked.

"The Seabed Caverns has always been this way," Mermista said. "There's a pool connected to it. It's the source of the merpeople's magic. We call it the 'moon water.' Each lunar phase has different effects."

Glimmer stepped onto the walkway. "What happens if the source is gone or destroyed?"

"The Kingdom of Salineas will perish as a result."

"Under the curse, how much time does the kingdom have left?"

Mermista paced ahead. "Not a lot. We must make haste if we want to save the merfolk."

The women raced through the door and began ascending the staircase. Once they reached the next floor, an octopus emerged from the water. Its snout expelled electrical spheres.

Glimmer shoved Adora and Mermista out of the way. The spheres exploded upon meeting the wall. Its eyes observed their movements. Glimmer deflected the next orb with an air spell. It returned to the octopus, electrocuting the creature. She plunged the sword into its eyes.

Glimmer repeated the actions until the octopus dissolved into black ichor. Its remains tainted the water. A wooden chest idled by the wall. The knight teleported over to see what was inside. A key, as it turned out. She stashed it in her bag. Mermista and Adora closed the distance between themselves and Glimmer.

"You found a key?" Mermista asked.

"I did," Glimmer said.

Adora's hand went to her hilt. "I admire your fighting skills. However, I want to help out. Can you give me a chance?"

"I could."

"Really?"

Glimmer strode to the door. "Yes."

The trio sprinted into a corridor. On either side of the tiled floor, Glimmer glimpsed purple water. It emitted a stench. Some tiles moved. Was it a trick of the eye? Or was something lurking? Before anyone could continue, Mermista held up a hand.

"Watch your step, girls," Mermista said. "I saw something. And the water? It's infected with a poisonous substance."

"No wonder it's an unusual color," Glimmer replied.

They proceeded, avoiding the traps and poisonous water. The trio made their way to the next door. A lock and chains blocked it. Glimmer pressed the key into the hole. With a click, the lock and chains fell.

The women continued, unhindered. Passageways twisted and turned. Underwater tunnels were teeming with monsters. Glimmer and her friends disposed of them with ease.

The deeper they went, the darker it became. It was unsettling. What would the visibility be like in the final room? The last tunnel was cramped, with wet walls and slippery floors. Glimmer, Adora, and Mermista stumbled into a chamber. A stone chest idled in the center. It had intricate carvings.

"It's where we stored the huge key," Mermista said. "We need to destroy the sea serpent and break the curse."

"Alright. Let's open the chest," Glimmer replied.

The trio placed their hands on the curved lid. Their fingers sunk into the gap. With their combined strength and effort, they opened the chest. They pulled out the key. It was half the size of a table. Mermista led the way as they carried the key. The hallway opened up to a descending staircase. A towering door waited for them. They could hear growls from the other side.

"The sea serpent could be anticipating our arrival," Mermista said. "Girls, are you ready for the dangerous battle?"

"Of course," Glimmer replied.

Adora stared at the door. "Here goes nothing."

"Let's save Salineas together."

They plunged the key into the lock. There was a brief whir of gears before it fell. The chains swung to the sides. With a deep breath, the trio entered a vast den. In the center, a pond of water idled. It was murky. Something about it didn't seem normal.

An elongated silhouette drew closer to the surface. Bubbles formed. A growl echoed off the walls. Glimmer adopted a wide stance. Mermista and Adora did, too. A serpent's head emerged, baring its fangs.

Glimmer and Adora leaped out of the way. Mermista lunged at a tentacle and yanked it. The sea serpent snapped at Mermista. Glimmer hurled a fireball at the monster. Its mouth opened at the perfect moment, allowing the fireball to enter. It roared in agony as it dove into the water. More bubbles materialized.

"Watch out, Adora!" Mermista shouted.

Glimmer whirled around. A tentacle grabbed Adora and dragged her toward the pond. Glimmer charged forward. Her sword gashed the tentacle. Adora broke free, trembling. More tentacles sprung at the group. Glimmer wrapped her arms around Adora's waist and teleported. They reappeared by a rock pillar. The blonde seemed dizzy.

"I haven't done that to someone before," Glimmer said, referring to the teleport.

Adora composed herself. "Can you warn me next time?"

"Yeah."

A scream drilled into Glimmer's ears. A tentacle pulled Mermista toward the sea serpent's mouth. Glimmer launched another fireball. It caught the beast by surprise. Mermista dropped into the water. Her legs merged into a tail.

"Follow my lead, princess," Glimmer told Adora.

Glimmer and Adora lunged at the tentacles and sliced them. The limbs retracted into the water. The sea serpent snapped at them. They dodged. Glimmer unleashed the stasis spell, freezing the head. With several swings, her sword gashed its snout. Adora joined in, landing a few hits. The monster freed itself from the spell. The rest of its body emerged.

"It's not giving in," Mermista pointed out.

A tentacle snaked around Adora and chucked her at a stalactite. A wave of anger washed over Glimmer. She used a fire spell on her sword. Glaring up at the sea serpent, she readied herself.

"Leave Adora alone!" Glimmer spat as she charged at the beast.

In swift motions, Glimmer expelled a series of fiery blasts from her sword. The sea serpent bellowed as each impact drove it back. She dismembered the tentacles. She rammed her weapon into the beast's chest. Pulling out the blade, she watched the monster collapse. She raced to check on Adora. The princess appeared to be in pain, reclining on the ground.

"Adora, are you okay?" Glimmer asked as she helped Adora up.

"It hurts," Adora said, groaning. "Are you and Mermista done fighting that thing?"

Mermista approached the sea serpent. "I guess so."

Before the women could celebrate, the sea serpent rose. Mermista backed away. It snapped at her. Glimmer ran, holding up her sword. She attacked the sea serpent without sparing a second. The moment the beast fell, she beheaded it. Within seconds, it disintegrated into black smoke.

"Let's find the moon water," Mermista said. "Glimmer, you saved Salineas. Thank you."

"Adora helped," Glimmer replied.

Adora limped over to Glimmer. "It was an intense battle. Glim, you're so courageous."

Mermista and the duo walked to a pool chamber. Its roof had a circular hole. Moonlight streamed through, highlighting the crystal clear water. Glimmer and Adora couldn't help but admire the beauty of this place. Rocks and gems glittered. Mermista placed a

shell onto a display. Like Perfuma in Plumeria sanctuary, Mermista honored the water spirits. A translucent woman appeared.

"Princess of Salineas, the heroine has broken the curse," the spirit said. "Because of her bravery, Salineas is free."

"Of course. Is there a quick way out of Seabed Caverns?" Mermista replied.

"There is." A pond materialized by the wall. "You may now return to your people."

"Thank you."

Mermista led Glimmer and Adora underwater. A series of tunnels later, they emerged. They swam to the castle. A crowd of merpeople gathered in the throne room. Mermista descended onto the throne.

"Glimmer and Adora, a pair of heroines, broke the curse. They slayed the sea serpent. The source of our magic is safe," Mermista explained.

The merpeople cheered. Within minutes, they held a celebration. Glimmer and Adora observed from a distance. By the end of the celebration, they began swimming to Seaworthy Island.

At some point, Glimmer noticed Adora lagging behind. She took her hand and pulled her to the surface. A canopy of stars hung in the sky. She glanced at the princess.

"I can't wait to get into bed," Adora said.

"We'll need to dry off first," Glimmer replied.

They reached the shore. Adora reclined on the sand. Glimmer lay next to her. Silence fell between them. Battling a sea serpent had drained their energy. Glimmer shivered from the dry chill. She moved closer to Adora and hugged her. They didn't care about the sand clinging to their hair and clothes. At this moment, they

wanted to celebrate their victory without words. Then, Adora spoke.

"Should we return to Grayskull?" Adora asked.

"We'll figure it out in the morning," Glimmer said.

"Yeah... right..."

Glimmer tucked a strand behind Adora's ear. "We could rest before taking another journey on the ship."

Adora's cheeks pinkened. "That'll be nice."

They stood. Glimmer helped Adora walk through the jungle. Vines dangled from the palm trees. The undergrowth crunched beneath their feet. The warm, wet air greeted them. A scent of plants lingered in the air. The duo wandered along the trail. A boundary came into view.

"Almost there," Glimmer said.

They strode into town. Street torches illuminated the cobblestone paths. An occasional carriage rolled down the street. Glimmer and Adora ambled to a two-story house. Adam had told them it was where he lived. The door opened, revealing an aged woman.

"You're Shakra, right? Adam's adoptive mother?" Adora asked.

"Yes. And you're Adam's sister?" Shakra replied.

"He still lives with you?"

"He does. Nowadays, he helps me with things. Do you need a place to stay? We have a guest room."

"We do. Thanks for your offer."

"It's on the first floor."

Once inside, Glimmer and Adora walked into a guest room. They changed their clothes, slipping into clean ones. Adora plopped onto the bed. Glimmer joined her in bed. There was nothing like the feel of a soft mattress after a battle. Images of the water and the Seabed Caverns remained vivid. The sea serpent put up quite a fight.

"We did it," Adora whispered. Her eyes were half-closed.

"We make a great team," Glimmer said.

Within three weeks, Catra's group arrived in Grayskull. They went to Mystacor Village. They were now visiting Castaspella. The older woman told stories of Glimmer's parents. From what Catra had gathered, the couple defied Shadow Weaver. Angella was the knight, and Micah was the sorcerer. Then, Castaspella and Bow discussed the curse on Catra.

"Evelyn, the sorceress in the Horde Clan, used that spell on Catra. It prevented Catra from transforming into her human form," Bow said.

"The sorceress who walked down the same path as Shadow Weaver did?" Castaspella replied. "She hasn't tried to hurt you or your friends, has she?"

"She mostly insulted us while holding us hostage. Evelyn taunted Catra."

The mention of the taunting made Catra recall her captivity. A flash of fury shot through her heart. A hiss escaped her snout. Evelyn wasn't the first sorceress to use dark magic on her. Sure, not all of them were horrible. However, she knew what they were capable of. Castaspella spoke to Catra as she conjured a spell. Eventually, the magic took effect.

Catra transformed. She sensed her body changing. She had almost forgotten how it felt - the cracking of bones, the tearing of muscles, and the insides shifting. Once in her human form, she

sat up. Castaspella and the others gave her a brief glance. The dark-haired woman's expression stood out. She seemed curious.

"You resemble someone I knew," Castaspella said.

"Someone you know?" Catra asked.

"Yes."

"Who is it?"

"Her name's Bastet. Her family and friends were passionate about freedom."

"Can you tell me more about her?"

Castaspella nodded. "She was there when Angella tried to recruit people into the resistance. They met after Angella quit her position as the captain of the royal guard. Bastet was married to a woman named Tabby."

Catra rested her palms on her knees. "Were they shapeshifters?"

"They were. One day, the Horde Clan raided their village and set their homes on fire. They lost their lives. There were rumors of their child escaping in panther form."

Catra thought of her suppressed memories. "Was it ten years ago?"

"I believe it is. Do you know anything about it? Had someone told you?"

"I have no idea. I did lose my family at a young age." Catra rose to her height. "Can I be alone?"

Castaspella stepped back. "Sure."

Catra strode to a quieter part of the house. She stared out the window. Taking deep breaths, she let the memories come to her.

They started with her childhood. The images were unclear at best. She let them pass through her mind...

A young brunette girl raced through the village. Catra was playing tag with the neighboring children. It was a beautiful day. The sun shone. The birds chirped. Everyone basked in the warm air. A breeze whistled around the tree trunks. One of the children grabbed Catra. They fell to the grass. It was a girl.

"Your turn!" The girl said.

"I'll get you next time," Catra replied, giggling.

"Why don't you run faster, then?"

Catra proceeded to chase her, laughing. Her foot met a log, and she fell forward. She forced herself up and brushed the dirt off her limbs. Leaves crunched beneath footsteps. She looked up. A woman with braided autumn hair wore a stern expression. It was Tabby, her mother. Usually, the woman's face was gentle.

"Catra, I just gave you a bath this morning. Now I had to do it again," Tabby said, shaking her head.

"I was playing tag with them," Catra said.

"I could tell. Anyway, let's go inside the house."

Catra obeyed. After several minutes of walking, they entered a cottage. Her other mother, Bastet, practiced sword-fighting. She halted as she watched her. It would be awesome to become a warrior someday. Like Bastet, she would use the sword to defend those who couldn't defend themselves. And if she didn't wield a weapon, she could fight enemies in panther form.

Bastet sheathed her sword. She made her way to the bench. Tabby sat next to her. Both women embraced each other, whispering. Catra was about to say something when a distant scream garnered their attention. Bastet and Tabby hurried

outside. Catra's curiosity led her to the dirt road. More shouts startled her. Felina, her aunt, sprinted to Bastet's side.

"The Horde Clan is burning homes and attacking people!" Felina said.

"We'll push the clan out of the village," Bastet said, drawing her sword. She turned her attention to Tabby. "Take Catra to safety."

Tabby held Bastet's hand. "What about you, my love? I know you can take care of yourself. However, I don't want us to wind up separated."

Dozens of people with capes vandalized the cottages. Fires consumed the walls and roofs. Innocent locals screamed as they ran back and forth. Others tried to attack their enemies. Blood splattered across the ground, staining the grass.

Many individuals collapsed. Their bodies became still, shouts fading to silence. Tabby gripped Catra's hand and ran to the outskirts. Flames rose into the sky, emitting clouds of smoke. A stranger shot arrows at Tabby.

"Mommy!" Catra wailed.

Tabby fell to her side. Somehow, she maintained the strength to speak. "Catra, run!"

"But-" Hot tears moistened Catra's cheeks.

"Go!"

Catra took one last peek before transforming into a panther. She ran as fast as possible. The young shapeshifter dove into a bush. Gazing at the burning village, she let out a whine. Where should she go? What happened to her mothers? She hid in the bush for what seemed like forever. The sun began approaching the horizon.

Catra galloped along the dirt path. She didn't have a particular destination in mind. A moat came into view. So did a wall of stone. Panting, she crossed a drawbridge. A guard shouted. Her heart raced, and she frantically searched for a way out of this situation. Then, she noticed a hole near the stone barrier. She jumped into the opening, wiggling her body through.

Upon emerging on the other side, Catra found herself in a vast yard. She remained close to the hedge, avoiding the guards. Another opening, and she raced into it. Now, she was in a dim passageway. A narrow stream of water flowed in no specific direction. She followed it to a set of metal bars. If it was inside the building, where did the liquid originate from?

Could Catra stay in the passageway? Or would there be a risk of discovery? Distant voices prompted her ears to perk up. Someone was coming. She sprung to a ledge and darted into an adjacent corridor. Within an hour, she had climbed stairs, shuffled across ropes, and reached dead ends. Despite her exhaustion, she didn't stop.

The rest of the memory came to a conclusion. Catra's cheeks were wet from tears. She remembered befriending Adora. During her grieving process, she gained a sister. As soon as she did, Shadow Weaver drove a wedge between them.

The old sorceress had given Adora special treatment. Out of the same mouth, she condemned Catra. Isolation was Shadow Weaver's main tactic. Through manipulation, she had convinced Adora to stay inside.

Shadow Weaver didn't do the same thing with Catra. It always seemed odd to the shapeshifter. The sorceress was the same woman who loathed Catra. Sighing, she peeked over her shoulder. In the other room, Bow still chatted with Castaspella. So did Teela and Sea Hawk. She thought of Scorpia. The woman had been kind to help them escape. Huntara, on the other hand, was gruff.

Catra figured it came with being an outlaw. The Village of the Lost had an abundance of those people. She sat in a chair. Then, she rested her jaw on her palms. She had taken the kindness of others for granted. The wall around her heart did more harm than good. She listened to the chatter. The topic must have been significant. At the mention of Shadow Weaver, Catra rose. She made her way to where the others were.

"A war has started within the Kingdom of Grayskull," Castaspella said.

"Is there any way to alert Adora and Glimmer?" Bow asked.

"I've used the location spell. Adora and Glimmer will arrive in a few days."

Teela leaned against the wall. "Are they the only ones on the road?"

"Someone has accompanied them. I guess it's Adora's twin sibling. Similar facial features, blonde hair."

"Is it a man?"

"Yes."

"I think I know that person. His name's Adam." Teela placed a hand on her hip. "When are we putting an end to Shadow Weaver's tyranny? Does the resistance need to be big? They say there's strength in numbers."

Bow shrugged. "We could be facing major opposition."

Sea Hawk flashed his signature smile. "The heroes of old succeeded despite all odds. If they can do it, we can."

Catra cleared her throat. "Yeah, and what happened to Angella's resistance group?"

Castaspella made eye contact. "They tried their best. However, it didn't work out for them."

"Was there any strategy involved?"

"I'm not sure. There was a heavy focus on freeing the kingdom."

It made Catra wonder if the group had charged in without a plan. Sure, they tried to defend others. But the enemies must have taken advantage of a weakness. People who were loyal to Shadow Weaver were ruthless. Catra stroked her chin, listening to the discussion. Each individual suggested an idea. There had to be something...

Realization dawned on Catra. She knew the layout of the passageways. There were multiple entrances and exits. Her companions could take down defenses from within.

Lured Back into Shadows

A week passed. Adora, Glimmer, and Adam arrived in Mystacor Village. The hooves met cobblestone with each step. Clouds blocked the sunlight. The crisp mountain air enveloped the trio. Adora and her companions led Kali, Artemis, and Star to the stables.

Glimmer's hometown was peaceful compared to the villages out there. The people in other towns seemed to live in fear. They were worked up over some 'disease.' In one village, the guards resorted to locking people in their houses.

It was crazy. The kingdom was divided over one issue. Adora and the others entered Glimmer's house. Bow, Sea Hawk, Teela, and Catra greeted them. The knight's aunt, Castaspella, joined in. Afterward, Adam proceeded to talk with Teela. Bow, Sea Hawk, and Castaspella went outside. Adora, Glimmer, and Catra gathered by the window.

"How did you and the others escape Evelyn?" Adora asked.

"A Horde Clan member helped us. Her name's Scorpia," Catra explained. "Adora, I'm sorry if I've hurt you in the past."

"I appreciate the apology if it's genuine. Does Glimmer get one, too?"

"Yes." Catra looked at Glimmer. "I'm sorry for taunting you about your abilities."

Glimmer pushed her hands into her pockets. "Promise me you won't do it again."

"I'll try not to."

"You better keep the promise."

Catra stepped back. "I'll do my best. Anyway, Bow and our friends came up with a plan. If it goes well, we could defeat Shadow Weaver."

The shapeshifter told Adora and Glimmer about the plan. It was detailed and sounded logical. Then, Adora realized something. What part would she and her brother play? What would Glimmer be doing? Would there be a flaw in the strategy?

"We'll think about it," Adora said.

"Don't you want to take back your kingdom?" Catra asked.

"I do. It's just that..." Adora's voice trailed off. "Are there alternatives?"

"We have warriors who use swords and magic. My panther form is agile and fast. Another benefit of being a panther? I could pin someone down, preventing them from escaping."

"Shadow Weaver is a sorceress. You're not."

"We have Glimmer and Castaspella."

Adora tapped her foot. "We can't lose anyone else." She paced back and forth. "Shadow Weaver murdered my parents. The Horde Clan captured Bow, Sea Hawk, and Teela. They could have died. What if we fail the kingdom?"

Adora spiraled into a rant, talking about every outcome. Each one was worse than the last. Her heart palpitated as she hyperventilated. Her mind went blank. Bile rose in her throat. She occupied a chair and buried her face in her trembling hands. Someone put a hand on her shoulder. It was Glimmer. The knight was comforting her.

"Adora, breathe. It's okay," Glimmer said.

"I don't want something happening to you guys," Adora said.

"Still, we need to take action. We won't let fear paralyze us."

"You're right. But we can't do anything drastic." Adora stood. "Where's your room?"

"Upstairs. Why do you ask?"

"I want to lay down."

"I'll take you upstairs."

Adora and Glimmer ascended the stairs. Once in the bedroom, they reclined on Glimmer's bed. Throughout their friendship, they became used to sleeping together. Holding hands and hugging were normal, too. Some people assumed they were a couple.

Adora wasn't sure if she wanted the friendship to change. Her eyes fluttered shut. Fatigue blanketed her body, and she rolled to her side. She drifted into dreamland...

Adora was standing in the middle of the throne room. Impenetrable darkness lurked in the doorways and windows. The latter had cracks in them. A chill settled in the air. Shadows stretched along the walls, climbing to the ceiling. Red eyes gleamed in the blackness. Whispers echoed, sending chills up her spine. Who was speaking? Shadow Weaver?

Adora patted her clothes for a weapon. She had nothing on her. And why was she wearing a dress with a corset? What happened to her adventuring outfit? A tall figure materialized in front of the throne. The grand doors swung open, and her friends charged in. The next thing she knew, Shadow Weaver grabbed Glimmer's neck.

The knight's legs dangled as she struggled to free herself. She turned her attention to Adora. Glimmer said something inaudible. Adora's nails dug into her palms. She wanted to do something, yet her feet wouldn't move.

"Don't hurt her," Adora said in a shaky voice. "Let Glimmer go. Please stop hurting her!"

"No amount of begging will prevent me from doing what needs to be done," Shadow Weaver said.

"Please, no!"

Glimmer fell to the floor, unconscious. Adora descended to her knees, sobbing. She couldn't protect her knight. Glowering at Shadow Weaver, she expected her to do her worst. However, nothing came. Everything went black.

Adora's eyes flung open, and she took a sharp breath. Her mind took a moment to catch up. Her heart hammered her ribs. Next to her, Glimmer stirred. The knight was alive. They were safe. Glimmer caressed Adora's cheek.

"Adora, I'm here," Glimmer said. Her thumb stroked Adora's jawline. "Is it a nightmare?"

"Yes. It's about Shadow Weaver," Adora said. "She was killing you. It felt real."

"I'm still alive. It won't become a reality."

"But she's powerful."

"It won't stop me from battling Shadow Weaver to the death."

Death. There was that word again. Adora had no desire to consider it. She preferred to solve the issue on her own. She would march into the castle by herself, then confront Shadow Weaver. Her friends would be safe. The royal twins would take back the throne. They could worry about the Horde Prime situation later.

Adora rolled to her back. Would it go according to plan? What if her friends intervened? What if Shadow Weaver outsmarted her? A hand wrapped around Adora's fingers.

"Adora..." Glimmer squeezed Adora's hand. "We'll do it together. You, me, and our friends."

"I hope everything goes well," Adora said. "Sheer luck may not be on our side."

"It's why some of us figured out a plan."

"You mean Catra's idea." Adora stared at the ceiling. "The only reason she brought it up is the castle layout."

"It wouldn't have been smart to just charge in," Glimmer said. "The guards would be attacking within seconds."

"It's what Catra said, huh?"

"She knows where the hallways, rooms, and entry points are."

"So do I." Adora buried her fingers in her hair. "I don't like discussing this. Anyway, I'm glad I met my brother on Seaworthy Island." She rested her palms on her abdomen. "He's kind and a great sibling. A certain shapeshifter, on the other hand..."

Glimmer snaked an arm around Adora's waist. "I get that you're frustrated with Catra. For now, let's see if her actions match her words."

Shadow Weaver scoffed, glaring at the crystal ball. No obstacle seemed to discourage Adora's group. Even nightmares were useless. At least the tension between Adora and Catra remained. It was something.

The plan was to isolate Adora and make her come home. Shadow Weaver couldn't care less about Adam and Catra. The hours trickled by. She wandered to the war room. Raindrops streamed down the windows. Papers cluttered the table. They were detailed notes about future strategies.

All of it meant nothing. It wouldn't convince Adora to return home. What would make her cave in? Shadow Weaver thought of the blonde's friendships.

The one closest to Adora was Glimmer. The crystal ball had shown moments of them acting cozy. Sometimes, they behaved like a couple. No one could deny how much Adora trusted Glimmer. It was where Shadow Weaver could start.

Shadow Weaver strode to a hall filled with paintings. She glimpsed countless portraits of the royal family. One displayed a sitting Randor and Marlena. They were holding a younger Adam and Adora. The twins wore soft grins. Their calm countenances belied all the trouble they caused. How did children manage to appear sweet and innocent in paintings? During her time as an advisor, the twins were out of control.

Even in Adam's absence, Shadow Weaver had a nursemaid watch over Adora. Catra came into the picture within two years. Both girls made the nursemaid's job harder. They often slipped in and out of passageways. Why did they find it fun? How many times had Shadow Weaver told them to quit it? The two were now older. They were running around with Angella's daughter. Glimmer must have been persuasive.

Shadow Weaver's fingertips brushed the painting. She narrowed her eyes at Marlena's smiling face. The former queen always acted soft and innocent. Randor was idealistic and foolish. No wonder they were weak and ineffective.

Shadow Weaver was often the one ending unexplained catastrophes. The Horde Clan instigated such events. She helped them organize those disasters under the guise of protecting Grayskull.

"You fell for my deception," Shadow Weaver whispered. "Somehow, your daughter discovered the truth. What a rebellious little princess. I won't allow her to steal the throne."

Shadow Weaver made her way into the hallway. Within a half hour, she stepped into her room. She opened the trunk and took out a journal. It belonged to Randor and Marlena. Adora must have found the book at some point. It was on the same night Adora snuck out. Wasn't it?

Shadow Weaver read the entries. The later ones implied the writer started suspecting things. The paragraphs mentioned Marlena's intuition. Marlena had also spoken to Angella. Shadow Weaver remembered the days leading up to the usurpation...

The conversation in the tea room had been irritating for the adviser. Shadow Weaver ambled to the courtyard. She gritted her teeth. Queen Marlena's questions had agitated her. Offering the same answer to each query? They didn't make the queen shut up. Nothing could.

A few feet away, a pair of children laughed. Those twins? Again? There was never a dull moment for those brats. They found everything entertaining.

Shadow Weaver closed the distance between herself and the twins. Adora and Adam stared with wide eyes. Their faces blanched. It was amusing how they went quiet at the sight of her.

"Will you brats tone it down?" Shadow Weaver demanded.

Tears glistened in their eyes. Adora and Adam wailed for their parents. It didn't take long for Marlena to approach. The queen took their hands. Shadow Weaver expected Marlena to accuse her. Marlena's nose wrinkled. Her upper lip curled.

"They did nothing wrong," Marlena said. "They're children."

"The twins are behaving like wild animals!" Shadow Weaver retorted.

"Even if they do, they won't be little forever. Someday, one of them will rule the kingdom. No matter how old or young they are, they deserve kindness."

"Wait until they grow up without manners." Shadow Weaver crossed her arms. "It'll be a shame for a future ruler to act immature."

"You know what? The conversation's over. One more thing - don't bother my children. You've scared them enough."

Shadow Weaver stormed into the castle. She wished Marlena would stop following her around. Didn't the queen have better things to do? In the hallway, the captain of the royal guard hindered her. Angella unsheathed the sword.

"I'm not the bad guy here," Shadow Weaver said.

"Oh, really? Micah told me about what you did as his former teacher," Angella replied.

"You and Micah are as blind as Norwyn and the others." Shadow Weaver pushed past Angella. "Can you not bring up my choice?"

Angella shook her head. "You may have fooled some with the 'good sorceress' act, but I know it's a facade. You're a murderer and a manipulator. And worst of all? You've made it no secret how much you hate children!"

Shadow Weaver arched her brow. "You want me to be the bad guy? Fine."

"I'll defend the royal family from you."

"Your response doesn't surprise me. After all, you're as self-righteous as the others."

"Your wickedness will be your downfall."

Shadow Weaver carried the journal to a sitting room. The fireplace emitted heat into the air. Its flames licked the logs. She chucked the book into the fire. The embers chewed up every page.

Randor and Marlena should have been forgotten by now. However, people continued remembering them. Shadow Weaver returned to her bedroom and gathered items that belonged to the deceased couple. Letters, documents, and portraits met their end in the flames.

Adora's freedom would come to an end. Shadow Weaver rushed to the balcony. The cool air settled around her. It was a contrast to the sitting room's temperature. Her cloak swayed to the side. Strands of black hair clung to her face. It was satisfying to discard some possessions. It would please her if Adora submits.

"It's time I get your attention," Shadow Weaver said. At the last word, she unleashed an illusion spell. Her 'spies' would pretend to be those Adora knew. Through the spell, she would isolate the princess.

Adora awakened in the morning. She joined Glimmer and Castaspella during breakfast. As they ate, they discussed the fate of Grayskull. Outside the window, a silhouette caught her attention. However, Glimmer and Castaspella didn't notice. The specter vanished as soon as it showed up. What was the apparition doing?

After everyone cleaned up the kitchen, Adora walked outside. She rubbed her arms despite the warmth of her sleeves. So far, nothing seemed off. The stress could be getting to her. Was there a place to relax and get her mind off things?

Adora meandered along the cobblestone path. Subtle footsteps followed her to an alley. Her gaze swept over her shoulder. No one was here. Was her imagination playing tricks on her?

"Adora has started acting paranoid, hasn't she? She has lost it," a familiar voice said.

"Yeah. Adora stared into empty space. She didn't talk to anyone," another speaker replied.

"Why did we take her out of the castle, then?"

Adora sprinted out of the alley. "Hey! I'm not crazy!"

Oddly enough, Adora didn't see anyone. The townspeople went about their day. Was she losing her mind? No, she had to think. The nightmares had tormented her last night.

Adora had struggled with a panic attack. Sighing, she made her way to a fountain. The water rippled, as did her reflection. A hooded figure materialized behind her.

"I didn't expect you to become a fool. You befriended the people I warned you about. Disappointing. Did they believe you could snatch the throne? Or were they toying with you? They're not impressed by your naivety," the stranger said.

"I'm not a fool," Adora muttered.

"Oh, so now you know best? Is it how it is now? All of them had deceived you. Watch how fast they'll leave. I won't say I told you so. Don't come crying when they betray you."

"It won't happen. My friends are loyal. Especially Glimmer."

"Your knight? More like your nightmare!"

The hooded individual disappeared. Whoever it was, they were wrong. Adora knew Glimmer and their friend group. Glimmer, Bow, and the others wouldn't hurt her. Within minutes, the knight approached. Glimmer pressed her lips into a thin line.

"Is everything alright?" Adora asked.

"I could have asked you the same thing this morning," Glimmer said. "However, I decided against it when you pulled the 'miss independent' act."

"Glimmer, I-"

"I thought you trusted us. You just wanted to tag along for the heck of it. It was all because you were bored and discontent."

"Glimmer, what are you talking about? You were the one who offered a way out. You helped me flee the castle. Have I done something to upset you?"

"Maybe you should forget the entire thing. It was a waste of time." Glimmer stormed off. "We're done!"

Adora hung her head. Had she used Glimmer and their friends as a mode of transportation? Would they turn against her today? With a heavy heart, she shuffled to the outskirts.

Adora had grown close to Glimmer during the adventure. Was it all for nothing? Memories of the journey flashed through her mind. Glimmer had been loyal to her, no matter what. So, what did Adora do? What made it change?

Adora analyzed every memory of the adventure. None of them stood out. Even her recollections were unreliable. Unaware of where she was going, she tripped over a log. She forced herself up and paced into the woods. Phantom fingers brushed her shoulder. The hairs on her neck bristled.

"Adora..." A voice whispered.

Adora gasped as she whirled around. Her heart leaped into her throat. An urge to run to town overwhelmed her. Her friends would ignore her. She dashed into a clearing. There was no one to turn to. She was a burden to everyone around her. Someone approached. It was Bow.

"What are you waiting for? Go away!" Bow demanded.

The words stung. Adora bit her bottom lip. "I'm so sorry. I take full responsibility for whatever I did."

"Everything that will happen is your fault. You're to blame."

Before Adora could respond, Bow left. She kicked at a rock. All around her, the area darkened. Thick, black fog obscured her view of the distance. What was going on? A feminine silhouette towered over her. Its hand pressed against her cheek.

"Have you opened your eyes, dear?" Shadow Weaver's voice dripped with false concern.

"Opened my eyes to what?" An ache flooded Adora's heart. "What do you expect me to believe?"

Shadow Weaver put her hands on Adora's shoulders. The sorceress turned her around. Parts of the fog dissipated. Through the haze, she could see Mystacor Village's entrance. A pair of individuals stood by the outskirts. Glimmer and Bow. They didn't move, and neither did they react. They ignored Adora.

"They still care-" Adora's voice trailed off. There was no mistaking what just happened. "No, they..."

Shadow Weaver drew Adora into an embrace. Adora accepted it this time. She was wrong about Glimmer and those people all along. Her adoptive mother was right. She needed the older woman more than anything.

"I'm so sorry, Shadow Weaver..." Hot tears streamed down Adora's cheeks.

"It's okay, my dear..." Shadow Weaver pulled away. "I must warn you, this is my phantom self. Brace yourself for the teleportation spell."

The specter faded into thin air. A magical aura enveloped Adora, transporting her away from the woods. She squeezed her eyes shut. In a matter of seconds, she would be back in the castle. Eventually, her feet met a floor. Her eyes fluttered open. She was now in her old bedroom. Shadow Weaver insisted on removing the dirty adventure outfit. Adora changed into her dress.

The sorceress closed the bedroom door and went downstairs. Adora leaned against the window. The room was darker and gloomier than she remembered. Numbness settled in her chest. She was alone. Shadow Weaver's words warred with memories of her friends. Did the sorceress have a reason to bring her home? The older woman hated it when Adora left.

Glimmer's face lingered in Adora's mind. Why were her thoughts tormenting her? Both women had gone through everything together. And the conversation with Adam? It had helped her remember her childhood. She rushed to the door and yanked it. A staircase spiraled downward. She descended the steps to the bottom. Shadow Weaver lingered as though waiting.

"What troubles you now, my dear?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"If you cared, why did you do it?" Adora replied.

"Do what?"

"Why did you force me to forget my family?"

Shadow Weaver scowled. "I hate hearing you complain."

Adora raised her chin in an attempt to seem confident. "Someone had a good reason for taking Adam to safety. Weeks ago, he shared his perspective on our childhood. We know the truth. You murdered our parents and usurped the throne."

Shadow Weaver reached for Adora's face. "You don't know what you're talking about."

Adora jerked away. "I do! You manipulated me for years!"

"Go to your room. You're being irrational!"

"No. I'm not irrational."

Before Adora could continue, Shadow Weaver unleashed a spell on her. She collapsed to the floor. The last thing she knew was the

woman's cold glare. Unconsciousness claimed her body.

Saving Adora

For hours, Glimmer searched Mystacor Village for Adora. She called out the blonde's name. Someone told her that the princess had gone into the woods. She checked the clearing. There was no sign of Adora. The knight stormed to the tavern, where her friends gathered. She didn't expect to hear Catra mentioning Adora's disappearance. Did the shapeshifter follow her, then?

"Shadow Weaver tricked Adora with the illusion spell. Her 'spies' pretended to be Glimmer and Bow," Catra explained.

Glimmer cleared her throat. "Shadow Weaver and her illusion spell?"

"Absolutely. What else would it be?" Catra slid off the chair and rose. "Shadow Weaver captured Adora. The old witch will try something awful."

Glimmer's heart sank. "We need to save Adora. We'll take down Shadow Weaver once we get there. How soon can we leave?"

"We don't plan on wasting time, so..." Catra placed her hands on her hips. "We'll get ready and go. Remember, no charging in without a strategy."

"I'll keep it in mind."

Glimmer proceeded to the bar and ordered a drink. It didn't take long for her to receive one. Her mind drifted to earlier in the day. Adora had seen something in the window. Glimmer had assumed Adora was watching birds. Instead, the blonde's expression was tense at that moment. What if she had intervened before the capture? Would Adora still be here?

"Like in the tales of heroes, we'll be storming the castle," Sea Hawk said to a group of ladies. "I will be one of them!"

Glimmer snorted. The sea captain's ego would always be there. Bow sat at the same table listening to Sea Hawk. Teela and Catra exchanged amused glances. Adam stood by the door, arms folded. Was he wondering about Adora? The plan to storm the castle? Glimmer sipped her drink. The liquid had a refreshing taste.

Once the group finished enjoying their drinks, they gathered their weapons. They all put on armor. Bow tied the horses to the wagon. The others entered. The horses pulled the wagon into the woods. Its wheels rolled over the dirt path. Glimmer scrutinized the castle in the distance. What was Adora thinking right now? Was the princess scared?

The horses broke into a gallop upon meeting steady ground. Trees and bushes whizzed by due to the wagon's speed. The sun hovered above the western horizon. Glimmer and her friends might sleep in the wagon. It was a possibility. However, it could be uncomfortable. Also, the group would be in the middle of the field. It would increase the chances of a monster interrupting them.

Glimmer peeked at Catra. The shapeshifter seemed introspective. Was the brunette thinking about the rescue mission? Catra's brows wrinkled, and she wore a grimace.

"What is it?" Glimmer asked.

"Shadow Weaver," Catra replied. She tugged at her sleeve. "She won't go easy on any of us."

"Are you worried?"

Catra shrugged. "Maybe."

"We'll work together."

"I know. Shadow Weaver's magic is powerful."

"It's true. However, let's not allow Shadow Weaver to intimidate us. I've fought tough opponents in the past. The deathstalker in

Plumeria Sanctuary. The sea serpent in Seabed Caverns."

Catra tilted her head. "Didn't both require group effort?"

Glimmer propped her elbows against her knees. "Of course. In both cases, someone helped. I was more confident fighting the sea serpent."

"Anyway, how big is the sea serpent? Is it the same size as a deathstalker?"

"It's the size of a regular dragon. There's tentacles. It's a weird combination."

"Was the battle underwater?"

Glimmer clasped her hands together. "The Seabed Caverns is a mix of underwater and above water."

Catra lifted her brows. "How were you able to breathe underwater?"

"Mermista gave us enchanted seashell necklaces."

"Pieces of magical jewelry?"

"Yep."

Catra chuckled. "You're so brave. I was sure being underwater would be unsettling."

Glimmer smiled. "Adora and I trusted Mermista. Salineas is a beautiful sea kingdom. When Adora and I returned to the surface, we were exhausted. And she was injured."

"Wow. You and Adora are determined. I'll give you that."

"We had to be. We didn't want Mermista to lose her kingdom."

"You also survived the creepy island. Are you sure you don't have the spirit of the legendary heroine?"

Glimmer snickered, noting the joking tone in Catra's voice. "I happen to be courageous."

Catra leaned back. "It's a quality people expect to witness in knights. You're protective and fierce, even more around Adora. Who will you save first when Grayskull is in danger? Adora or the people?"

"Adora. It's not just because of my duty to her." Heat bloomed in Glimmer's cheeks. "She means a lot to me."

"What drew you to her?"

"Adora's sweet and compassionate. She's beautiful, inside and out. Her smile is endearing."

Catra nodded. "I can see why you'd be drawn to her."

Glimmer peeked out the window. The wagon remained on the road even when monsters patrolled the fields. Teela and Bow would shoot arrows at them. Glimmer used fireballs. Because of their pinpoint aim, the beasts fell. The group continued their banter after each battle. Without the sun, it was a wonder how long they traveled. One hour? Or three? The moon glided toward the middle of the sky.

"Are we riding all night?" Catra yawned, stretching her limbs. "Aren't you guys getting tired by now?"

"Funny you should say that," Glimmer said. "The horses are beginning to slow down."

Teela grabbed a canteen from her belt. "Do we set up camp? We're near the river."

"Sure. I'll summon the protection spell to keep us safe," Glimmer replied.

The group disembarked the wagon. As promised, Glimmer conjured the protection spell. Sea Hawk, Bow, and Adam set up

the tents. Everyone took off their armor for the night. Inside a tent, Glimmer pulled the blanket over her body.

Glimmer shut her eyes. Her mind wouldn't rest. She kept thinking about Adora. Sleep was elusive. Until the wee hours, she spent those minutes tossing and turning. A heaviness weighed on her limbs. She drifted into a dreamless slumber.

The sun rose in the kingdom of Grayskull. Its golden light bathed the land in a soft glow. Glimmer and her friends began traveling as soon as they put on armor. Judging by the distance, Gray Haven wasn't too far off. Like yesterday, the horses galloped. Their hooves thundered along the path. Morning transitioned into noon. The group approached Gray Haven. They decided to find a different entrance. They crossed the moat.

Glimmer followed the others into a passageway. Catra showed the group some notes and sketches of the layout. Due to the presence of guards, their voices were muted.

"Which do we check first? The tallest tower or the throne room?" Teela asked.

"Would it be safe to split up?" Bow suggested.

Glimmer observed her surroundings. "I suppose we could. We'll go in pairs for safety. Adam and Teela. Bow and Sea Hawk. Catra and I could go to the tallest tower. The rest of you could explore the hallways and rooms."

"So, why that tower?"

"It was where Adora slept before we snuck her out." Glimmer's fingers moved along her hilt. "We can't keep Adora waiting. The fate of Grayskull rests on our shoulders."

Everyone nodded in agreement. Adam and Teela hurried in one direction. Bow and Sea Hawk went the other way. Glimmer and Catra crept through the tunnels. Half the corridors were narrow.

A mouse skittered over Glimmer's feet. Despite the sudden sensation, she tried to remain calm. The network of passageways was like a maze. Sometimes, Catra would transform into a panther and sniff around.

Glimmer and Catra snuck through a door. It led to a bridge. Sunlight illuminated the roofs. Glimmer glimpsed a courtyard under the overpass. Skeleton warriors charged forward, raising their swords.

Glimmer unsheathed her sword and lunged at them. One of them parried her weapon. Catra attacked the other skeletons. The blades clanged together.

Glimmer sidestepped, then teleported behind the skeletons and slashed them. Upon impact, they crumbled into heaps of bones. An arrow sped past the knight, narrowly grazing her shoulder. She peeked at the bridges. There were more of those skeletal enemies. And they were shooting arrows. Bow, Sea Hawk, Adam, and Teela struck the skeletons from behind. They raced into a neighboring tower.

Glimmer and Catra made their way to the tallest tower's entrance. She glanced at the window near the top. Catra pointed to a ladder. It hung from the window's ledge.

"Was it usually how you got into Adora's room?" Glimmer asked.

"Yeah. It's been around for years," Catra said. She began climbing. "Ready to rescue Adora?"

"Yes."

Both women ascended the ladder. They slipped into Adora's room, feet meeting the floor. The princess lay on the bed, unconscious. Her chest rose and fell in slow motions. Glimmer strode to the bed. There was a slight gap between Adora's lips. Adora's eyebrows rose, then lowered. The blonde could be dreaming.

"Adora?" Glimmer asked. "Can you hear me?" She reached out and touched Adora's cheek. Her fingertips slid along the blonde's cheekbone. "Wake up. I'm here to save you."

Glimmer didn't receive a response. Adora mumbled in her sleep. Could it be a sleeping curse? Glimmer sat near her. Again, the princess didn't budge.

"Adora..." Glimmer leaned closer. "There is something I've always wanted to tell you. But I haven't said anything in the past. I... I have feelings for you. You mean everything to me." Her lips brushed Adora's. She pulled away.

Adora's eyes opened. She sat up in bed. "Glimmer..." She wore a faint smile.

"Adora, you're awake." Glimmer hugged Adora. "So, were you aware of the kiss?" She released the blonde.

"You did it to wake me up? I thought you were mad at me."

Catra stepped forward. "It was Shadow Weaver's illusion spell. Glimmer and Bow weren't angry at you. Shadow Weaver used the shadow 'spies' to manipulate your emotions. Her intent was to isolate you."

Adora furrowed her brows. "You saw the entire thing?"

"Not all of it. At first, I was curious about Bow and Glimmer acting weird. It seemed out of the blue. When I saw the dark haze in the woods, it made sense. I could tell it was Shadow Weaver's magic. If I intervened, I would be on the receiving end of her anger."

"Thanks for the explanation, I guess. Have any of you defeated Shadow Weaver?"

Glimmer stood. "Not yet, but we will."

Adora swung her legs over the edge of the bed. Glimmer led her and Catra out of the room. The trio searched for the throne room,

evading the guards. In a spacious hall, they reunited with Bow and the group. They all hugged Adora.

"I'm so glad my sister is okay," Adam said.

"Glimmer woke me up," Adora said. "She did it with a kiss."

"It sounds like something out of a storybook."

"Except that it occurred in real life. The kiss of true love."

Bow grinned. "Does it mean you and Glimmer confessed feelings for each other?"

Adora blushed, rubbing the back of her neck. "Can you not start? We have bigger issues to deal with."

Teela and Sea Hawk chuckled. Everyone proceeded through the hallways. Ten minutes later, they arrived in the throne room. Shadow Weaver glowered at them. The sorceress descended the steps with a confident posture.

Shadow Weaver's face twisted into a sneer. "Oh, I was anticipating your arrival. Look who came. A bunch of kids who snatched the princess from my grasp. I have years of magical experience. You brats, on the other hand? What makes you assume you can overthrow me?"

"My friends and I will work together," Glimmer said. "We will bring an end to your tyranny."

"Your mother told me the same thing. She perished, and so did your father. Why haven't you considered it a warning? Their defiance ended their lives."

"You're responsible for the deaths of my parents, aren't you?"

"The Horde Clan did the job. Since you and your little friends are here, I'll enjoy tormenting you." Shadow Weaver turned her

attention to Adora. "I'll destroy everything you love. It includes those fools."

Adora closed the distance between herself and Shadow Weaver. "Don't even think about it. Spare them. No matter what, I won't stop resisting you. Even if it means I suffer, and my friends live."

"You will stay out of this!" Shadow Weaver shot a blast of magic at Adora. It sent her flying to the grand doors.

Adam advanced. Shadow Weaver repeated the spell. She conjured a barrier, blocking the twins from approaching. Bow and Teela nocked their arrows. Catra transformed into a panther. Shadow Weaver expelled a volley of dark orbs at the group. Glimmer teleported out of the way. Bow, Teela, Catra, and Sea Hawk evaded the spells.

On the other side of the barrier, Adora and Adam watched the battle. They must have felt helpless. Shadow Weaver summoned a sword out of thin air. She lunged at Glimmer. Both women struggled to gain the upper hand. Glimmer feinted. She spotted an opening and gashed Shadow Weaver's leg.

Shadow Weaver thrusted her sword at Glimmer. "It'll take more than a slash."

Glimmer sidestepped. The knight's sword blocked another strike. The blades clashed, letting out an echoing sound. She rammed her foot into Shadow Weaver's ankles, sending her tumbling. Shadow Weaver fell onto her side.

Before Glimmer could land the finishing blow, Shadow Weaver rolled away. The sorceress levitated into the air and unleashed a spell. Its magic restrained Glimmer and her friends to the floor. Dark tendrils snaked around their limbs.

"Don't say I haven't warned you," Shadow Weaver said. She strode toward Glimmer. "You're so similar to your parents. Annoying, rebellious, and a thorn in the side. You never accepted my reign." She began circling the knight, taking slow strides.

"Everyone in this room will pay the price. I've had enough of your uprising."

Out of the corner of her eye, Glimmer watched Catra break free. The shapeshifter sprung at Shadow Weaver, pinning her to the floor. In an instant, dark magic shoved Catra off. She was sent flying. Teela and Bow freed themselves. Then, they shot arrows. Each missile sped toward Shadow Weaver.

With a wave of the hand, Shadow Weaver redirected the arrows. The projectiles struck Bow, Sea Hawk, and Teela. Luckily, they didn't pierce internal organs. Glimmer forced herself up despite the tightening restraints.

Glimmer widened her stance. "You'll pay for murdering Adora's parents. You isolated her from the outside world. And lying about her family? Abusing her?"

"I did everything I could," Shadow Weaver said.

"You're excusing your cruel actions. It has affected Adora. She feared your reaction to her leaving the castle. Every other night, the nightmares haunted her."

"Adora regretted her rash decision."

"You're wrong. Dead wrong!" A kinetic blast ripped from Glimmer's palm, striking Shadow Weaver. "All of us are sick of your tyranny and wickedness!"

A column of dark magic rushed from Shadow Weaver's hand. Glimmer answered with her own. The blasts collided, shoving against one another. Shadow Weaver's magic pushed toward Glimmer's body. The knight broke contact and teleported. Then, she reappeared by the steps. She launched a barrage of fireballs.

Shadow Weaver ducked to and fro to avoid them. Upon landing on the floor, the fireballs exploded into flames. Glimmer fired an air spell to extinguish the blaze. It also propelled Shadow Weaver backward.

"How dare you! I have a kingdom to rule!" Shadow Weaver spat. She levitated off the floor.

"You're so desperate for power. At this point, you're barely hanging on," Glimmer said. She hurled a ball of magical energy at Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver deflected the sphere at Glimmer. "You can't be serious. I'm guessing you took magic lessons from Castaspella. I've never seen her use her powers in a fight. Your father did. And he lost his life. So will you."

Glimmer repelled the sphere with her sword. Both sorceresses hit it back and forth. Soon, its aura consumed Shadow Weaver, paralyzing her. The wicked woman fell, landing on her knees. Glimmer leaped at her, seizing the opportunity to attack. The tip of her sword gashed Shadow Weaver's side.

"Yield!" Glimmer pointed her sword at Shadow Weaver's neck. "You won't get away with your crimes."

Shadow Weaver's sword vanished. Contrary to how a defeated opponent would react, she started laughing. It was cold, lacking joy. It was the sound of desperation. A dark aura seeped from her body. With a flick of her wrist, she sent Glimmer flying into the barrier. Glimmer fell into a slump, aching from the impact.

Each memory flooded Glimmer's mind, fueling her with strength. Discovering how her parents died. Shadow Weaver's cruelty to Adora. The skeleton in Plumeria Sanctuary. The curse on Plumeria Woods and on Salineas. Adora awakening from nightmares. The night Evelyn captured Bow and their friends.

"No more." Glimmer shot up to her height, hands glowing with magic. "You brought harm to many people." With each sentence, she stepped closer. "You have blood on your hands. Your reign ends today!"

Glimmer let loose a powerful spell. It engulfed Shadow Weaver in a matter of seconds. The next thing Glimmer knew, the sorceress

was unconscious. The barrier vanished. Moments passed, and Shadow Weaver didn't get up. Catra transformed into her human form. She approached.

"Is she dead?" Catra asked. She touched Shadow Weaver's neck. "Oh. The pulse is still there. She's breathing. It looks like the old witch will be out for a while."

Adora rushed over to Glimmer and pulled her into a hug. "You did it. Glimmer, you're so amazing. That aside, I was afraid I would lose you. I could have done something to help you."

"Adora, don't blame yourself. You didn't know she would use the barrier. It kept you away from the fight," Glimmer said.

Adora held Glimmer's hand. "Are you injured?"

Glimmer rolled her shoulders. "Just some scratches."

After the battle, the guards sent Shadow Weaver on the transport to Executioner's Grounds. It was the name of the abandoned prison in the Crimson Desert. The dungeon would reopen to house dangerous criminals like Shadow Weaver.

The servants in the castle cleaned up the damage caused by the battle. One morning, Adora and Adam held a discussion regarding the throne. Ruling Grayskull might mean staying in the castle. They suspected that running a kingdom would be hard work.

"How did our parents do it?" Adora asked.

"I don't know," Adam said.

"Perhaps we could get some ideas from reading about past rulers. The royal library contains tons of books."

The royal twins walked to the library and searched the bookshelves. After what seemed to be an eternity, Adora pulled

out a tome. The title said "The Rulers of Grayskull: A History." She carried it to a desk and pored over the pages.

"Adam, come here," Adora said.

Adam occupied a chair next to Adora. "Did you find something?"

"Of course. The entire book has records of past rulers. They lived in different eras. They all had something in common. Formal training. How to deal with foreign leaders, kingdom issues, and oversee justice. Significant decisions could affect a kingdom. Sometimes, they faced threats."

"That's a lot, isn't it?"

"Yeah. No pressure. And one more thing - maintaining peace in the realm." Adora shut the book. "I want to undo the damage Shadow Weaver's tyranny caused. I might try my hand at being queen."

"Alright. And what do I do as a prince?"

"You could travel around the kingdom. You may also help villages."

"I could do that."

Adora returned the tome to the bookshelf. She made her way into the hallway. Glimmer lingered by the window. A ray of sunlight spilled in, highlighting her armor. Adora strode over to her.

"Have you and your brother decided yet?" Glimmer asked.

"I'll be the queen. Adam won't have as much responsibilities. Still, he'll have things to do, like traveling," Adora said.

"Does it mean you won't be adventuring as much?"

"I won't be. As queen, I'd still protect the Kingdom of Grayskull."

"That's a big responsibility. Ruling a kingdom."

Adora nodded. "True. Anyway, what will you be doing for the time being?"

Glimmer made eye contact. "As your knight, I'll continue guarding you."

"I'm sure you will. So, about the kiss..." Adora went quiet, aware of the heat in her cheeks. "What can we call our relationship, moving forward?"

Glimmer took Adora's hands into hers. "I guess we're more than just friends."

"I think so, too."

Their mouths met in a passionate kiss. Adora wrapped her arms around Glimmer's waist. She couldn't deny how safe the embrace felt. The knight had a comforting presence. Adora's worries about being queen faded at the moment. The coronation could come later.

Being Queen

Today was the day. Adora stood in the master suite, gazing into the mirror. Her parents once slept here. The defeated tyrant did, too. She combed her hair, finalizing the style.

A crown braid wrapped around Adora's head. Part of it was hidden beneath her hair. The white ribbons held it in place. A sky blue corset and a matching apron sash covered the alabaster gown. Her earrings and tiara glittered in the sunlight. The jewelry and dress gave her the impression of elegance.

Adora's gloved palms brushed against her earrings. Despite the polished, confident facade, she was unsure. The royal title - queen - suggested the amount of weight on her shoulders. It was more than dresses and etiquette.

Adora would oversee the well-being of her kingdom. She would have to be present in the throne room to speak with subjects. Would she be as great as her parents were rumored to be?

It was supposed to be a joyful occasion. The people would no longer suffer under tyranny. Adora's reign should bring forth peace. Right? She walked out to the balcony overlooking the courtyard. Nobles and royalty arrived, waiting in the crowd. She couldn't believe it was her coronation day. Her heart pounded.

Adora would be speaking to hundreds upon hundreds of strangers. What if she said the wrong thing? Clasping her hands together, she quelled their trembling.

Behind Adora, the door swung open. She whirled around, not expecting anyone's arrival. It was Glimmer. The knight approached, armor glinting in the sunlight. Glimmer's cape displayed the kingdom's emblem. The same symbol was carved onto the chestplate.

"Oh, hi," Adora said.

"Hello, my queen," Glimmer said.

"I'm Queen Adora now. It sounds strange. It doesn't have the same ring as 'Princess' would."

Glimmer shrugged, then said those two words repeatedly. "We'll have to get used to it. You'll be fine." She rested a hand on Adora's shoulder. "You have me and Adam. Our friends support you, too. Come on. Let's go to the throne room. Everyone's waiting."

Adora and Glimmer meandered through the hallways. The palace was a flurry of activity. Servants prepared the food and cleaned the rooms. Guards hurried back and forth. Not too long ago, the royal twins removed the ones who were loyal to Shadow Weaver. A quarter of the guards were dismissed. As a result, they had to put in extra effort to keep the castle safe. A few servants had tried to help.

The two women entered the throne room. Everyone rose, acknowledging the queen's presence. Adora tried to ignore everyone's gaze. She kept her focus on striding toward the throne. Taking deep breaths, the young regent approached the throne.

Adora turned to face the crowd. Standing in the room were hundreds of people. Nobles, foreign royals, and even those in the lower classes. In the front stood her friends. Bow, Teela, Sea Hawk, Adam, even Catra. She also saw Mermista, Perfuma, and Castaspella.

There were others Adora had met during her journey. Wearing a smile, she addressed the crowd. "I'm here today because I overthrew Shadow Weaver with the help of my friends. We ended her tyranny. Glimmer, my knight, stopped her. Shadow Weaver won't be a threat to us any longer. She'll stay in a prison in the Crimson Desert. Our best sorcerers restrained her magic."

Everyone watched in wonder, seemingly taking in the information. Adora exhaled, continuing the speech. "There are things we still need to take care of. The Horde Clan remains a threat, as do its sorcerers. They are seeking to release an ancient evil. Horde Prime will bring destruction and darkness if freed. As long as my friends and I live, we won't let Grayskull fall under tyranny again."

Adora beckoned Glimmer closer. The knight descended into a kneel. "Glimmer, you have shown unwavering courage. In the face of adversity, you didn't flinch. You saved the Kingdom of Grayskull. And for that, we thank you."

Once Adora was done speaking to the people, the guests made their way to the ballroom. Tables and chairs filled up the left side of the room. An array of food covered the banquet table. On the other side, people would dance. Musicians played music on the inner balconies. Catra was talking to a tall woman. The shapeshifter acted as though she knew her. The woman in question was muscular.

Adora walked over to them. "Hello. What's your name?"

The woman glanced at Adora. "Scorpia."

"I'm Adora, Queen of Grayskull. Catra told me a bit about you. Have you left the Horde Clan?"

"Yes."

"Was it hard to leave?"

Scorpia nodded. "The clan members were angry upon hearing of my departure. I had to defend myself."

Adora frowned. "Did anything happen afterward?"

"No. The clan hasn't bothered me since I moved to a mountain village."

"Mystacor Village or a different town?"

"A different one."

Adora turned her attention to Catra. "Are the two of you friends?"

Catra crossed her arms. "Somewhat. I'm getting to know Scorpia."

"And you're getting along?"

"Yeah."

Adora turned to leave, ready to speak with the guests, when she saw Adam talking to someone. It was a broad-shouldered man with angular features. He wore a black cape and a dark purple tunic. A jeweled clasp held the cape together.

"So, wait, you're the brother of my father?" Adam was saying.

"Yes," the man replied.

"I guess you're another long-lost relative. Where do you live, Keldor?"

"Snake Isles. I travel a lot, though."

"How did you know about my sister's coronation?"

"Hordak told me."

Adora paused as she listened to the conversation. Did Keldor have connections to the Horde Clan? She continued eavesdropping. He mentioned the clan. At some point, he strode out of the ballroom. She considered going after him.

The music's tempo slowed. Many couples linked their hands together. They held their free hands behind their backs. Glimmer came, extending a hand to Adora.

Adora accepted the offer. The two danced in tandem, neither leading. Off to the side, she glimpsed Catra and Scorpia doing the same thing. Teela and Adam danced, too. The song took on a romantic tune. Glimmer placed her hands on Adora's waist.

"You're so gorgeous, like the queen you are," Glimmer said.

"Thank you," Adora replied. "By the way, did you see Adam talk to that man earlier?"

"Which man?"

"The one in the black cape. Adam called him Keldor." Adora peeked at the door. "Keldor claimed to be Randor's brother. He said something about Hordak. They must have known each other."

Glimmer moved her hands to Adora's shoulders. "A man waltzed in and claimed to be your uncle? And he was acquaintances with Hordak? It sounds suspicious."

"I agree. No one told me my father had a brother."

Adora and Glimmer continued dancing. Several guests stopped to watch them. At times, both women shared a tender kiss. The ball lasted until evening. By sundown, the guests left the castle and went home.

Adora was quick to change out of her coronation gown. She now wore a nightgown. Sitting on her bed, she braided her hair.

Glimmer removed her armor and tunic, revealing a sleeveless undershirt. A pair of leggings encased her toned legs. She ran her fingers through her hair. The knight placed the armor onto a display by the wardrobe. She joined Adora on the bed. Moonlight streamed into the room, landing on the bed.

Adora snaked her arms around Glimmer's left arm. She became aware of the feeling of muscle beneath her fingertips. Leaning against Glimmer, she dwelled on today's events. The coronation. Adam's conversation with Keldor.

At least Adora danced with Glimmer for the first time. It was as romantic as she had imagined. She and Glimmer reclined on the bed. Sleepiness took hold...

The dark forest stretched for miles. A churning haze obscured the trail. Adora's foot met a twig as she searched for an escape. The snapping sound echoed. A growl pierced her ear. With a gasp, she whirled around. There was nothing to find here - just miles of blackness.

A puff of white air left Adora's lips. The frigid air enveloped her. Rubbing her arms, she noticed that she was wearing the nightgown. A distant roar erupted.

Adora broke into a run. Something started pursuing her through the forest. Her ankle connected with a log. Upon breaking the fall, she forced herself up. At the edge of the woods, a light shone.

Without thinking, Adora sprinted closer. To her horror, the light revealed an intimidating figure. Sinister green eyes glowered at her. The tall individual had broad shoulders and heavy armor. Unsheathing the sword, he raised it to her neck.

"Horde Prime will rule..."

"No... he won't..." Adora stepped back and tripped over a rock. Her spine met the hard ground. "A heroine defeated him!"

The man transformed into a boar. Its green mane rippled in the invisible wind. The beast reared up, ready to attack. Its front hooves descended toward Adora's body. As she held her arms over her chest, everything went dark.

Adora jolted awake, screaming. Images of the dream lingered as she panted. It was a nightmare about Horde Prime. She had encountered the boar in a previous dream. Someone grabbed her wrists. The familiar sight of Glimmer provided instant comfort. Both women were still in bed. It was dark in here. The wee hours, perhaps? A soft glow illuminated Glimmer's face. Her light spell.

"Adora, you screamed," Glimmer said. "Did you have a nightmare?"

Adora took a moment to steady her breathing. Glimmer didn't pressure her to hurry up. Instead, she waited for Adora to speak. Adora released a soft sigh.

"I did. It's vivid and scary," Adora said. "Toward the end of it, someone told me about Horde Prime. He turned into a boar."

"What did the boar look like?" Glimmer asked.

"It had green eyes and a matching mane. The body is white with some gray streaks." Adora shuddered. "Its face had a demonic appearance."

"The same creature from the tale of the legendary heroine?"

"Could be. What if the dream's a warning?"

The question hung in the air. Neither woman had an answer to it. In Adora's heart, she suspected it was a yes. It could be her worries whispering into her mind. Her hands rested in Glimmer's palms.

"Can we continue the discussion regarding Horde Prime in the morning?" Adora asked.

"Of course," Glimmer said.

Morning arose in the kingdom of Grayskull. It manifested as a brilliant sunrise, an array of colors painting the clouds. Golden rays stretched across the brightening sky. Distant mist obscured the mountains, making the horizon seem dreamlike.

In the courtyard, Catra was observing the sunrise. The birds chirped, flitting around trees. Teela and the others should be meeting with her soon. They would talk about their group and the royal guard.

Catra plopped onto a stone bench. The others were probably changing clothes at this point. Maybe a few had breakfast. After

several minutes of quiet reflection, she trained with her sword. It kept her preoccupied. Exploring Grayskull again would be fun. She imagined journeying through unfamiliar lands. Approaching footsteps halted her swift movements. She looked up.

"Morning," Scorpia said, smiling.

"Hey. Did you spend the night in the inn?" Catra replied.

"Yes."

"How was it?"

"I slept well."

Catra sheathed her sword. What should she and Scorpia discuss in the meantime? Adora's coronation? The ball? A dream she had? The final question made images arise in her mind. She figured they were fragments from last night's slumber. A man in a black cape. An army of monsters. Flashes of the Horde Clan. Was it a warning of things to come? She decided not to mention the vision.

"What do you think of Adora's coronation speech yesterday?" Catra asked.

"It was awesome," Scorpia said.

"Oh, really? What kind of queen do you suppose she'll be?"

"I hope she'll be better than Shadow Weaver."

"Trust me, Adora will be. She's gentle and compassionate."

Catra had never expected to speak highly of her adoptive sister. Her old self was quick to belittle Adora. She used to blame her whenever Shadow Weaver punished them. Scorpia's voice interrupted her thoughts.

"They're here," Scorpia said, referring to their group.

Bow, Teela, and Adam approached Catra and Scorpia. Catra waited for her friends to finish talking. Then, her turn came.

"The 'captain of the royal guard' position is empty," Catra said. "In your opinion, who should be the new captain?"

"Teela?" Adam said.

Teela glanced at Adam. "I suppose I could accept the position. Giving orders to guards and protecting royalty."

Bow nodded. "I believe Teela is fit to handle those responsibilities."

Catra adjusted her ponytail. Some strands stuck out, brushing her cheekbones. "Anyway, the resistance group needs a name and a symbol. We could call it the Rebellion. Our goal remains the same. Defending Grayskull from the Horde Clan." She peeked at Scorpia. "You once worked for the Horde Clan. How many evil sorcerers does it have? Adora said they were planning to release Horde Prime."

"You've already met Evelyn," Scorpia said. "There's also Shokoti and Zed. I haven't kept count. Maybe they're the only sorcerers in the clan."

"How powerful are they? We better not deal with another Shadow Weaver."

"They're experienced, but not the same level as Shadow Weaver."

"Some of us were on the receiving end of Evelyn's magic."

Teela let out an audible exhale. "Still, we shouldn't allow evil sorcerers to intimidate us."

Catra shrugged. "True."

Glimmer followed Adora to the council room. They had planned to discuss Horde Prime this morning. However, life had other plans. Adora's current advisor, Juliet, was blabbering. Juliet had some ideas of how a kingdom should be run.

Keldor interrupted with his own thoughts. Glimmer didn't agree with some of his opinions. However, she remained silent. Adora seemed uncertain.

"Can I talk without interruptions?" Adora asked at last. "I'm the queen."

"You're young and naive," Keldor said. "How can you know which decisions are sensible?"

"I saw the kingdom suffer under tyranny."

"You are idealistic, much like your brother and your father. What makes you sure there will be long-lasting peace in Grayskull?"

"I will follow in the footsteps of my parents. Their rule was just and fair. Shadow Weaver's tyranny, on the other hand-"

"Not everything is as black and white as it seems."

"And what do you know about running a kingdom?"

Keldor crossed his arms. "Randor had to deal with the pressures. Our father did, too."

Adora straightened her posture. "At least they didn't resort to cruel measures."

"Randor and I lost our father at a young age. Shadow Weaver usurped Randor. Perhaps there's a flaw."

Glimmer expected an argument to ensue. However, Keldor continued trying to test Adora's confidence. What did he seek to gain? Juliet held up a hand. The gesture seemed to calm the growing tension.

"I believe the queen doesn't want you to dominate the conversation," Juliet said.

Adora lifted her brows. Then, her face relaxed as she smiled gratefully. "Anyway, shall we come up with a strategy? We need to stop the Horde Clan."

Keldor cleared his throat. "I could go see their leader, Hordak."

"Would Hordak listen?"

"I'll see what I can do." Keldor walked toward the door. "I'm done here."

Once the meeting ended, Glimmer and Adora strode to the throne room. According to Juliet, Adora needed to be present to listen to subjects. The day was busier than anticipated. Would it be a daily occurrence? Was it due to Adora's first day of being queen? She occupied the throne. People waited to speak with the queen.

"It's going to be a while, isn't it?" Adora asked.

"That's not all. You'll do paperwork after this," Juliet said.

The subjects took turns bringing their requests to Adora. Glimmer stood close. The minutes trickled into an hour. Or was it two? Later on, Glimmer and Adora went to the royal office. Ten minutes into paperwork, the queen groaned.

"They're hoping I would undo the damage Shadow Weaver caused," Adora said. "I'm busy, and it's not even afternoon." She proceeded to write on some papers. "It won't surprise me if council meetings happen more often."

"Yeah. The responsibilities are taking up your time," Glimmer said.

"I'll have to adjust." Adora placed the quill into the ink bottle. "Not too long ago, we were adventuring."

"Do you want to stroll in the courtyard? It could make you feel better."

Adora grinned. "That'll be nice."

They strode outside. Adora's hair reflected the glow of the sun. It made her strands resemble a sunset's golden rays. She held Glimmer's hand. A faint dusting of pink colored her cheeks. It made her appear innocent.

"The weather is pleasant today," Adora said.

"I agree. The temperature is perfect," Glimmer replied. She tucked a strand behind Adora's ear. "We could do this more often. Whenever you're stressed, we could come out here."

"You're so sweet, my knight. What would I do without you?"

Glimmer kissed the back of Adora's hand. Upon letting go, she made eye contact. Their gazes lingered. Glimmer's palm cupped Adora's jaw. Adora tilted her head into the touch.

Glimmer's thumb brushed Adora's cheekbone. "Your smile is so lovely."

Adora leaned in. Their mouths met. Glimmer wrapped her arms around Adora's neck. The queen's palms trailed down her back. Though the kiss was brief, they kept holding each other.

"I still have to attend to my royal duties," Adora said.

"How about the nightmare you had last night?" Glimmer replied.

"The Horde Prime one?"

Glimmer nodded. "By the way, you mentioned the boar's appearance. Some copies of the story included an illustration. Perhaps there's one in the library."

They entered the castle and made their way to the library. Hundreds upon hundreds of books filled every bookshelf. Many of them were sorted by genre. Romance, comedy, and everything else. Glimmer found one that said "Tales and Legends." She pulled out a chair, sat down, and opened the book.

The tome included illustrations. One of them contained a drawing of a boar. Glimmer beckoned Adora to her side. She pointed to the image. Adora's face paled.

"That's what I saw in the nightmare," Adora said.

"And what is it about nightmares?" Juliet's voice interrupted the conversation. "I'm sorry to cut your break short, but you must resume your duties, Majesty."

Adora flinched. "I needed to clear my mind."

"The Kingdom of Grayskull needs you. As soon as you're done, go to the throne room."

"I will."

Juliet left the library. Glimmer and Adora put the books away. They wandered into the hallway. The illustration remained in Glimmer's mind. The corridors led them to the throne room. This time, their friends were here.

"Do you have a request?" Adora asked.

"No," Teela said. "I may sign up to be the captain of the royal guard."

"What will the others do?"

"They'll protect the kingdom from the Horde Clan."

Juliet approached Adora. "Your Majesty, there are reports of disturbances in the mountains. Some wagons vanished. There was

an attack near a cave. I suspect the Horde Clan is responsible for such chaos."

Adora arched her brows. "Oh. Thanks for bringing the information to me. Is there anything else?"

"No."

"You may now leave the throne room."

Juliet bowed her head before hurrying off. Glimmer and Adora glanced at their friends. The reports must have made the group curious. They were now asking questions.

"You may investigate the disturbances. Remember to be on alert for dangers in the mountains. Please be safe out there," Adora said.

"We can handle ourselves," Adam said.

"I know you can. However, you guys aren't invincible. You might encounter a powerful enemy or dozens of Horde Clan members."

"I'll keep it in mind. Can we go on the mission now?"

"Yes."

A Lurking Threat

Catra, Scorpia, Adam, and Bow arrived in the mountains. On the way here, they spent the night in an inn. It was nice to be outside the castle. Traveling through the kingdom gave her the thrill of adventure.

Inhaling the refreshing forest scents, Catra wandered around. She wasn't here to hike along the trail. There was an investigation to conduct. Her group journeyed deep into the mountains. The twigs and leaves made pleasant, familiar snaps beneath hooves.

Most wouldn't consider the mountains remarkable, other than their peaks. Still, anyone would find the forest sounds calming. With each step, Catra recalled the adventure. She reminded herself to focus.

The Rebellion shouldn't mess up with their mission over nostalgia. Catra led her group to a cave entrance. The wagons had supposedly gone missing. An attacker could be lurking nearby.

Catra shifted into her panther form and sniffed the ground. She began tracking the scent to the cave. A scraping noise made her ears perk up. Blade against stone? There were whimpers accompanied by angry voices. Someone could be holding their victim hostage. She transformed into her human form. Who got ambushed, and why?

"Who's going in first?" Bow asked.

"I could," Catra said. "I'll lead the way."

Catra led the group into the cave. Shouts echoed off the walls. The crying followed. They entered a room.

A cluster of individuals were chained up. The captors snickered at their misfortune. Catra glimpsed the Horde Clan's symbol on the captors' capes.

"Lonnie, some people decided to bother us," a man said.

"I'll fight them, Kyle," a woman said.

"Jitsu can hold them off. There's four of them."

"I'll bring Jitsu." Lonnie stormed off. "And don't be a chicken!"

Kyle flinched at Lonnie's tone. He didn't seem the type of person to put up a fight. Was he just Lonnie's foolish sidekick? Bow walked over to him. Adam and Scorpia released the strangers from the chains.

"Are there any more Horde Clan members here?" Bow asked.

"No. Lonnie, Jitsu, and I captured those people. Hordak's orders," Kyle said.

"How long did you work for Hordak?"

"A while. Lonnie joined first. She invited me to come along."

Bow and Kyle continued chatting. Catra watched for enemies that might hinder the mission. What did the Horde Clan want from their hostages? Was one of them an ex-member? As she lost herself in her thoughts, footsteps thudded. It was Lonnie. A muscular man stood by Lonnie. Catra guessed it was Jitsu.

"Kyle, stop being nice to the intruders!" Lonnie demanded. "Our prisoners are gone, idiot!"

"Where are they?" Jitsu boomed.

Kyle rubbed his arms. "I, ah... got distracted."

Lonnie shoved Kyle. "I'll report your incompetence to Hordak!"

Jitsu charged at Catra. Their swords clanged. Catra, aware of the sheer force, stood her ground. She pretended to have an opening, only to take him by surprise. Her sword nicked his shoulder.

Jitsu held his shield in front of his body, blocking blows. Catra sidestepped, then slashed. The gash on Jitsu's leg bled.

"Thought you could hide behind your shield, huh?" Catra said, smirking.

"Ugh, shut up!" Jitsu retorted. He dropped his shield and sword.

"Yielding already?"

"No. We're doing it with fists."

Catra sheathed her sword. "Gotta warn you, I have a panther side."

"I've fought shapeshifters before," Jitsu said.

"I'd like to see you try!"

Catra transformed into a panther and growled. Jitsu widened his stance. She lunged at him, but he raised his arm over his chest. Her fangs sunk into his forearm. Jitsu shoved her off, sending her flying.

Catra collided against the stone wall. She rolled to her paws. Off to the side, Bow and Lonnie were exchanging blows. Kyle cowered in the corner. It would be an easy battle.

Catra sprung at Jitsu and pinned him, snarling. He punched her snout, and she jerked back. A kick, and he broke free. Did she underestimate him? Emitting a hiss, she retaliated. Jitsu didn't give up. Instead, he shot up and advanced. Catra dodged.

"You're more intense than my previous shapeshifter foes," Jitsu said.

Was it an honest observation? Or was Catra more of a warrior than other shapeshifters? It didn't matter either way. She pounced on her foe and prevented him from struggling. Jitsu tensed beneath her weight. Would he yield? She reverted to her human

form and straightened her spine. With a single foot, she pinned him.

"You lost to this one," Catra said.

"Fine. You win," Jitsu muttered.

Jitsu and Lonnie ran off. Kyle stayed, trembling. Catra and Bow led Kyle outside, where Scorpia and Adam waited. Scorpia was talking to the former hostages. One of them thanked her and Adam. The strangers left. Scorpia furrowed her brows at the sight of Kyle.

"Have you turned against the Horde Clan?" Scorpia asked.

"Yes," Kyle said.

Catra approached the Rebellion's wagon. "Kyle, can you tell me what happened to the missing wagons?"

Kyle pointed to a descending slope. "Jitsu and Lonnie toppled them over during the ambush."

"Were they transporting anything?"

"They were taking building supplies to a village."

"Is there a reason for the attack?"

"According to Hordak, one of those individuals betrayed the Horde Clan."

Catra stroked her chin, pondering over the information. "He doesn't take disloyalty lightly, does he? Does Hordak make spies pursue ex-members?"

Kyle put his hands on his hips. "Hordak's a harsh leader. He hates it whenever someone questions him or defects from the clan. Sometimes, the loyalists hunted the defectors."

"Are you willing to flee the Horde Clan? If so, can you accept the consequences?"

"Consequences for what?"

"Working for those who intend to harm Grayskull."

"I can handle the consequences."

Afterward, everyone boarded the wagon. Catra and her friends would take Kyle to the castle. Would there be more investigations in the future? Did Kyle have significant information he could share? The wagon whizzed past trees and bushes. Scorpia and Kyle started talking.

"Should we try getting Entrapta out of the Horde Clan?" Kyle asked.

"She's close to Hordak. It might be a challenge," Scorpia said. "Entrapta helps with the potions and magical candles."

"Not to mention enchanted objects and summoning sigils."

Catra peeked at them. "Is Entrapta a sorceress?"

Scorpia made eye contact. "She specializes in potion-making and magical objects. As for sigils, she and Hordak do them together. Shokoti, Evelyn, and Zed are the ones casting spells."

"What does Hordak do?"

Kyle fiddled with his sleeve. "He talks to a voice in a mirror."

Catra tilted her head. "What do you mean?"

"Hordak communicates with someone sinister and mysterious."

"Had someone used a spell to make it possible to communicate through the mirror?"

"Shokoti did."

Catra took a moment to process the words. She expected a story about how Hordak got a haunted mirror. It would sound more

interesting than a simple enchantment. A ghost trapped in a mirror? There were many tales about such a concept.

"Did you ever catch Hordak chatting with the mirror?" Catra asked.

"On several occasions," Scorpia said.

"And who was it?"

"Horde Prime."

The name gave Catra pause. "The wicked man in the legend?"

"Yes," Scorpia replied.

Hordak was scrutinizing the map when someone entered his tent. He turned around, scowling. Keldor strode toward the map. Did Keldor gather any intel while attending the coronation? Would he admit to failing again? Hordak hoped the former was true. Still, the latter could become the case.

"I spent the night in Gray Haven after the coronation," Keldor said.

"Did the coronation take place in Grayskull Castle?" Hordak asked.

"Of course."

"Is there any intel?"

"No. The queen is young and idealistic. She reminds me of her parents."

"Yeah, and what about it?"

Keldor retrieved some figurines from the table. He moved one across the map. "The Horde Clan is now the size of an army. Half are in the desert. A few reside on the islands. The monsters could

give us an advantage. I wonder how the queen will react to the war."

Hordak nodded as he listened. "Sure, the strategy makes sense. However, Horde Prime's influence could guarantee a potential victory. I shall check on our sorcerers and their progress."

"Is there anything you need me to do right now?"

"You go train the new recruits."

"I will."

Once Keldor was gone, Hordak met with the sorcerers. Entrapta had created a sigil from a cluster of stones. Outside the circle, the candles idled. Evelyn and Shokoti pushed the mirror into the center.

Zed lit the candles with a fire spell. The trio chanted in an ancient language. The reflection rippled, then revealed a silhouette and green flames. Matching eyes materialized.

"Greetings, little brothers and sisters. When are you using the spell? I desire to regain freedom," Horde Prime said.

"They need to make sure the spell works," Hordak replied.

Horde Prime narrowed his eyes. "I am growing tired of my imprisonment. Once I escape, I will rule Grayskull and remake it into my image. My reign shall spread to other lands."

"And what if a so-called 'hero' stands in the way?"

"They will suffer. I could end their lives or send them to the dark realm."

"A fitting punishment for rebels, huh?"

Horde Prime flashed a cruel grin. "They will regret defying me." He faded away, as did the flames.

Hordak closed the distance between himself and the tent flap. "Evelyn, Zed, and Shokoti? Horde Prime's not going to wait forever. Make haste, but exercise caution."

The trio bowed their heads. "We will, Lord Hordak."

Hordak stepped outside. On the outskirts of the base, two familiar faces came. Lonnie and Jitsu lowered their heads as if ashamed. Did they fail to capture the traitor? Did they encounter people who opposed the Horde Clan?

"Did you follow through with my orders? Where is Kyle?" Hordak asked.

"Kyle joined our enemies. They battled us and stole the hostages," Lonnie said. "There were four of them. One transformed into a panther. Scorpia was with them."

Hordak clenched his jaw. "Am I to understand that you blundered the assignment? You had one task. And you chose to be incompetent!"

Jitsu sighed, his shoulders slumping. "We should have planned ahead."

Hordak pinched the bridge of his nose. "Whatever. Did you run into Scorpia?"

"Not just her. We saw the archer and a man who resembled the queen."

"An archer, a queen's brother, a traitor, and a shapeshifter. Got it. Which one do you consider the strongest foe?"

Lonnie shrugged. "The shapeshifter. Wasn't she our captive in the past?"

Hordak rolled his eyes. "It's who Scorpia helped escape. Anyway, I'm giving you and Jitsu another chance. Don't screw it up."

Jitsu folded his arms. "What can we do?"

"You and Lonnie could spar with the clan's soldiers. The army should be strong, not weak."

Jitsu and Lonnie hurried off. Hordak returned to his tent and sat by his desk. The papers and notes were piling up. They contained information regarding every clan member. He had crossed out the names of those who betrayed the clan. Individuals who joined were kept under close watch. Some outsiders were persuasive, luring the members out of the army.

Hordak hated it. People always came up with excuses to leave. Perhaps if the Horde Clan's idealogy was convincing, they would stay. Would they obey if he instituted stricter policies and rules?

Groaning, Hordak wrote down a few ideas. Within an hour, he went to the meeting tent. Everyone else made their way inside. Many of them wore either armor or chainmail. He glowered at the crowd.

Hordak took a deep breath. "From now on, the consequences of deserting the Horde Clan will be severe. It will be punishable by execution on sight. As for sneaking away in the middle of the night? Our footsoldiers shall catch and kill them. There is no mercy for those who choose to be the enemy. Do you understand?"

Several people exchanged glances before agreeing. The message should stick in their minds. After the meeting ended, everyone resumed their tasks in the base. Outside the tent, Hordak bumped into Entrapta.

"Watch where you're going," Hordak said.

"Oh, sorry. I was excited to brew more potions," Entrapta replied, smiling. Her grin was sheepish.

"The sigil is good, by the way. You've been helpful to me and the sorcerers."

"Do you appreciate me?"

"Yes. Why do you ask?"

"Before I joined the Horde Clan, some people treated me like the odd one out. My mind was different, which was why they refused to befriend me. You were one of the first to give me a chance. There was Scorpia, but she hadn't reached out in a while. Kyle doesn't talk to me. What was something that drew you to me?"

"You're intelligent, and I can open up to you without fear of judgment."

"Speaking of opening up, can you explain the reason behind the Horde Clan?"

Hordak led Entrapta to his tent. "We could keep the topic between us. Before founding the Horde Clan, I was part of a coven. We were trying to access the dark realm through a portal. Somehow, one of them found fault within me. They said I would drag them down. Thus, they kicked me out."

Entrapta frowned. "Why did they do it?"

"Because I don't use magic despite my lineage. Apparently, sigils weren't enough."

"What's interesting about the dark realm?"

"We wanted to explore a parallel world."

"You mean the spooky dimension."

"It's where Horde Prime is."

Hordak and Entrapta held the conversation for an hour. Soon, Entrapta left. Hordak enjoyed their friendship. As for parallel dimensions, he wasn't sure what he could find. Would there be danger lurking? Was there life in that world? If so, who else lived in it?

Within several days, Catra and her group visited the castle. Adora waited in the throne room. Someone else was with Catra, Bow, Scorpia, and Adam. It was a blonde man. Did Adora meet him at some point? Why did they bring him here? They all approached.

"This is Kyle. He left the Horde Clan," Adam explained.

"I recognize him," Adora said. "Kyle and Lonnie once ambushed me and Glimmer."

As if on cue, Glimmer moved closer to Adora's side. She glared at Kyle. He bowed his head, looking at his feet. Adora cleared her throat. The former Horde Clan member avoided her gaze.

"Were you and Lonnie responsible for the disturbances in the mountains?" Adora asked.

"Of course," Kyle replied. "Someone was with us. His name's Jitsu. He and Lonnie attacked the missing wagons. The victims were taking building supplies to a village."

"Do you acknowledge the harm in such actions?"

"Yes. Are you going to punish me?"

Adora exhaled. "You will send apology letters to those you've hurt. Also, you will repair broken wagons."

"Is that all?" Kyle asked.

"I think so. You may go now."

Catra led Kyle out of the throne room. Scorpia began talking to Bow. Adora and Glimmer strode to the council room. Juliet and Teela were sitting opposite each other.

Perfuma and Mermista sat next to a young girl. The girl could be fourteen. What was she doing here? A man in a brown tunic with chainmail underneath sat by the wall.

Adora occupied the chair at the center of the table. "I'm familiar with Juliet, Teela, Perfuma, and Mermista. Would the newcomers like to introduce themselves? I'm referring to the man and the teenage girl."

The man was the first to speak. "My name is Sunder. I'm a guard who patrols the Executioner's Grounds. I live in the Crimson Desert."

The teenager leaned back. "I'm Frosta. I'm from the Snow Mountains."

Adora figured they were here for a reason. "Sunder, has Shadow Weaver remained in her cell?"

Sunder grimaced. "She has. Even in prison, Shadow Weaver is being disruptive. She would cuss out the guards and threaten revenge."

"Disruptive? Threatening revenge?"

"Once, Shadow Weaver attempted to manipulate a soldier into releasing her. I had to intervene before the situation escalated. She swore she would avenge herself upon escaping."

"Have you decided on a punishment?"

"What do you think of a possible execution?"

Adora paused for a moment. Shadow Weaver had caused the deaths of several people. The old sorceress usurped Adora's parents and became a tyrant. Also, she unleashed a sleeping curse upon the current queen. Shadow Weaver abused Adora and Catra while raising them.

"I could discuss this with Catra," Adora said. "Shadow Weaver was a guardian to both of us. And an abusive one, at that. Someone could ask Shadow Weaver questions and see if she pleads guilty."

"Very well, Your Majesty," Sunder replied. "Though, I suspect she'll be dishonest."

"One of our sorcerers can use a truth spell on Shadow Weaver." Adora turned her attention to Frosta. "Frosta, how are things in the Snow Mountains?"

Frosta intertwined her fingers on the table. "We have been dealing with dark forces. Demonic creatures reside in the Snow Caverns."

"Snow Caverns?"

"Yeah. Its main chamber is corrupted. A dragon guards it."

"Did sinister magic corrupt the Snow Caverns?"

"I bet it did."

Adora inclined her head. "I suppose I could send someone to investigate the curse. Any other happenings they should be aware of?"

"Unnatural blizzards and black clouds. It's like something is controlling them."

"Maybe there is." Adora glanced at Perfuma and Mermista. "How are the forest and the ocean?"

Perfuma twisted a strand around her finger. "A dozen monsters attacked Plumeria Woods for the third time this week! Everyone in the forest is worried about the next invasion."

Adora's eyes widened. Didn't Glimmer help break the curse on Plumeria Woods? Was there anything they overlooked? Composing herself, she proceeded to ask Mermista.

"Were there any problems in the Kingdom of Salineas?" Adora said.

"I received reports of a few disappearances," Mermista replied. "The remaining merpeople are investigating."

"Any monsters?"

"There could be. The merpeople notified me of some unfortunate encounters."

Once the meeting ended, Glimmer turned to Adora. "Who's going to the Snow Mountains?"

Adora walked to the window. "I haven't decided. I couldn't leave the castle and go on an adventure. The kingdom needs me."

"Maybe we could send some sorcerers to the Snow Mountains?"

"I'll write a letter to Castaspella and ask her to suggest experienced sorcerers."

"It'll take a while for the letter to reach her."

"And what's the alternative?" Adora smoothed her gown. "Sending you into the middle of a blizzard?"

Glimmer sighed. "You're talking to the knight who slayed dangerous monsters and defeated Shadow Weaver."

"Good point. However, you got hurt from time to time. I had nightmares about losing you."

"I'm still here, you know."

They wandered to the courtyard and occupied a bench. Roses dotted the bushes. Flowery scents wafted in the air. Butterflies landed on the flowers. The clouds glided across the blue sky.

Adora rested her head on Glimmer's shoulder. It was relaxing compared to the council meetings. During those discussions, they always mentioned a problem to fix. She didn't want to neglect her

duty as the Queen of Grayskull. Instead, she hoped to be the leader the kingdom deserved.

As the new queen, Adora was still undoing the damage done during Shadow Weaver's tyranny. The kingdom hadn't completed its healing process. The Horde Clan continued harming the innocent. What would it take for them to stop?

Pulling away, Adora gazed at the clouds. A voice shouted her name, garnering her attention. Juliet waited in the doorway. What could be so important right now? Adora followed Juliet inside. Some hallways later, she entered the royal office. Juliet left.

More paperwork. Perfect. Just what a ruler needed. The hours dragged on as Adora worked on the papers. After sunset, she retreated to her bedroom. Exhaustion rolled over her as she plopped onto the bed. The door opened, then closed. Next were movements over the floor. Soft hums drifted into her ears.

Footsteps approached. Glimmer drew Adora into an embrace. Adora melted into the hug. She buried her face in the crook of Glimmer's neck. Glimmer played with her hair. The feeling of safety was undeniable. At the end of the day, she was free to be herself. And it was within the walls of her room.

Adora didn't have to worry about obligations and the opinions of others. Besides, her girlfriend and her friends knew who she was beneath the royal title.

Adora's forehead met Glimmer's. Their breaths mingled. She lost herself in Glimmer's eyes. Listening to the soft breathing, she shut her eyes. Glimmer's lips pressed against hers. The knight caressed Adora's back. What a pleasant way to end the day - nestled in a hug.

"I feel so lucky. Falling in love with such a beautiful woman," Glimmer said.

"So do I," Adora replied.

Their bodies pressed against each other. Both women whispered sweet nothings. Then, they reclined. Adora didn't want to let go. She was sure Glimmer felt the same.

"It's nice to not be interrupted," Adora whispered. "There's no Juliet to pull me away."

Glimmer chortled. "At least we have the night to ourselves."

"True."

Swords and Snow

Glimmer, Adora, and their friends decided who would visit the Snow Mountains. Glimmer would travel with Catra, Adam, and Bow. Teela and Scorpia would stay in the castle. The group finished preparing for the journey.

They rode the wagon northward. Upon approaching the northern portion of Grayskull, the temperature dropped. They continued traveling, even when enemies attacked. Often, Glimmer was swift to slay their foes.

By evening, everyone set up tents by a stream. Adam, Catra, and Bow gathered firewood. Glimmer draped a sheepskin cloak over herself, snuggling into its warmth. The fire emerged from the firewood, heating the immediate area.

"We should be in the Snow Mountains by noon tomorrow," Bow said, scrutinizing the map.

"Which means we'll deal with the worst parts of winter in one location," Catra replied. "I wonder what's inside the Snow Caverns, aside from demons. Not to mention dragons."

Adam rubbed his arms. "Perhaps a lot of ice."

Glimmer flashed a reassuring smile. "Good thing we have cozy and warm clothes. Oh, and a heating spell."

"We all thought ahead, didn't we?" Adam rested his palms on his lap. "So, you've been dating my sister for a while."

"Okay? Is there anything you want to say?"

"I can tell how much she means to you. I hope it's not too soon for me or anyone to ask. Do you imagine a future with Adora?"

"If it leads to a certain point in the relationship, yes."

"Do you love her?"

Glimmer nodded. "Of course. I'd do anything for Adora."

The moon rose higher into the sky as everyone chatted. Its silver glow cast a gentle, ethereal light. Silence washed over everyone. They all yawned. Glimmer, Catra, Bow, and Adam stepped inside their respective tents.

Glimmer slipped beneath her blanket. Her cloak served as an additional covering. Eyes fluttering shut, she rolled to her side. Her thoughts drifted to Adora. The blonde had been hesitant to let her go on the mission. She recalled how tight Adora hugged her. Though Glimmer said she would return, it didn't comfort Adora much. Adora's parting words were: "Come home safely."

At the moment, Adora could be in bed alone. Would the royal duties keep the blonde's mind occupied? More questions came. An hour passed, and Glimmer was in dreamland...

The drawbridge leading into Gray Haven came into view. For an odd reason, no guards patrolled the town. Did anything happen? Did Teela pull them in? Glimmer made her way into Gray Haven. No one was outside. The musicians were absent, as were the stalls. What was everyone doing? Glimmer's footsteps echoed.

Around the town square, abandoned buildings lined the streets. There were missing windows and doors. Broken objects cluttered the ground. Was there an invasion? Did anyone stay? The sky darkened, and thunder boomed. Blood spewed from the fountain. Something was wrong.

Glimmer raced to the castle. Fires burned the greenery to ashes. Upon entering the palace, she searched for Adora. The queen was nowhere to be found.

Teela and Scorpia were absent, too. Pitch-black fog penetrated the hallways and rooms. Glimmer settled on visiting the throne room. A man with glowing green eyes grabbed Adora's throat.

Glimmer reached for the sword, only to grasp empty air. A portal materialized near Adora. The next thing she knew, she found herself in an abandoned town. Its streets stretched for miles. The outskirts consisted of churning darkness. Behind her, the leaves crunched. The most she could register was a blur of fangs and claws. Its presence was ominous.

An unnatural growl sent shivers down Glimmer's spine. In an attempt to fight back, she fell to the ground. Everything went dark.

Glimmer jolted from her slumber, panting. A portal? The man with green eyes? Ruined towns? Was the nightmare telling her something? Was it connected to her recent thoughts regarding Horde Prime? Frigid air seeped through her blanket and cloak.

"It's just a tale," Glimmer whispered.

No matter how much Glimmer convinced herself, the words didn't calm her. She recalled Adora telling her about similar nightmares. Except in Adora's dreams, Horde Prime was mentioned. Green seemed to be a recurring color in their nightmares. She stood, then walked outside. The moon hovered above the western horizon. A canopy of stars glittered. Her gaze flitted between constellations.

The water in the stream trickled by, washing over rocks and branches. Within minutes, memories of the nightmare faded. Glimmer returned to the tent and reclined.

As time passed, the pull of slumber became apparent. Glimmer's body alternated between wakefulness and sleep. Brief dreams of awakening surfaced, most of them vivid and strange.

Glimmer slipped into unconsciousness, unaware of hours speeding by. In the morning, the knight awakened to footsteps outside. She stretched her arms and legs. Then, she gathered her possessions and stashed them in her bag. After putting on armor, she boarded

the wagon with her friends. The horses trotted, drawing the wagon north. A frigid wind howled.

"How did the residents of the Snow Mountains handle the cold?" Catra asked.

"A higher tolerance, I guess?" Bow replied.

Glimmer leaned against the window. "It could be the clothes they wear."

Adam adjusted his gloves. "Or they're shapeshifters that turn into animals with tons of hair." He grinned. "Just kidding."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Very funny."

The path led the group to a winding, snowy trail. Hundreds of snowflakes blurred the windows. Within several hours, they arrived in a village. The cottages were made out of stone, although they resembled snow. Its locals wore heavy layers. A few people gathered fish from an icy lake. Young children tossed snowballs at each other.

Glimmer and her group disembarked the wagon. A woman with delicate facial features approached them. The woman might be in her mid-forties, with dark under-eye circles and platinum locks. Her tunic displayed a familiar emblem on its right side. Was she a sorceress from Mystacor Village?

"Hello. How is the journey to this town? Frosta said the Queen of Grayskull would send someone to investigate the curse," the woman said. "My name is Chione. I'm one of Frosta's advisors."

"I'm Glimmer. I saved Grayskull from Shadow Weaver's tyranny. My friends helped," Glimmer replied. "We're here to find the Snow Caverns."

"You are a courageous young woman. I must warn you, dangers lurk in the Snow Caverns. One of the villagers went in. He suffered life-threatening injuries upon fleeing."

"Wow. Anyway, do you possess magical powers?"

Chione nodded. "Yes. However, my barrier spell is losing its strength. I've been maintaining it without taking breaks. The attacks were relentless. I saw horrifying creatures. Their faces would haunt anyone's dreams."

Glimmer glanced around. The townsfolk seemed on edge. Was there anyone helping Chione? Or was the older sorceress the only one guarding the town? She tried to see if there was. Many of them didn't have a backbone. Were they ill-prepared? Were they uninterested in fighting? Should Glimmer lend a hand in case? Should she go ahead and explore the Snow Caverns?

"Is there anything we can do? You look tired," Glimmer said.

"No. Thanks for asking," Chione replied.

"How much more magic can you use before exhausting yourself?"

"I'll be fine."

Just then, black clouds descended from the sky, surrounding the village. A magical barrier flickered. Everyone began dashing into their homes in a panic, screaming in terror. No one lifted a finger to help Chione. The middle-aged woman passed out, reclining on the ground. Reptilian monsters emerged from the black clouds.

Glimmer, Catra, Bow, and Adam began defending the village. She led the charge, cutting through hordes of monsters. Catra, in her panther form, clawed the beasts and bit them. Bow unleashed arrows. Adam slashed the rest of their foes.

Glimmer conjured a strong barrier once she and her friends were done. When Chione awakened, the group helped her walk into a house. Glimmer's spell should do for now. They all sat in the living room. The fireplace emitted heat.

"Did you save the village?" Chione asked, yawning as she sat up.

"Yes," Glimmer said. "And the barrier should be sturdy this time. Can you tell us where to go? We still intend to explore the Snow Caverns. One of us could guard the town."

"I would appreciate some assistance. As for directions, go on the westward path. It'll lead you to the Snow Caverns. By the way, you remind me of someone I knew. Her name's Angella."

"Were you a part of her group in the past?"

"I was until it fell apart. At the time, I left Mystacor Village. It had been a period of uncertainty, as I had no idea where I could go. Then, I came here and bought this cottage."

"How did you know Frosta? Were you acquaintances with her parents?"

"Her guardians are Spinnerella and Netossa. Frosta's parents died when she was small."

Something about the second sentence reminded Glimmer of Adora. Frosta and Adora had one thing in common - losing parents at a young age.

"How old was she when it happened?" Glimmer asked.

"Seven," Chione said. "Why do you ask?"

"It reminded me of Queen Adora's story regarding her younger years." Glimmer pointed a thumb at Adam. "Adam could stay here. Catra, Bow, and I will visit the Snow Caverns."

Adora breezed through her royal duties. All she could think about was Glimmer. She had sent the knight and her friends into danger. They could handle themselves. However, something unexpected could occur.

Frosta's description of the Snow Mountains gave Adora a vague idea of what they could expect. Unnatural blizzards? Clouds? Evil

creatures? She ignored the ache in her wrist as she wrote on each paper.

Once Adora finished writing, she put the quill into the ink bottle. The royal twins could have agreed to a diarchy. Still, Adam preferred going on adventures over staying in the castle.

As a result, Adora carried the responsibilities on her shoulders. The weight of the crown was tiring. And whenever she was in her girlfriend's embrace, she would relax. There would be no thought of royal responsibilities.

During those hugs, Adora would give herself permission to not think. It often felt like home. A knock on the door garnered her attention. It was Keldor. Was he here to criticize her reign? The last time they spoke, he looked down on her for apparent inexperience. She was trying her best for Grayskull. Keldor refused to acknowledge that.

And to top it all off, Keldor's behavior was suspicious. Did he have anything to do with the upcoming war? Adora rested her chin on her intertwined hands. If he was involved, would he express approval of the Horde Clan's strategy?

"Are you here to belittle me some more?" Adora asked. "Another question - what is Hordak planning?"

Keldor plopped into a chair, draping his arms over the armrests. "I was offering my honesty. Something Juliet hesitated to do. As for Hordak and his clan, there will be a war. He'll order the attack."

"Are their sorcerers still trying to release Horde Prime?"

"Can you at least focus on the problems in Grayskull first? Sure, you could get the troops ready for battle. If I were you, I'd pause before making rash decisions."

Adora pressed her fingers against her temples. "Answer the question about Horde Prime."

Keldor shot up and stormed to the door. "For all we know, Horde Prime could be mythical. He can't be real! The Horde Clan's sorcerers are chasing fables."

"Tell me the truth." Adora considered insisting on a confession. She decided against it based on Keldor's initial reaction to her words. "I bet there's a reason my father was king instead of you."

"Whatever, foolish queen."

Keldor stomped into the hallway. Adora gritted her teeth. She could tell he was avoiding the question. It made her think of Shadow Weaver's deception. Sighing, the queen walked to the council room. A group of soldiers were waiting. Perfuma and Mermista were here again.

Adora took a seat. "Hello, everyone. Are there any more updates? We have to prepare for the war. The Horde Clan needs to be stopped."

Juliet bowed her head. "I've received reports of various scuffles by the border. Other members of the Horde Clan raided villages."

"And their sorcerers?"

"A spy saw them putting more effort into their spells. Given enough time, they could free Horde Prime."

Adora processed the words in her mind. Then, she parted her lips to speak. "I could assign several guards to protect the villages and the borders. Everyone else in our army could confront the Horde Clan. Teela and Scorpia will watch the castle's entrances and exits."

Juliet crossed her arms. "We have to be careful not to squander our best fighters. Some warriors were trained to deal with powerful enemies."

Adora's fingers drummed the table. "Mermista, how's the Kingdom of Salineas?"

Mermista lowered her brows. "We discovered the source of the disappearances. Most of us rescued the survivors. However, we lost the others."

"It's unfortunate that you suffered some losses. I could send assistance to your kingdom."

"Thanks. Is there anything I can do to repay you? It was brave of you and Glimmer to defeat the beast in the Seabed Caverns."

"You don't have to repay me. We wouldn't have breathed underwater without the seashell necklaces." Adora turned her attention to Perfuma. "I could send the troops to Plumeria Woods. Their presence may hinder future invasions."

Perfuma grinned. "That would be nice. Would they keep us safe during the war, though?"

"They will."

Everyone continued discussing strategies. As the meeting concluded, a soldier barged in, breathless. He took a moment to catch his breath. Adora rose, straightening her spine.

"What is it?" Adora asked.

"They're coming!" The soldier exclaimed.

"Who is?"

"The Horde Clan. Their army is marching closer!"

Adora's heart froze at the information. "How much time do we have to prepare?"

"Not as much as we hoped."

Unpleasant images flashed through Adora's mind. She composed herself. "Everyone, grab your armor and weapons. Go to the stables and mount your horses. I'll go with you."

Juliet touched Adora's shoulder. "Your Majesty, the kingdom cannot lose you."

Adora's gaze met Juliet's concerned expression. "Glimmer taught me to use a sword in the past. I could help. I'm the Queen of Grayskull."

"Alright. Be careful out there."

Adora made her way to her room and changed clothes. Instead of a gown with an apron-sash, she wore a tunic and leggings. She fastened pieces of armor over her body. The reflection in the mirror gazed back at her. Gone were the days of her unconfident self. She was ready to face the upcoming battle.

Upon leaving the castle, Adora and the troops rode into the battlefield. The Horde Clan was vast, its soldiers brandishing weapons. Their leader, Hordak, was at the front.

Adora maintained a calm facade. A familiar face accompanied Hordak. Keldor? Their suits of dark armor gave them a menacing appearance. In a slow, sure motion, she drew her sword. She glanced at Grayskull's soldiers.

"Charge!" Adora shouted.

Both armies advanced, weapons clanging. Horses neighed. Hoofbeats pounded the grass. Shouts rang through the air, mingling with metallic clashes. At first, Adora remained at a safe distance, only fighting when attacked. Soon, Keldor approached her. His scowl was sinister.

"What do you want?" Adora asked, bracing herself.

Keldor dismounted his horse. "To destroy you. Your brother is next."

Adora hopped off her own horse. "Do you have an issue with us because my father got to be king instead of you?"

"I see you're as arrogant as Randor had been."

"And you won't hesitate to hurt your family, huh?" Adora held her sword in front of her chest. "Going after your niece and nephew?"

Keldor's sword glinted in broad daylight. Blood-red jewels dotted the cross-guard. The armor covered every inch of his torso and legs. Adora tightened her grip on her sword. Her knuckles blanched. She could tell he had years of experience. A bellow drilled into her ears. The tip of Keldor's blade nicked her leg. It took her by surprise.

Adora stumbled back. Keldor had answered her question without saying a word. She dodged the incoming blows. He closed the distance and grabbed her wrist.

"You don't have anyone to protect you," Keldor said. "Once Horde Prime comes, it will be over. The Horde Clan will destroy everything and everyone you hold dear. This is war, not some game."

"Then why did you say what you said about him earlier?" Adora replied.

"You never ceased to be nosy. Sending your warriors after us? What did you hope to gain from that?"

Adora attempted to pull her wrist from Keldor's grip. Her struggle didn't make him budge. He tightened his hold. She drove a foot into his groin. He released her.

"You and the Horde Clan are hurting innocent people!" Adora said, rubbing her wrist.

Keldor let out a cruel snicker. "I don't care who gets hurt in the end. No amount of kicking will slow me down."

"You're heartless monsters. All of you!"

"The weak won't last long. The strong will prevail."

Their swords clanged. Adora poured her strength into pushing back. Keldor showed no signs of giving up. They exchanged parries, strikes, and hits. Both warriors ignored the distant sounds of battle. Adora took advantage of an opening and slashed Keldor.

"It's not over," Keldor said as he recovered from the blow. He widened his stance.

"We'll make sure you and the Horde Clan won't succeed," Adora replied.

The walk to the Snow Caverns had been swift. Glimmer had used a spell to repel the unnatural blizzard. She followed Catra and Bow into the icy tunnel. Stalagmites dotted the floor. Despite the warming spell surrounding the trio, the temperature sank. Heavy footsteps echoed off the walls. A growl reverberated.

"How many do you guess could be lurking?" Bow asked.

"Maybe a dozen or so," Glimmer said.

Catra opened a small chest by a stalagmite. "A map and a key. Got it."

Glimmer strode ahead. "It'll be like exploring Plumeria Sanctuary. Or the Seabed Caverns."

"I remember you telling me of those quests."

They proceeded into a passageway. It ascended to a chamber with floating platforms. Below them, a foggy abyss waited to swallow the group whole. On the opposite side of the chamber, Glimmer saw creatures resembling boars. They sported spikes on their backs. Their teeth and tusks were sharp.

They looked up, then glared at Glimmer and her companions. She led Catra and Bow to the nearest platform. The next one approached, and they hopped. It floated to the third one. The trio repeated the action.

They landed on the opposite side. The demon boars charged at them. Glimmer conjured a shield to deflect their attacks. The impact was audible, similar to a metallic noise. The knight expelled an air spell, sending them flying backward. She watched them descend into the abyss.

Catra unlocked a door a few steps away. She turned the knob and peered into an adjacent room. Within seconds, she said the coast was clear. They continued into the chamber. As soon as they entered, the presence of evil became palpable.

Glimmer sensed that they were being watched. In the center of the room, multiple chains held an ominous blade in place. Catra transformed into a panther and began scrutinizing it.

Something must have caught Catra's attention, as she had let out a growl. Was it a ghost? Glimmer poked at the chains with the tip of the sword. Behind them, Bow shot a worried glance. The eerie whispers made the hairs on Glimmer's neck stand.

Then, Catra bit one of the chains and gave a quick pull. The specter could have originated from forbidden magic. Or it could be from the dark realm. An unnatural shriek startled the trio. The sword levitated into the air as though someone moved it. A dark mist emphasized the specter's silhouette.

Bow barraged the specter with multiple arrows. It dodged each missile. Glimmer unleashed runes at their enemy, slowing it down. With a lunge, Catra pinned it to the ground. The specter roared, sending a blast that sent Catra flying toward the wall. She was now unconscious.

Using a magical shield, Glimmer blocked the demon's attacks. An opening revealed itself. The knight plunged her sword into the skeletal torso. It bellowed in agony. She repeated the stabs and slices. With a flick of the wrist, the specter levitated Glimmer.

It flung Glimmer at a stalagmite. Groaning, she forced herself up. She summoned a fireball and launched it. The flaming sphere

enveloped her enemy.

Once the fire vanished, it left behind a pile of ashes. A black tendril floated through the ceiling. Catra awakened, then strode toward the ashes.

"Perhaps it was gone for good," Glimmer said. "Let's find the dragon."

"That demon was scary," Bow said. "It could have made its way out of the dark realm in the past."

"We should finish the quest as quick as possible. I want to see how things are going in Grayskull."

In truth, Glimmer wanted to check on Adora. The disturbing nightmare had given her a bad feeling. What if something happened in her absence? What would the Horde Clan do while she was away?

Horde Prime

Grayskull's soldiers slayed their enemies. Hordak called for reinforcements. His troops, along with monsters, fought back. Adora had managed to beat Keldor in a sword fight. She figured it was sheer luck. Her army tried to kill the beasts. Both sides struggled to gain the upper hand. For every foe defeated, Grayskull lost ten more warriors. The kingdom's fate was at stake.

By evening, the Horde Clan retreated. They still posed a threat to the Kingdom of Grayskull. Adora limped into her suite and shut the door behind her. Those foes were formidable opponents. She removed her armor, careful not to disturb her injuries. For a minute, she thought about her clothing choices. Should she be in her nightgown? Or wear a formal gown until bedtime?

Adora chose the latter. As a queen, she wished she could do more for her people. The survivors had to recover from injuries. They had to bury the dead soldiers. Should she enlist some sorcerers? She knew they wouldn't use weapons. At least they had powerful magic. However, an enemy could ambush them when they weren't looking.

Muttering under her breath, Adora wandered to the throne room. It was challenging to maintain a good posture due to physical pain. With each step, her ankles throbbed. The tenderness would spread to her calves whenever she moved them. Keldor certainly didn't go easy on her during their scuffle.

Glimmer would have been helpful. The knight was skilled in sword fighting and magic. Adora, on the other hand, wasn't allowed to train while Shadow Weaver ruled. Glimmer did teach her during their journey together. Juliet's voice interrupted Adora's thoughts.

"Your Majesty, someone is here to speak with you," Juliet said.

"Thanks for letting me know," Adora replied. She leaned back on her throne. "Can you go check on the survivors in Gray Haven's

infirmary? You could follow Scorpia and Teela."

"I will."

Juliet hurried out of the room. A man with light blue hair and a cerulean tunic entered. He had an hourglass waist. Overall, his appearance was feminine.

"Hello. What brings you here?" Adora asked.

"I figured I could pay a visit to the new queen of Grayskull," the man replied. "I'm Peekablue."

"Is there a reason for your presence?"

"Yes. This morning, I received a troubling vision."

Adora tilted her head. "What did you see?"

Peekablue clasped his hands together. "I was in a room. The wall torches were the only sources of illumination. A mirror appeared. Its reflection swirled. Green flames surrounded it, then stretched to the ceiling. The next thing I knew, the same fire spread from village to village. I saw people bowing to a tall warlord. They were trembling and whimpering."

Could the warlord be Horde Prime? Adora let the words repeat in her mind. What Peekablue said next unnerved her. He mentioned the royal family.

"A hooded figure with green eyes had put a crown into a birdcage," Peekablue said.

A crown in a birdcage? What could it mean? Would Adora or Adam be held hostage? Would another enemy usurp the royal family? More unsettling questions surfaced.

Adora found her voice at last. "Is that all?"

Peekablue nodded. "There will be a period of darkness."

"I was trying to help Grayskull recover from Shadow Weaver's tyranny. Now, another threat is coming."

"It won't be forever."

Peekablue left the castle without another word. Adora wanted to follow him and ask for answers. However, she couldn't. She walked to the window. When would Glimmer and the others return? She recalled the unfinished letter on her desk.

Adora made her way to her room and sat by her desk. She could add a new paragraph to the letter. It would include what Peekablue told her. Did the vision compel him to warn her? She wrote whatever came to mind. Later, she handed the letter to someone and told him to go to the Snow Mountains. The moon ascended into the sky. Now wearing her nightgown, she reclined on her bed and fell asleep...

The battlefield was much more gruesome than Adora remembered. Dismembered bodies, blood-stained horses, and shattered armor. The Horde Clan sat on their steeds, smirking. They didn't move. This entire situation was eerie. For some reason, a mirror lingered in the middle of the battlefield.

An invisible force drew Adora closer to the mirror. She blinked, then found herself in a cell. Where was she? Holding her breath, she checked the walls and bars. Nothing budged. A torch in the hallway flickered. She glimpsed a man in armor.

"Who... who are you?" Adora asked, her voice wavering.

The man flashed a cruel grin as he stepped closer. Adora pressed her back against the wall. What would he do to her? He stopped in front of the bars. His eyes glowed green.

"I have you now," he said.

"What are you going to do?" Adora replied.

The man threw his head back, cackling. It was a cold laugh. What was so funny? Adora wished she knew what made him react this way. Was it her tone? There was no way out. She tried screaming for help. No one came.

"Crown... birdcage..."

Adora's eyes flung open. On instinct, she reached for the empty side of her bed. Her hand met pillows and blankets. Heart palpitating, she attempted to process the nightmare. She wrapped her arms around a pillow and sobbed. For a moment, she pretended it was Glimmer hugging her. She longed for that comforting touch. It always made her feel safe.

The last two words in the dream? It reminded Adora of what Peekablue said. However, someone else uttered them. She hadn't seen the speaker. Releasing the pillow, she slipped out of bed. She opened the window, basking in the cool air.

The scents of nature wafted in the breeze. It made Adora forget the nightmare. She propped her elbows against the sill, counting the constellations. As much as she preferred daylight, she couldn't deny how peaceful the night was. It wouldn't make sense to stay awake until sunrise, though. Yawning, she returned to bed.

The fight against the dragon in the Snow Caverns had been challenging. Glimmer and her group remained in the village for a week to recover. One morning, they loaded their wagon with their possessions. Someone handed a letter to Glimmer, then left. It was from Adora. In the first part, the queen mentioned how much she missed Glimmer. The rest of it sounded urgent.

"Glimmer, what is it?" Bow asked.

"Adora sent me a message. She's worried about Horde Prime destroying Grayskull," Glimmer said.

Catra opened the wagon door. "Is Horde Prime on the loose already?"

"I don't know. But, we must prepare ourselves for a possible confrontation. We'll go to the castle, first things first. We have to make sure nothing happens to Adora."

Adam carried a bag to the wagon. "What's going on?"

"We got a letter from Adora," Glimmer said. "She spoke of Horde Prime and the Horde Clan."

"Has Horde Prime escaped the dark realm? And what is the Horde Clan doing?"

"We'll find out when we arrive at the castle. Adora said the Horde Clan instigated a battle some time ago."

"Was it intense?"

"I bet it was."

The four of them boarded the wagon. Within seconds, the horses pulled it out of town. The journey to Grayskull had begun. This time, there were no dark clouds and unnatural blizzards. Hoofbeats picked up the pace. As morning transitioned into noon, they chose a shortcut. So far, the weather remained calm.

"You were so brave in the Snow Caverns," Catra said.

Glimmer opened her spellbook. "Yeah, considering that the dragon breathes out ice." She scrutinized the pages. "I had to use fire magic."

"Are you studying spells right now?"

"Of course." Glimmer turned a page. "I've learned to use most of them. There are others I haven't practiced. So far, it's air magic, fire, and light. Not to mention levitation and teleportation. There's also the stasis spell and the ability to blow things up using hand gestures. Some sorcerers refer to it as the ability to manipulate matter."

"And how about wielding the sword?"

"I could enchant it with magic."

Catra rested her hands on her lap. "Does it mean you'll become one of the strongest warriors in Grayskull?"

Glimmer smirked. "Perhaps."

Bow grinned. "Glimmer, your parents would be proud of you. Saving others, breaking curses, and overthrowing Shadow Weaver."

"I'm sure they would." Glimmer flipped another page. "I hope I don't fail to protect the kingdom. And as a knight, I'm supposed to keep Adora safe."

"Scorpia and Teela are guarding the castle."

"True, but an experienced sorcerer could knock them out. Someone such as Shadow Weaver."

Catra shrugged. "Good point. Speaking of Shadow Weaver, I'd like to ask her why she was cruel."

Glimmer furrowed her brows. "You mean, you want to talk to her? After what Shadow Weaver put you and Adora through?"

"I could. I'll do my best not to let Shadow Weaver hurt me."

"Would it be alright for someone to accompany you just in case?"

"I'd prefer to talk to her alone."

"Okay."

The hours that passed were a blur. Sometimes, the group chatted. Other times, they didn't. Even at night, they didn't stop riding the wagon. They took turns either staying awake or sleeping. By midnight, they set up their tents.

Glimmer and her companions entered their tents. Nearby, a twig snapped. Muffled voices spoke. The horses whinnied before swishing their tails. Their ears pinned back. Glimmer attempted to calm them. However, they didn't quiet down. Another snap alerted her to a potential foe lurking in the bushes. More footsteps crept toward the tents.

The moonlight revealed the Horde Clan's emblem on their capes. One of them grabbed Adam. Glimmer sprung to action, fighting her enemies. The blades clanged. Bow and Catra joined in. Adam's captors held him in a vice-like grip.

"Surrender, and we'll release the prince," the female said.

"Let him go, or you'll regret it!" Catra retorted.

"Says the people that made Kyle betray us!"

"Lonnie, we didn't convince him. He chose to leave the Horde Clan."

"Whatever." Lonnie shook her head. "Jitsu, hold the prince. I'll bring reinforcements." She raced off.

Glimmer, Bow, and Catra glowered at Jitsu. In response, the muscular man snickered. Glimmer summoned an electrical sphere. The orb emitted sparks. Jitsu brought his sword to Adam's neck.

"Attack, and I'll kill him," Jitsu said.

"Don't do it," Bow said. "Please don't kill him."

"Give me one reason why I shouldn't. Adam's as much of a threat to the Horde Clan as Adora is. They'll sic their soldiers on us. And don't get us started on Horde Prime."

Glimmer cleared her throat. "Wait a minute. What did you say about Horde Prime?"

Jitsu narrowed his eyes. "Shut up. I won't reveal the Horde Clan's strategies to an enemy!"

"But does one of them involve Horde Prime?"

"Why does it matter to you?"

Suddenly, a cluster of Horde Clan members ambushed Glimmer and her friends. One of them, Evelyn, stepped forward. Her hands glowed with magic. Both women shot spells at each other. Bow and Catra battled their foes. Evelyn seemed intent on distracting Glimmer from noticing what was going on.

Their kinetic blasts lit up the area around them. Bow's arrows made several hits. Catra sunk her fangs into one individual's leg. Glimmer poured all her determination into taking down Evelyn.

"Weren't you supposedly the 'hero of Grayskull?' I thought you'd be faster," Evelyn snarked.

"And how did you even have the energy for this? It's late!" Glimmer spat.

"We were sure you'd be sleeping by then."

"So, you followed us. And you all instigated the fight. What do you want?"

Pained shouts pierced the night. Glimmer glanced in the direction of the sound. Catra and Bow fell unconscious. Adam was nowhere in sight. Did the Horde Clan kidnap the prince?

"You and your friends will never win," Evelyn said, chuckling.

"You're wrong!" Glimmer retorted.

Evelyn shot a spell at Glimmer. The next thing Glimmer knew, she fell to the ground. Her consciousness began slipping. She listened to receding footsteps and a wagon's movement.

In the morning, Adora received a troubling letter from a member of the Horde Clan. They said they were holding Adam captive. The last part of the message asked if Adora could surrender. She tried to focus on her royal duties throughout the day.

Adora hoped the others were okay. Once evening came, she sat in her office, writing a response. There could be another way to solve the situation. She didn't want anything happening to her brother. Juliet yanked the door open.

"Is there any news?" Adora asked.

"The castle is under attack!" Juliet replied.

Adora's heart skipped a beat. "Is it the Horde Clan?"

"Yes. The Horde Clan bypassed the defenses. Their leader, Horde Prime, helped them."

Adora's hands trembled as she set down the papers. "Go help the guards. I'll figure out what to do."

Juliet rushed away. Adora made her way to her bedroom and retrieved the sword. She ran to the throne room. In front of the grand doors stood a man from her dreams. He was as menacing in the waking world. His green eyes scrutinized her body.

"And this is how you plan to welcome me?" He asked.

"Are you... Horde Prime?" Adora replied.

"Yes. And you're the queen. You must have heard of the legends."

"Did the Horde Clan's sorcerers release you?"

Horde Prime approached, footsteps echoing. The wicked man must be an experienced warrior. Had he killed his enemies in the past? Adora wasn't sure she wanted to know.

"They have. And I will lead the Horde Clan to victory," Horde Prime said.

"What will happen to me and my brother?" Adora asked.

"I seek to bring order. Those who resist will meet an unfortunate fate." Horde Prime stepped closer, towering over Adora. "I will not allow myself to be sent back to my prison again."

Adora backed away, noting the threatening tone in Horde Prime's voice. She raised her sword and attempted to land a hit. He caught the blade with his hand. Despite the cold expression, anger darkened his eyes. He yanked the weapon and threw it across the room.

"You have defied me," Horde Prime said. "You weren't the first one to do so. And they succeeded a long time ago. I won't go easy on anyone this time."

"My friends will stop you," Adora replied.

"No, they won't."

Horde Prime conjured a crystal prison that encased Adora. A portal materialized. Where was he sending her? She slammed her fists against the durable barrier.

"Let me go!" Adora shouted.

Adora's effort to escape was fruitless. She floated through the portal. Squeezing her eyes shut, she braced herself for what she could encounter. Hot tears streamed down her cheeks. Her eyes fluttered open, and she found herself in a dark cell. The magical barrier was gone. Heavy chains restrained her ankles. Images of Glimmer flashed into her mind.

Glimmer would save Adora. Though the situation seemed dire, Adora clung to that hope. It was better than caving to fear and despair. She pressed her back against the wall and slid to the floor. Footsteps walked past. She peered into the hallway.

Whatever this place was, it had guards. They don't seem friendly. Each one wore heavy armor and a cloak. One of them stared at her.

The face was hidden, but Adora noticed the glowing eyes. This individual wandered off. A part of her wanted to search for an escape route. However, the chains would hold her in place. She glanced at a barred window. Maybe she could look outside.

Adora rose to her height, stood on her toes, and took a peek. Cold air seeped into the cell. The darkness was unnatural. It concealed everything in strange shadows. Was she in a fortress in the middle of the dark realm? Winged silhouettes glided across the sky. Were they birds or demonic creatures?

The blackness was something out of a nightmare. Adora suppressed a shudder. The sun and moon could be nonexistent in this eerie dimension. Were the stars gone, too? At least she saw the ground below. It was faint. A blur of a twisted creature spooked her.

A haunting howl sent shivers down Adora's spine. She had heard and seen enough. Without a second thought, she sat on the floor. How was Grayskull doing in her absence? Would the Horde Clan go after those she loved? How was her brother handling her disappearance? What about Glimmer, Catra, Bow, and the others?

Adora wished there was some way to contact them. In truth, there wasn't. Footsteps came. It was Horde Prime. She steeled her nerves, trying to maintain her composure.

Horde Prime smirked. "I will crush the resistance in Grayskull. The kingdom is mine to take. You will rot in here. Your brother may join you."

"Don't touch them," Adora said.

"Your words cannot sway me. According to my loyal followers, you have a knight. She hasn't been fulfilling her duty lately, has she?"

"What are you getting at?"

Horde Prime laughed. "Do you not find it pointless to put on a brave front? I can see the fear in your eyes." He tapped the lock with a single finger. "Your pathetic sword hasn't done much, has it?"

Adora swallowed a lump in her throat. She couldn't give her captor the satisfaction. "I know what you're doing. You're trying to break my spirit. Why don't you end my life, then?"

"I'd like to see what your friends will do once they realize their queen is missing. They will try to destroy me, I bet." Horde Prime scowled. "In the end, they will suffer for refusing to submit."

Adora gasped. "Are you going to hurt them?"

"I could start with your knight."

"No. Don't." Adora's heart raced. "Please leave her alone."

Horde Prime opened the steel door and entered. He crouched, now eye-level. His icy fingers gripped Adora's chin. She sensed her composure melting away.

"You are as predictable as everyone else in the light realm. So emotional and so obsessed with love," Horde Prime said. "It's a wonder the Goddess tolerates the sight of you people tripping over your feelings."

"She gave us emotions for a reason," Adora replied. "Something your cold heart didn't have. It's why the legendary heroine and her friends locked you away. It's all because you desired power."

"You will never see your kingdom again. Your knight and your friends won't stand a chance."

"Don't consider it." Adora struggled to keep her tone neutral. "I'll do anything you want. Just leave them alone."

Horde Prime straightened his spine, looming over Adora as usual. "Very well. You will have to agree to something. We could discuss it later."

Horde Prime walked away. Adora stared after him. What would he have her do? And what would happen if she didn't comply? She sobbed into her hands. The isolation and uncertainty weighed upon her soul. Sniffling, she gazed at the ceiling. Her bottom lip trembled. She never asked for any of this. For now, she could only look forward to the end of the ordeal.

Into the Dark

Glimmer, Catra, and Bow arrived at the castle. There were signs of an invasion - broken windows, stairs, and fallen chandeliers. Several guards lay comatose. They hadn't found Scorpia or Teela. The trio snuck into Adora's room and searched every corner. The queen wasn't here.

Glimmer tried a location spell. It didn't come with any results. However, the rune floated to a mirror. Its reflection rippled.

"Does it mean Adora is in the dark realm?" Glimmer asked.

"I guess," Bow said.

Catra's fingers brushed the metallic frame. "Is there a spell to transport us to another realm?"

Glimmer shrugged. "I've never used it before. I'll try my best." Her hands gleamed with a magical aura. The spell trickled into the mirror. Not once did she break her focus.

"Is it-" Catra began.

"Shh." Bow held up a finger. "She has to concentrate."

Glimmer envisioned a portal opening up. Soon, the mirror revealed something resembling a tunnel. A faint, low hum reverberated. It worked. The trio counted to three, then jumped in. Upon entering the dark realm, Glimmer observed her surroundings. Bow and Catra opened their eyes.

They were in the middle of some abandoned village. The houses could have been destroyed. Or perhaps they decayed over time. The fog around the town churned, shrouding the distance. Glimmer unsheathed the sword.

"The town is so weird," Catra said. "There's no sign of life here."

"Let's stick together. The dark realm is dangerous," Glimmer said.

"Safety in numbers. Got it."

Glimmer led Catra and Bow to a small hill. The cold air was unlike the temperatures in the Snow Mountains. She figured the absence of sunlight caused this. They ascended the slope and reached the top.

The view from here made it easy to see the town limits. A few chasms yawned here and there. The grass was brown and withered. Was rain nonexistent, too?

Many miles in the distance, mountains stretched high into the featureless sky. There was a castle-like structure. Glimmer scrutinized the area for possible landmarks. She suspected there was something significant about the fortress. But what?

"I bet Horde Prime corrupted this dimension centuries ago," Bow said.

"That's what I thought, too," Catra said.

Glimmer set her foot on the slope. "There has to be a map. We could search the houses."

"It could take a while."

They descended the hill. As soon as they did, they checked every house. The map was nowhere to be found. An hour ticked by. Still nothing. Glimmer, Catra, and Bow strode to the town center. The fountain was dry. Cracks zigzagged along the cobblestone streets.

"How did the absent inhabitants not see a need for maps?" Glimmer asked.

"There were no compasses, either," Bow said.

Catra propped a hand against her hip. "How did those people find their way around the strange realm?"

They exchanged glances before approaching town limits. Every cottage had the same structure. The streets were identical, too. Something about the outskirts was unnerving. They avoided the chasms. Sure, there were a few bridges, but they seemed unstable.

The trio approached the outskirts again. Glimmer conjured an orb of light. Its glow penetrated the darkness. The blackness churned as if pushing back. Just how thick was the fog? She poured more energy into the light spell. The visibility improved somewhat.

Glimmer led the way, ensuring that Bow and Catra remained nearby. Dried leaves crunched beneath their feet.

Glimmer listened for suspicious noises. The monsters could be more aggressive in this dimension. In the light world, they usually attacked in groups. Perhaps it was also the case in this place.

So far, the trio hadn't encountered anything. A creature with scraggly fur and yellow eyes pounced on Bow, knocking him to the ground. The archer struggled underneath its weight.

The growls echoed. Glimmer swung the sword at the beast, sending it flying. It was hard to tell if the creature was a wolf or another animal. Its claws and fangs were sharp. The knight widened her stance, daring the beast to advance. Within seconds, it lunged at her. She blocked her chest using the sword. One swing. The blade's tip gashed the monster's side. Her foe tumbled into the stream.

Glimmer watched the stream, adrenaline coursing through her. Behind her, Catra helped Bow up. Glimmer stepped closer and cast a healing spell.

"How are you feeling?" Glimmer asked.

"A little better. Still shaken," Bow said.

Glimmer released an audible exhale. "We could encounter more of those monsters."

Catra peeked over her shoulder, then at Glimmer. "Yeah. No wonder people call it the dark realm. And the monster? It looked evil."

Glimmer recalled the yellow eyes. It was true the creature had a sinister expression. If it had slayed either Bow or Catra...

Catra cocked her head to one side. "So, are we going to get moving or what?"

"Oh, right. We have a rescue mission to complete," Glimmer said. "You seem a little nervous. Didn't you say you were fearless or something?" Her tone was lighthearted.

"Well, how were you unbothered? We're dealing with demonic enemies."

"Let's just say I've seen more things than you did."

They continued their banter as they proceeded through the darkness. The minutes became hours. Heaviness settled in Glimmer's abdomen. The group didn't have food or water for a while. A pond came into view. It was murky and greenish. It emitted the stench of rotten vegetation. Should they drink from this one?

"It stinks," Catra pointed out.

"I know. But there wasn't a lot of water on the way here," Glimmer said. "Would you rather go without having a drink?"

"I'm not sure. It's not the same as the water in Grayskull."

"There's one way to find out."

Glimmer cupped her hands beneath the water's surface. A purification spell told her it was safe. She brought it to her lips. The refreshing liquid trickled down her throat as she sipped. Even if it wasn't Grayskull's water, it possessed no adverse effect. She took out a canteen and gathered some of it.

"The water's safe," Glimmer said.

Bow and Catra drank some of the liquid. Several paces to the right, the fog began fading. A silhouette or two floated past. They appeared to be bipedal. Glimmer swore they had glowing eyes. Whispers drifted into her ears.

The trio followed the path out of the fog. Some rock formations stretched upward. Others curved in twisted arches. Under one arch, a faceless statue lingered.

Piles of skeletons cluttered the dead garden. Death had replaced life a long time ago. All that was left were evil creatures. Demons, to be exact. Spores levitated along the wind.

A lantern dangled in the air. Its fire was green instead of deep orange. Catra shifted into her panther form and sprang forward. A bellow pierced the silence. The lantern shattered upon meeting the ground.

"Was it a ghost?" Glimmer asked.

Catra reverted to her human form. "It's another demon."

Glimmer stepped toward a trail. "There should have been a way to know where we are going."

Bow walked to a rock wall and scrutinized it. "There's something. I see illustrations."

Glimmer and Catra rushed closer. The lines and symbols reminded her of Grayskull's map. However, there were differences. Bow took out a piece of paper and copied the illustration. Similarly to Grayskull, the map displayed markers of various biomes. According to it, they were in a sort of canyon.

They strode along the path. The cliffs led to foggy chasms. Upon reaching the last curve, they arrived at a clearing. Dilapidated houses lined the stone barriers. It was once a village. In the graveyard, headstones and raised tombs dotted the ground. A few

coffins were left open. Armored skeletons pointed their weapons. Mummified corpses shuffled forward, moaning.

The skeletons charged. Glimmer and Catra retaliated. Bow shot arrows while standing on a ledge. One by one, the mummies fell. Their armored enemies kept fighting. Each sword collided against Glimmer's. She and Catra made short work of the skeletons.

Adam became aware of the tight ropes on his wrists as he awakened. The restraints were connected to a pole behind him. Everything else came into view - a dim hallway, torches, and Horde Clan members. A vague recollection of the midnight ambush surfaced. His gaze flitted around. He could outsmart his captors and escape. Or, he could sneak out.

The clan's footsoldiers chatted as they walked off. Adam bent backward, letting his fingertips brush the ground. His index finger met the handle of a dagger. Someone must have forgotten it. His captors weren't as clever as they assumed.

"I'll check on the prisoner," a female voice said.

Footsteps came closer. Adam waited for that individual. Would they mock him or try to break him? Lonnie, one of the clan members, glared as she approached.

"Guess your friends didn't come for you," Lonnie said.

"They will," Adam replied.

"You put blind trust in your friends?"

"How about we discuss something else. How far will Horde Prime go to secure his tyrannical rule? What will you do to Adora and the others?"

"The naive queen? Why do you ask about Adora?"

"Did anything happen to my sister?"

Lonnie rolled her eyes. "I can't share such information with prisoners."

Adam's shoulders tensed. "You mean hostages."

"Same definition, different words. Horde Prime is the leader now. I don't care how harsh his methods seem at times. He's a capable ruler, unlike your weak sister."

"Adora's not weak. She was helping the kingdom recover from Shadow Weaver's reign. Now Horde Prime's standing in the way of a peaceful future."

"Horde Prime is bringing order!"

Adam maintained eye contact. "He is the wicked warlord from the ancient tale. The heroine of that era had every reason to stop him. If Horde Prime had won, the world would be hopelessly ruined."

Lonnie grimaced. "You're uttering nonsense."

"I'm telling the truth."

"Oh, please. You could blabber all you want. You won't escape." Lonnie turned to leave. "As for Adora, you'll never see her again."

Adam struggled against the ropes. "What did the Horde Clan do to her?"

"You want to know? Here's a hint. Adora's in the dark realm."

"What? How did she get there? Did Horde Prime-"

"The conversation's over."

"We're not done yet!"

Lonnie stormed off. Adam gritted his teeth, then took deep breaths. If her goal was to break him, she hadn't succeeded. The woman never would. All she did was attempt to get under his

skin. And she didn't answer his questions. The idea of Adora trapped in a dangerous dimension worried him. Were their friends searching for her at the moment? Would anyone come for him, too?

Adam reached for the dagger again after a while. This time, he gripped the handle. He twisted his wrists, straining to let the blade meet the ropes. After several tries, the blade cut into the binds. He rose to his height.

Adam crept toward the wall and pressed his palms against the stones. One of them gave way. Next to him, a hidden door disappeared into the wall. He hurried into a passageway. It curved and turned until he found a door at the end.

Once outside, the fresh air enveloped Adam. Judging by the presence of footsoldiers, he wasn't safe yet. He ducked behind a stack of crates to avoid watchful eyes. By the training grounds, Lonnie was talking to Evelyn.

"Hordak says we should plan a fitting punishment for the prisoner," Evelyn said. "He hasn't given suggestions."

"Because Hordak spends his free time with Horde Prime," Lonnie replied. "Entrapta always went with him."

"I could use torture spells. The intensity depends on the stubbornness of the prisoner."

"And when will you start?"

"Lead me to the prisoner. Now."

Adam watched them step through the door. He bolted ahead, evading detection as he winded through the courtyard. Within thirty minutes, there was enough distance between himself and the hideout. The dirt trail split into multiple directions. He could go to Mystacor Village, Gray Haven, or the ocean. The three options lingered in his mind.

Adam could talk to Castaspella in Mystacor Village. The sorceress might know a spell that allowed someone to travel to another realm. Gray Haven was probably teeming with monsters by now. Ocean travel would take weeks. He had to know whether the Rebellion was okay or not. They needed to rescue Adora. The problem was that Horde Prime's followers could track down anyone who rebelled.

Of the three choices, Mystacor Village made the most sense. Adam dashed as fast as possible. There was no way he would let the Horde Clan capture him again. The scenery blurred past him as he continued the journey on foot.

Every hour felt like an eternity in the cell. Adora paced back and forth. She thought about countless outcomes. Hands jittering, she ran her hands through her hair. There was no one here to talk to. Blinking back tears, she plopped onto a stone bench. What would Horde Prime say regarding the agreement? A guard unlocked the cell door and grabbed her wrist.

Adora flinched at the rough hold. "Where are you taking me?"

"Horde Prime seeks your presence," the guard said.

"Why?"

"He will explain once you get there."

The guard escorted Adora to a dining hall. Illustrations on tapestries and stained glass told a story. Conquest was the main goal for the evil protagonist. She recognized Horde Prime in each one. He must have destroyed beautiful worlds. On the opposite side of the dining table sat Horde Prime. He interlaced his fingers.

Adora occupied an empty seat. Horde Prime's eyes evoked a sense of unease within her. His gaze combed over her body. It seemed predatory. In a way, he was trying to probe into her mind. She resisted the urge to fidget.

"You will agree to my terms. Besides, you want the Kingdom of Grayskull to be safe, don't you?" Horde Prime said.

There had to be a catch. Adora bit back a question and maintained a neutral expression. In her heart, she was the opposite. She knew Horde Prime was holding her captive. He could harm anyone he wanted. For now, the queen could answer questions.

"I care about my kingdom," Adora said. "I'd do anything to ensure the well-being of my people."

"Will they welcome you back after your supposed disappearance?" Horde Prime asked.

"You kidnapped me." Adora's voice remained firm. "I would never abandon my kingdom. I'm following in my parents' footsteps. You, on the other hand, usurped me."

"Now, let's not argue. You are a guest here." A growl seeped into Horde Prime's voice. "You know what happens if you defy me."

Adora gulped. "Fine."

A satisfied smirk flashed across Horde Prime's face. "Good. You would not have made it out alive anyway. The guards are stronger. So am I."

"I see. Share the details of the agreement."

"If you listen, the kingdom will live. The light world will not perish. In centuries past, I've conquered various realms. Unfortunately for many, they brought their fates upon themselves. They didn't allow me to remake their dimensions into my image. The people in your world are stubborn."

"There's plenty of brave individuals. They weren't quick to cave in." Adora lowered her brows. "You won't get away with this."

Horde Prime crossed his arms. "I have not finished. Why must you add your words? That aside, I shall get to the point. If you desire to continue ruling, you will do it with me."

Adora felt sick in her stomach. By submitting to a tyrant, she would be betraying her kingdom. She never wanted to become the next Shadow Weaver. Was there another way to convince Horde Prime to avoid destroying Grayskull?

"Do you want to say something?" Horde Prime asked.

Adora's throat constricted. Pain flooded her chest, and she was unable to speak. She couldn't turn her back on the kingdom she loved. What would her parents do if they were in the same situation? Vague memories of Randor and Marlena surfaced. One of them showed Shadow Weaver attacking her parents. The royal couple hadn't lived.

Adora did help defend the kingdom when she led Grayskull's army. But it was one time. Would she meet the same fate as her parents? Her mind became jumbled the longer she focused on events in her life.

It was frustrating. Adora was sure she wouldn't let fear take over. Ironically, she did. Her parents would have called her a coward for hesitating. A single thought pierced her heart - she failed everyone.

"Is there nothing to say?" Horde Prime asked.

"I... I don't know," Adora said in a small voice.

"What will it be? Will you be my empress and ensure the survival of the kingdom? Or will you watch everything crumble?"

Adora's breath caught in her throat. She wanted to beg, to plead. A floating creature with tentacles and a sphere for a head entered. It resembled a jellyfish. Its limbs crackled with electricity. The pulsing light in its head swirled. Familiar faces appeared amidst the glow.

"How did they infiltrate this realm?" Horde Prime spat. His muscles tensed with suppressed anger. "And what are they doing?"

Adora stared at the faces of those she cared about. Glimmer was leading the way. Bow carried a map. Catra sniffed the air in her panther form. Would they come here? Hope fluttered in Adora's chest.

"Tell my little brothers to hinder them," Horde Prime told the creature. "I will not have anyone wrest the queen from my grasp so easily."

The creature emitted an unnatural noise before exiting. Worry overrode hope in Adora's heart. As if noticing her emotions, Horde Prime wore a mocking smile. His eye contact remained direct and probing.

"You won't have a choice." Horde Prime rose from his seat. "Your silence has worn my patience thin."

"What... what are you going to do?" Adora asked.

"You will see."

"Please don't destroy my kingdom."

Horde Prime held up a hand. "Guards, take the queen to her cell. I've heard enough."

A pair of guards grabbed Adora's arms and dragged her into the hallway. Tears stained her cheeks. Soon, her captors tossed her into the cell. They slammed the door shut and left. She rested her forehead against the bars.

After what seemed like forever, Adora reclined on the cot. It would be wrong to submit to a tyrant to protect Grayskull. There was no reason to become Horde Prime's empress.

Adora closed her eyes, inhaling deeply. She imagined herself in the sunlit fields of Grayskull. The flowers and trees would be swaying in the gentle breeze. Warm light would envelop her. The beautiful image provided a break from her current situation. For a moment, she forgot about her anxieties. In the middle of the daydream, a hand grasped hers. It was Glimmer's. She went along with the scene in her mind.

Later on, Adora didn't realize she had fallen asleep. A thought lingered in her mind. Her beacon of hope might come. And she wouldn't be stuck here forever. She yearned for freedom. It couldn't come soon enough.

A Dangerous Nightmare

Glimmer could make out silhouettes in the murky darkness. The clanking sound told her they were wearing armor. Cloaks concealed their faces. Catra was snarling. Bow nocked an arrow.

Their enemies stalked through the fog, advancing. One of them carried a pair of long, sharp swords. Another held a staff with a crystal embedded in it. The tall one had a sword and shield.

The demon footsoldier with two swords leaped, ready to strike. Glimmer retaliated with a parry. She blocked the incoming strikes. Bow let loose the arrows at the other two footsoldiers. The foe with the staff teleported behind him and unleashed an electrical sphere. A scream erupted from his mouth as he collapsed.

Catra was in the middle of sidestepping the demon with the shield. Its weapon met her torso. Glimmer attempted a stasis spell on the monsters. However, they shrugged it off. She enchanted her sword, making it glow. With several swings, she flung multiple blasts. The demons landed on their backs, yet they didn't slow down.

"Did Horde Prime send you after us?" Glimmer spat, readying herself.

"Yes, our master has," the footsoldier said.

"Where is he holding Adora?"

"We are not at liberty to tell you."

"Is there something you're not telling me?"

"This is Horde Prime's domain. He does whatever he wants, and we cannot question his methods. He imprisoned the queen for opposing him."

The other two monsters grabbed Bow and Catra. Glimmer narrowed her eyes. Were they abducting her friends? She stepped forward, scowling. Horde Prime would rue the day he kidnapped her girlfriend. He would also pay for making his minions ambush Bow and Catra.

"What are you doing to them?" Glimmer asked.

"We won't harm them. Instead, we're locking them away," the footsoldier replied.

"Where are-"

An electrical spell cut off Glimmer's sentence as she fell. The ground came up to meet her spine. She slipped into unconsciousness. Later, she awakened, groaning. Darkness met her eyes as she sat up. Her companions were gone. Falling had not been kind to her, as evidenced by her backache. She stretched her limbs, then stood.

Flashes of the confrontation haunted Glimmer's mind. Something on the ground caught her attention. Bow's makeshift map. It could be helpful. She retrieved the paper and pored over it. Judging by the surroundings, she was in the northern part of the plains.

Several paces ahead? Glimmer would be in the forest. In the east, there was a lake. The west? A desert. There were swamp villages, but they might be empty like the one she started in. She conjured a location spell, searching for Catra and Bow. The former was somewhere deep in the forest. The latter was in the desert.

Horde Prime's minions could have locked them in either caverns or ruins. Glimmer strode into the forest, stepping over logs and bushes. In the woods, the landscape seemed more ominous. She swatted the vines away from her face. Picking up the pace, she kept her head on a swivel. Demon bats and crows swooped down, screeching.

Glimmer froze them with the stasis spell. With a flick of the wrist, the knight made them explode. Summoning the light orb, she noticed the darkness clearing away. The lack of churning fog unveiled multiple trails. It would be easy for anyone to get lost in here. Because she knew some spells, she could find her destination. Again, she used her magic, this time seeking out clues.

Sometimes, magical beings would leave behind a residue of their aura. The traces were spaced apart. Did the staff-wielding demon cover up their tracks? Did they teleport? Glimmer followed the trail, never straying from the path. Making her way deeper, she remained alert. A building came into view. Ancient ruins? Or a cavern?

The skeletal arches resembled the shape of a dragon's snout. Strange. Would it mean exploring the inside of a skeleton? Glimmer approached. There was an entrance. She figured it was a cave. With a deep breath, she entered. The glowing sphere in her right hand illuminated the openings. Stalagmites and stalactites filled the corners. She proceeded into the tunnels.

Glimmer couldn't shake off the sense of being stared at. Anything could be lurking in the shadows. The passages had a maze-like structure. Disembodied hands emerged from murky green puddles. They levitated toward Glimmer.

With a single swing of the sword, Glimmer slayed her foes. She continued walking. Sometimes, she ran into dead ends. Descending the stairs, the knight was aware of the foreboding atmosphere. A familiar voice called out. Catra?

If Horde Prime intended for his minions to hinder the heroes, why didn't the footsoldier take Catra somewhere far? Had the dark sorcerer lured Glimmer into a trap? The voice rang out again. It prompted the knight to race into a chamber. A silhouette waited inside the cell. Glimmer's light magic revealed their face. It was Catra.

It seemed too easy. Any moment now, a monster would emerge. The shapeshifter's eyes widened. Catra saw something, didn't she? Glimmer glanced over her shoulder. Then, she whirled around. She recognized the staff in the demon's hand. Something was different - its staff was glowing green. A chilling voice spoke through its mouth.

"You are the hero who wants to stop me. Anyone would consider your determination admirable. You are as predictable as the girl I once fought," he said.

A realization dawned on Glimmer. "Are you communicating through your minion?"

"He'll be my vessel for now. How far will you go to get your precious queen?"

"Horde Prime! Where exactly are you holding Adora?"

Icy laughter reverberated. "I figured you would ask. You will do anything for the queen, correct? But I have plans for her. She will be my empress. If she refuses, the kingdom will not survive. In the end, she will perish."

"Don't touch a single hair on Adora's head!" Glimmer retorted.

"How amusing. You're protective of the queen."

"I have every reason to protect Adora."

"Anyway, we talked too long. See if you can free that girl from this cave." The tone was sarcastic. "Or will you be a failure to everyone who calls you a hero?"

Glimmer swung her sword at the monster's staff. Both weapons clanged. The demon-sorcerer levitated into the air. It volleyed energy orbs at her. Sword slicing through the air, she deflected them. One of them hit her enemy. It descended to the floor, paralyzed. She slashed it repeatedly, cutting vulnerable spots.

The monster retreated to the air. Again, Glimmer beat back the spheres. More slashes slowed its movements. As a last resort, it pulled a dirty trick. It summoned puddles teeming with disembodied hands. They attempted to distract her, but her movements were quick.

Once Glimmer was finished, she plunged the sword into her foe. It disintegrated into a puff of black mist. An unseen voice spoke. Horde Prime again?

"You may have defeated my vessel. However, I will anticipate your arrival in Grayskull," he said.

"What do you mean, in Grayskull?" Glimmer replied.

"Oh, I happen to be a step ahead. The kingdom will bow to me. If not, the people will face my wrath."

"Wait, what?"

"Enjoy the dark realm. See if you manage to fight your way out."

With that, the voice stopped talking. Glimmer muttered, then unlocked the cell. The knight led Catra into an adjacent passage. Tremors shook the ground. Was there an earthquake?

"What's going on?" Catra exclaimed.

Boulders fell from the ceiling, blocking their path. Behind the duo, a chasm formed. Glimmer shot an air spell at the boulders. They didn't budge. Levitating all of them would take time. Glimmer gripped Catra's hand and teleported. Within seconds, they stood several feet from the entrance.

The cave collapsed in on itself, falling into a widening abyss. What if the forest was imploding? Green flames emerged. If Glimmer and Catra had stayed a minute longer...

"Did Horde Prime do it on purpose?" Catra asked.

Glimmer kept an eye on the chasm's edge. "Maybe. I wouldn't put it past him. It was a close call."

"Yeah. Do you know where Bow is?"

"The location spell told me he was in the desert. It's in the west."

"And Adora?"

Glimmer took out the map. A marker signified the location of the fortress. It was in the mountains. Should the duo visit the mountains first? Or should they travel to the desert?

"She might be in the fortress," Glimmer said. "It could be my guess, though."

"We heard what Horde Prime said. He could make it hard for us to save Adora," Catra replied.

"We're not giving up, no matter what he throws our way." Glimmer paced ahead. "Are you in? Let's go save Adora and the kingdom."

Catra caught up to Glimmer. "Yes, let's do it."

They walked along the trail. Glimmer thought about the abyss and the earthquake. The knight frowned. It didn't sit right with her. The timing couldn't be a coincidence. It took place after the battle and freeing Catra. Horde Prime's power must have caused it. Would there be similar incidents in the future?

In Mystacor Village, it seemed as if everything went quiet. The few people who were outside exchanged looks before rushing off. They whispered about Horde Prime's reign. Adam visited Castaspella's residence, exhausted from hours of running. Members of the Rebellion were present.

Some were sorcerers. Others used weapons in fights. Several were non-combatants. Those who were friends with Adam

acknowledged his arrival. He gave Scorpia, Teela, and Sea Hawk a brief smile.

Adam made his way toward Castaspella. "How's everything in the Rebellion?"

"We've been more careful since Horde Prime stole the throne," Castaspella said. "The kingdom's troops were following his orders. They were the same people who fought the Horde Clan. It's as if they felt lost without Adora's leadership."

"There has to be a way to solve this. We can't hide forever." Adam sighed. "Adora is stuck in the dark realm. Bow, Catra, and Glimmer aren't here. Do you know a spell that allows someone to travel between realms?"

"Yes. Are you looking for your sister?"

Adam nodded. "Of course."

"I will begin the spell on the mirror. Have you prepared for the dangers in the dark realm?"

"The Horde Clan took my sword after capturing me."

"I'm guessing they didn't give it back?"

"They didn't."

Castaspella clasped her hands together. "We have a spare sword. It hasn't been used for years. I'll go get it. Wait here."

Castaspella left the living room. Adam sat next to Teela, Scorpia, and Sea Hawk. The pirate was sharing exaggerated tales as usual. Adam couldn't help but crack an amused grin at times. Some of the mentioned feats sounded impossible. Once Sea Hawk finished talking, Adam spoke.

"Did anything happen in Gray Haven and the castle while I'm gone?" Adam asked.

"Dozens of monsters took over," Teela said. "Scorpia and I did our best to help people escape. Others got murdered. In the castle, demonic sentries replaced the guards."

"Have you seen Bow, Catra, and Glimmer?"

"I have no idea."

Adam frowned. All he could think about was starting a rescue mission. What could Adora be feeling at the moment? Was she scared and lonely? His sister didn't deserve to be held hostage. He stood, deep in thought. Castaspella returned, carrying a sword. There were visible marks on the blade, perhaps from past battles. The former owner must have been a warrior.

"This is what I could find," Castaspella said as she handed the sword to Adam. "I'll prepare the inter-dimensional spell. Be careful in that realm."

Castaspella surged her magic into a mirror by the window. The reflection swirled and dimmed. Adam advanced, sheathing his sword. His gaze swept over his shoulder.

"Are you coming?" Adam asked.

"I could," Teela replied.

Thunder boomed outside. A flash of lightning flooded the room. Someone banged on the door. Castaspella rushed to confront the visitor. The next thing Adam knew, Horde Prime's footsoldiers invaded the house. Teela, Scorpia, and other Rebellion members jumped into action.

"Horde Prime's orders! He knows all. He sees all!" One of the footsoldiers shouted.

"Cut the crap! We won't bow to Horde Prime!" Castaspella retorted, sending a volley of kinetic blasts at their foes.

Adam joined the fight. Everyone exchanged blows. Soon, Horde Prime's cronies managed to overwhelm the Rebellion. Each footsoldier restrained the arms of Rebellion members. A floating, jellyfish-like creature floated toward the open door. Its pulsing light churned, revealing Horde Prime's face. Dread and anger mingled in Adam's stomach.

"Ah, the problematic group. What made you assume you could defy me? There will be no peace for those who do!" Horde Prime said.

"Are you arresting all of us?" Adam replied.

"If it is what it takes. Other individuals in Grayskull were wise to submit to me. You are a misguided group. I swear, there is always someone who has chosen to resist. It is foolish to force my hand. All of you must yield. If you refuse, I will take drastic measures. You will receive punishment for disobedience."

"Release my friends and my sister."

"Much like the queen, you had a confident facade. See if it fades."

Adam lowered his brows. "You heard me. Let them go. Take me."

Horde Prime snickered. "Is Grayskull's prince surrendering? You and your sister are not so different. When the push comes to a shove, you both lose courage. You also hide behind the kingdom's warriors."

"Adora and I aren't cowards."

"The same Adora broke down in tears. She trembled in utter terror. Just as you will."

"Shut up about my sister! We're not scared of you. We don't want to lose Grayskull to another tyrant!"

Horde Prime waved dismissively. "You would not be saying such words if you were there." A muscle flickered in his neck, then his

jaw. "Brothers, do with my enemies what you will. Do not let them get away with disobeying me."

Horde Prime's face faded from the jellyfish-like creature's spherical head. The monster vanished into the distance. The footsoldiers began tormenting the Rebellion.

Adam and Castaspella managed to free themselves. They fought to defend their friends. Their foes restrained Adam. Others distracted Castaspella using relentless spells. Teela freed herself after some struggle and attempted to save Adam.

"Go find Adora in the dark realm!" Adam said.

"But-" Teela began.

"You can go without me. I'll be fine. If you meet Bow and the others on the way, stick with them."

They held each other's gaze for a moment. In a swift motion, Teela jumped through the mirror, disappearing. Something sharp pierced Adam's side. The last thing he knew was footsteps leaving the house. Someone was dragging him outside.

It took days to reach the mountains. Compared to Grayskull's mountains, the terrain was rough in the peaks. One wrong move - either Glimmer or Catra could fall down the slopes.

Descending into a chasm would be much worse. Avian creatures with concave heads glided across the sky, emitting eerie hoots. They seemed to be the size of humans. One of them swooped toward Glimmer and Catra.

It was convenient how close the duo was to the cliffs. Glimmer unleashed firebolts at the beasts. The avians dodged each one. The knight launched the spells at a quicker pace. No matter her efforts, they kept eluding her magic. The more aggressive avian rammed into Catra's body, sending her plummeting over the cliff. Catra let out a scream. Her voice echoed.

The ground shook. An avalanche was coming. Glimmer's gaze swept over the area. Would it be possible to teleport Catra to safety and fight monsters simultaneously? Talons snapped at Glimmer's head. Ducking, the knight tried to maintain her balance. Both demon birds screeched as they advanced. The world became a blur as she dodged the tumbling boulders.

Catra's shout became faint. She was repeating Glimmer's name. A lot was happening at once. Glimmer's mind couldn't come up with anything. The avalanche was progressing, the birds were attacking, and Catra was falling. She lost her balance. Talons wrapped around her upper arms. An avian carried her into the sky. Without thinking, she struggled. Then, she teleported, not knowing where she was going.

Glimmer noticed she was plummeting in the same direction as Catra did. Except her companion was nowhere to be seen. Something heavy and solid slammed into her body. Upon blacking out, memories of Adora filled her mind. Something warm enveloped her body. Was she in the water or what? A soft voice murmured her name.

Once Glimmer awakened, the knight found herself reclining on grass. Catra lay next to her. Weren't they in the mountains earlier? The surroundings blurred into view. It was the interior of a cave. How did they survive the fall? Where did the warmth come from? And who talked to her? A groan interrupted the silence. She turned her head in the direction of the sound.

"Catra?" Glimmer asked. "Are you hurt?"

A grunt answered Glimmer's question. She helped Catra sit up. They leaned against the wall. Part of her still wondered about the mysterious rescuer. Could it be a spirit? Or was it the Goddess?

"I'm surprised that we survived," Glimmer said. "We could have died."

"Yet someone or something kept us alive," Catra whispered. "The avalanche was intense."

"I don't think the impact was direct, though." Glimmer recalled the talons. "The demon birds tried to kill us." She drew her knees to her chest. "It was so sudden. It wouldn't have happened if I was more careful. I was so focused on defeating the beasts that I didn't think ahead. I wanted to protect both of us."

"Hey, don't blame yourself. You were holding off the evil birds." Catra's eyes fluttered shut. She inclined her head back. "Is it okay if we take a break?"

"Sure."

Silence fell between the two. Glimmer stared at the exit. Despite the blackness, she could make out faint outlines of mountain peaks. Exhaustion crept over her. The absence of the day-night cycle had messed up her inner clock. She was sure it also affected Catra. At this point, would they call it an adventure? The spooky dimension tested them in many ways.

The sole reason Glimmer visited the dark realm was so that she could save Adora. Bow and Catra came with her. A few times so far, the trio got separated. Now, Bow was awaiting rescue in the desert. What dirty tricks would Horde Prime or the monsters pull later?

Glimmer was slipping into slumber when she jolted with a start. Her senses were on high alert. Was the noise real? Or was her mind playing tricks? She glimpsed Catra's still body.

For now, Glimmer could keep watch. Outside, shadows zipped past vague mountain peaks. She was hoping the horrible birds would leave the duo alone. Fatigue seeped into her bones. It became an uphill battle to remain awake.

Then again, Glimmer and Catra didn't seem to be in danger. Sure, there wouldn't be any harm in catching up on sleep. Yet, anxious thoughts flooded her mind.

However, memories of home washed away the anxiety. Glimmer would do anything to sleep in a warm bed again. She imagined the sun's warmth during sunrises. Her mind drifted to images of the moon and stars. And Adora... The queen's smile was beautiful, as was her laughter.

Glimmer thought of Adora's soft kisses. The way the blonde would melt into her embrace was unforgettable. It made her want to keep Adora safe. Nothing could compare with cuddling at night beneath the covers. She recalled the sensation of running fingers through her girlfriend's soft hair. The memories threatened to make her cry.

Right now, Glimmer needed to be strong. She would do it for her friends and for Adora. And someday soon, things would be right once more. While she slept, she dreamed of a certain blue-eyed queen.

Together Again

"Glimmer... wake up..."

"Hmm?"

"We must have slept for hours..."

Glimmer blinked, yawning as she stretched her stiff legs. Catra was already awake. Waking up to darkness was as confusing as ever. The slumber refreshed her, though. It was a nice change. Still, she wasn't in a plush bed. Cold air washed over her.

"How did you sleep?" Glimmer asked with another yawn.

"It was good. My body must have needed it so bad," Catra replied.

"And your injuries? How are you feeling?"

"Still in pain."

Glimmer's hands lit up with magic. "You'll be okay. I'm going to use the healing spell."

The glow rippled from Glimmer's palms to Catra's body. Its magic encompassed the shapeshifter. For a second, it intensified. The duo chatted while the spell progressed. Catra's wounds and injuries disappeared.

"Thanks," Catra said.

"No problem," Glimmer said.

They stood, then strode to the exit. In parts of the mountain range, the effects of the avalanche were visible. The boulders had toppled trees and blocked waterways. In the distance, the fortress loomed over the mountains.

Familiar hoots penetrated the silence. There was a chance the duo would encounter more demon birds. Glimmer and Catra proceeded, intending to reach the fortress.

The ground was uneven, which posed a risk of losing balance. An hour passed as Glimmer and Catra sought out smooth terrain. To their disappointment, the trail remained bumpy. The path twisted and turned. Sometimes, one of them came close to falling forward. They would mention how it was a close call.

More hours went by. They were alert as they moved, refusing to let their guard down. Glimmer's gaze roamed the surroundings. As they neared their destination, something emerged from under the drawbridge. They jumped back.

It was a dragon. Bone-like spines protruded from its back. The monster's yellow eyes gleamed. There appeared to be a mask on its face. Unfurling its wings, the beast roared. A deep growl rumbled. Its claws swiped at Glimmer and Catra. They leaped out of the way. Fire shot from the dragon's mouth.

Fighting the sea serpent in Seabed Caverns was one thing. So was battling the beast in the Snow Mountains. A hulking dragon in the dark realm? It was different. The beast could shrug off fireballs.

For the next ten minutes, Glimmer and Catra continued dodging. There had to be a strategy. Pillars of fire rose into the churning clouds. The dragon bared its sharp teeth. Its nostrils emitted smoke.

Glimmer and Catra stepped back, observing their opponent. The wings were usually weak. However, this dragon's wings had bony armor. There should be vulnerable spots. The beast advanced, swinging its claws at Glimmer.

Glimmer teleported to a reasonable distance. The knight's magic streamed into her sword. A shout pierced her ears. She attempted to position herself between Catra and the dragon. Its tail came close to slamming into Glimmer. She dodged the blow just in time.

Glimmer rushed to create some distance while analyzing her opponent. Catra sprinted to her side, eyes widening. The dragon was the size of several buildings stacked on one another. An idea formed in Glimmer's mind.

"What if we use size to the dragon's disadvantage?" Glimmer suggested.

"Use size?" Catra repeated.

"See how slow it moves? We could circle around the dragon's legs and land some hits. I'll lead. You follow."

The ground rumbled. Glimmer zipped around the dragon's limbs. Catra, in her panther form, targeted the weak spots. Glimmer plunged the sword into the beast's hind leg. Then, she yanked it out. She nodded at Catra. They continued attacking the dragon from multiple directions.

"Keep going!" Glimmer shouted. "Let's show the dragon what we're made of!"

The battle resumed for countless minutes. Since their foe was powerful, the main goal was to shove the dragon into the abyss. Catra alternated between her panther form and her human form.

Glimmer unleashed spells from time to time while wielding the sword. The dragon glared at them as if aware of their plan. It expelled fire at the duo.

Glimmer conjured a shield, covering the duo. The fire bombarded the shield. The knight's feet skidded along the ground. She waited for the dragon's breath to run out. And it did. She unleashed kinetic blasts in quick succession. The barrage caused the dragon to lose its balance. Its back met the ground in a resounding boom.

Glimmer and Catra weren't done yet. They worked together until they could add the finishing blow. With combined effort, they shoved the dragon into the abyss. Panting, they strode across the

drawbridge. The birds from yesterday ambushed them. Glimmer and Catra made short work of their avian opponents.

They entered the fortress. The dim torches gave the hallway an eerie atmosphere. Statues stood guard over the corridor. The approaching footsteps were faint. Glimmer grabbed Catra's wrist and led her behind a statue.

"Are we sneaking?" Catra whispered.

"We can't have an entire fleet of demons attacking us at once," Glimmer said. "Our objective is to find Adora and get her out of there."

The footsteps slowed to a halt as the sentry glanced around. Glimmer and Catra waited for the opportune moment. The guard neared the statue. When it turned its back, Glimmer slashed its neck, drawing a bloody gash. It collapsed, unconscious. She beckoned Catra toward the door. So far, so good. They walked into an adjacent room. A rope stretched from one ledge to the other.

Below, they saw what seemed to be either a basement or the first floor. Glimmer placed a foot onto the rope. It gave way, yet it didn't break. There was an option to teleport. However, the door on the ledge could open if she landed on it. As for the rope? After dealing with unstable terrain earlier, she didn't want to shuffle across the rope. Maybe she should-

"Glimmer, watch out!"

Catra yanked Glimmer away from whatever ambushed them. A jellyfish-like creature dove at them, extending tendrils. A cold voice inquired about intruders. The familiar tone sent a shiver up Glimmer's spine and shoulders. Feinting to the side, the duo launched an attack. She expelled an air spell at their enemy.

Upon meeting the wall, the creature's head shattered. Glimmer and Catra exchanged glances. There could be more coming. Regardless of the peril, they proceeded to the next room. It opened up to a winding balcony. The surface narrowed.

Eventually, they pressed their backs against the wall to refrain from falling. At the end of it, the ledge widened.

They made their way to a round platform. Towering doors came into view. Hoots flooded the air, accompanied by wings flapping. The birds circled Glimmer and Catra like predators cornering prey. Sentries charged, brandishing their weapons.

"Well, that escalated," Glimmer said. She braced herself for the onslaught.

Glimmer and Catra moved in tandem, vanquishing monsters from all sides. The beasts kept coming. Their assault was intense, as they wouldn't let up. The last of their foes fell. They began pushing the heavy door. As it opened, they peeked inside. Something could be lurking on the other side.

When the duo found nothing, they decided the coast was clear. Still, Glimmer motioned for Catra to be quiet. She let out a soft 'shh.' They crept through the hallway. Another door led them to a spiraling staircase.

Adora lingered by the bars that kept her inside the cell. Many minutes prior, she had heard something outside. Or was it from a hallway? It was hard to tell. A dull thud here. A clang there. She gripped the bars, straining to listen. Something or someone was approaching. Her pulse sped up. Who could it be? Horde Prime's guards? A part of her hoped it was a rescuer.

"Hello?" Adora called out. "Anyone there?"

Swords clashed, each hit echoing. A thud followed. Then, the sound of feet hitting the floor. Someone was running. The next thing Adora knew, Glimmer and Catra stood before the cell. Was it real? Or was it a dream?

Adora silently pleaded for the former to be true. She took in the sight of them. They must have gone through so much. Scratches and wounds darkened parts of their bodies.

Admiration coursed through Adora's veins. It must have taken courage and willpower to endure the realm's dangers. Many heroes bore those qualities. Glimmer unlocked the cell door, freeing her. For the first time in a while, they embraced.

"You came..." Adora said between sobs. Every emotion poured out as she buried her face in Glimmer's shoulder.

Glimmer caressed Adora's back. "Let it all out... you're safe now. We'll stop Horde Prime later."

"Thank you so much..."

Catra cleared her throat. "We gotta go, girls. They'll try to cut the reunion short."

As if on cue, the guards came running. Adora's heart jumped into her throat. Glimmer took her hand, and they bolted. The knight used magic to hold off their enemies. Sometimes, Catra helped. Other sentries attempted to hinder them. A jellyfish-like creature chased them. It alerted nearby monsters.

"Ugh! Just go away!" Catra shouted before shifting into her panther form. She lunged at the monsters.

Glimmer helped beat down their foes. Once the battle halted, the knight led Adora and Catra outside. They dashed to a slope and descended the hill. Hours passed as they sought a place to rest. Despite the lack of danger, Adora couldn't stop shaking. She kept expecting Horde Prime to track them down.

They entered a cottage. Somehow, a few trees displayed signs of life despite the barren landscape. They collected apples and returned to their temporal dwelling. Adora clung to Glimmer, seeking a sense of safety. The women nibbled on their apples, not saying a word.

"Adora... did Horde Prime do something to you?" Glimmer asked, breaking the silence.

Adora could only nod. She hadn't forgotten the threats and unwelcome touches. Horde Prime was determined to break her spirit. Tears sprang to her eyes. It had been a living nightmare. He had made her feel powerless and small.

Glimmer pulled Adora into an embrace. "I won't let Horde Prime hurt you. Do you want to lay down? I'm not going anywhere."

"Sure..." Adora released a shuddering sigh.

Within minutes, Adora reclined on a bed. To her surprise, there wasn't a single layer of dust. Was there remaining life in the dark realm? If so, who survived? She rolled to her side. Glimmer lay next to her. Catra was watching the doors and windows.

"How's everyone else?" Adora asked.

"Other than Bow, I'm not sure. He's somewhere in this realm's desert," Glimmer said. "We'll find him first, then we'll go home."

"What about the Kingdom of Grayskull?" Adora looked into Glimmer's eyes. "What did they think of me now that I failed as queen?"

Glimmer stroked Adora's hair. "They don't view you as a failure. We'll solve this together."

"You promise?"

"I promise."

Adora rested her head on Glimmer's chest. The heartbeat calmed her like nothing else. Her eyes drifted shut. One thought was constant in her mind. It brought her peace. Everything was going to be okay. No matter what she went through, she had an anchor in life. And it was her true love. It was similar to tranquility in the middle of the storm. Sleep took hold of her...

Adora sat in the dining hall. Cold air settled in the room, making her rub her arms. She noticed she was the only one in the hall.

Tapping her foot, she scrutinized the doors and arches. Under one arch, a shadow stared at her. She recognized the green eyes.

"You are my possession," the sinister voice said. "Never escape me."

The shadow stepped forward, revealing its identity. Horde Prime. He reached for Adora's cheek. His icy palm brushed her jaw. It moved to her neck. Shivering, she squeezed her eyes shut. She sensed him drawing closer.

"As Grayskull's queen, you cannot stand on your own. You have failed your people once," Horde Prime said. "I am more of a ruler than you will ever be."

The dining hall transitioned to a field in Grayskull. Everything was burning. Bystanders shot disgusted glares at Adora. She slapped her palms over her ears, blocking out the heckles. The complaints and insults grew louder.

"Coward! Fool! Weak damsel!" The crowd taunted.

Adora took a sharp inhale upon awakening. Her eyes blurred with tears as she sniffled. Aware of Glimmer's arms enveloping her body, the sobs subsided. She was here with Glimmer. The knight had rescued her from the fortress. She didn't know what she would have done without her love.

"Was it a nightmare?" Glimmer whispered.

"Yeah. I dreamed I was in the fortress," Adora said. "Horde Prime was touching me, and..." Her voice trailed off.

Due to their proximity, Adora felt Glimmer's body tense at the mention of Horde Prime. Glimmer held her closer as if protecting her. Not long after, she seemed to relax.

"He does that again, I'll slice his hands off," Glimmer said.

For a moment, Adora imagined Glimmer dismembering Horde Prime's creepy hands. She was sure Glimmer would do more than that, though. They didn't say another word since the fiery statement. Later, they sat up. Catra had taken a seat by the window. The shapeshifter appeared to be nodding off.

"The rescue mission must have worn you two out," Adora said.

"So did fighting a dragon," Glimmer replied.

"Whoa."

Just as Adora thought her girlfriend couldn't get any more impressive, the revelation made her gasp. It must have been terrifying to do it in the darkness. Glimmer then told her what happened before the battle. She shared details of the avalanche.

"It's like the dark realm wanted to destroy us," Glimmer said.

"And yet you survived," Adora replied.

Glimmer chuckled. "It won't be easy to get rid of me."

Adora smiled in response. "I'm glad we're together again."

"Me too."

Glimmer stayed by Adora's side as they chatted for hours. She didn't want anyone or anything to snatch Adora away. A peek at the window reminded her it was still dark out.

The permanent absence of light was disorienting. At some point, a figure observed the group through the window. The top had a spherical shape. It vanished as soon as it materialized.

"Are they following us?" Adora asked.

"It appears so," Glimmer said, glancing outside. "Anyway, we may start traveling to the desert."

"Right now?" Adora furrowed her brows. "I hope we get this done as soon as possible. How can I be the queen Grayskull deserves if I'm not there to defend them?" She folded her hands in her lap. "Glimmer... I'm afraid. If Horde Prime destroys our home, we'll have nothing to return to."

"Adora..." Glimmer walked over and sat. She drew Adora into a hug. "I know how you're feeling. The kingdom might be in grave danger, but not for long. We'll save everyone."

A scratching noise halted their conversation. It came from outside. Catra leaned against the window, perhaps detecting something. She flinched. Whatever it was, it startled her.

A bang prompted Glimmer and Adora to stand. The door swung open, revealing demonic footsoldiers and monsters. Glimmer launched the air spell at them, buying the trio time to flee.

Glimmer, Adora, and Catra raced out the back door. The landscape blurred past them. Hours whizzed by. They dove into a cave, out of breath. Glimmer turned her attention to Adora and Catra. The latter lingered by the exit. Adora placed her head on Glimmer's shoulder.

Glimmer pulled the map from her pocket and scrutinized it. The location spell showed their whereabouts. They were no longer in the mountains. She recalled the chase. Did Horde Prime order his minions to patrol the entire realm? Would there be a peaceful way to arrive in the desert? Or would similar situations occur?

"Glimmer?" Adora asked.

Glimmer made eye contact. "What is it?"

"How far are we from the desert?"

"Not as far as we used to be. We could get there within a week."

"There's no way to tell time in this realm, though."

"True, but we could make guesses."

Adora tucked a strand behind her ear. "The dark realm is empty, right?"

Glimmer tilted her head. "Other than the monsters? Pretty much."

"Where we're from, our home is filled with light and life. Even at night, we have the moon and stars. They illuminate the sky, though not as bright as the sun. In Grayskull and surrounding kingdoms, we had animal life instead of many monsters. The dark realm is the opposite of what we're familiar with."

"Yeah. I've noticed that, too. The things we take for granted aren't anywhere in this dimension. I suspect there was once life in the dark realm. It had villages and graveyards. An extinct civilization could have built those houses. Now, it's a nightmarish land."

A pause fell between Glimmer and Adora. They associated the eerie, empty realm with death and corruption. The black, churning clouds from outside added to the chilling atmosphere.

"If you were home now, what would you be doing?" Adora asked. She pressed her lips and glanced down.

"Guarding you?" Glimmer replied.

Adora chortled. There was a playful glint in her eyes. "Anything other than your duty, my knight. We all enjoyed something about the light realm. Things such as horseback riding, reading..."

"Oh, of course. I rode a horse a lot. There was something about the wind blowing through your hair. I'm sure you enjoyed it, too. Remember the adventure after sneaking out?"

"Yes. It was quite a journey." Adora's posture relaxed. A shallow sigh left her lips. "Upon beating Shadow Weaver, my responsibilities took up most of my waking hours. Being queen has its positives and negatives."

"What would you say are good things about ruling a kingdom? And the bad things?"

"It provided an opportunity to help the kingdom of Grayskull. My intention is to bring in an era of peace. However, it's not easy." Adora swept her hair to one side and twisted a strand around her finger. "People expect a lot from an individual leading their nation. It's a lot of pressure. They wanted a confident leader who made them feel secure. I tried my best to play the part. I had to be strong." Her eyes began glistening as she spoke.

Glimmer took Adora's free hand. Her thumb brushed the blonde's knuckles. Their gazes met. Both women leaned in, breaths mingling. Glimmer wrapped her arms around Adora's waist. Their mouths closed the gap, meeting with tenderness. Her fingers wove through Adora's hair.

They separated, taking a breath. Adora's smile was faint. Glimmer rested a palm against her cheek. She thought about her girlfriend's words. It must have been emotionally taxing to lead an entire kingdom. No wonder her love wanted to cuddle after a long day of responsibilities.

"I'm here. It's okay," Glimmer said. "You may be shouldering your duties, but you're not alone. You have me and our friends. We all want to defend the kingdom from threats."

"You're right. I have my loyal knight." Adora touched Glimmer's forearm. She peeked at Catra, who was watching. "I have our friends. And I'm grateful for that."

Glimmer hugged Adora. "We're in this together."

"I love you, Glimmer."

"I love you, too."

The Darkest Hour

Chapter Notes

> Double update done just in case the storm does something to my area.

It took a week and a half to reach the desert. On the way, Glimmer and her companions had some run-ins. The heat blanketed the land as they walked across the dunes. A brief wind threw sand in their faces. Glimmer searched the expanse. The horizon was shrouded in pitch blackness. There could have been a different source of the heat.

"Are we lost?" Adora asked.

The sand shifted beneath the group's feet. It didn't give way, which was fortunate. They passed a pile of bones. Even the desert was a dead zone. A disembodied howl made them freeze. Were there any ghosts? Glimmer wouldn't be surprised if there were some.

"We have enough water, right?" Adora murmured.

"We do. However, we should conserve it," Glimmer said.

Catra nodded. "Makes sense. Deserts can be dry and hot. I've been in one before."

Specks of sand floated in the wind. Onward, the trio proceeded. At times, the breeze seemed ready to transition into a sandstorm. Waves of heat emerged from the ground. The hot weather was a harsh mistress, oppressing the group. Glimmer conjured a cooling spell. It offered relief to the trio. The drop in temperature renewed their energy. Checking the map, she saw they were halfway.

The progress was noticeable. However, the hours stretched long. A quicksand almost swallowed them whole. Later, they took

shelter in a shack. Glimmer, Adora, and Catra drank water. It was refreshing. The knight stashed the canteen away. It was a mystery how the desert remained hot without the sun. Then again, the weather in the dark realm was independent of the day-night cycle.

Perhaps the realm's seasons were different, too. Unless they were non-existent. Glimmer found it strange how the creatures didn't attack for a while. The knight had gotten used to it in this twisted dimension. She rolled her shoulders.

"The quicksand was rough," Catra said.

"I agree. But Glimmer got us out of there," Adora replied.

"It's one of those situations where life flashes before your eyes."

Adora nodded. Glimmer listened to their conversation for a bit. Glancing outside, she glimpsed a triangular structure in the distance. Was it a pyramid or a temple? Was it their destination?

"See anything interesting?" Adora asked.

"It's a triangle-shaped building. Look out the window," Glimmer said.

Adora did as Glimmer told her. Catra seemed curious, too. They mumbled something about ancient legends. As if to etch the image in their minds, they peeked again. Glimmer rose from her seat. If the pyramid was anything like the places she explored, it might have many chambers. She could picture the layout.

Maybe Bow was in there. All everyone could do was complete the rescue mission, and they would leave the dark realm. Hopefully, they wouldn't encounter another quicksand.

"We could go see what's in there," Glimmer said. "If we find Bow, we could get him out."

"Yeah," Adora said.

Catra stepped toward the door. "Let's go, girls."

And so, their quest continued. The darkness was as unsettling as ever. Something brushed Glimmer's upper arm. She realized it was Adora. The blonde was clinging tight. Did something scare Adora? Glimmer thought the desert was lacking danger. The quicksands were nothing compared to demonic creatures. Sure, a person could sink into one. But someone could also escape it.

The monsters in this realm would kill anything alive. If it weren't for combat experience, the trio would have perished. Being a knight with magical powers, Glimmer needed to be level-headed. Running away wasn't an option when Adora or their friends were threatened.

Glimmer searched for signs of monsters. So far, the knight hadn't seen anything out of the blue. Regardless, she kept her eyes open for anything suspicious.

"Did you see it earlier?" Adora asked.

"See what?" Glimmer replied.

"One of Horde Prime's minions. It's a demonic footsoldier."

"Ugh. It's like Horde Prime wanted them to stalk us."

"That's what I think, too. I bet Horde Prime is trying to intimidate us."

The journey on foot lasted a few hours, perhaps less than the previous walk. The blackness made the passage of time seem vague. At this point, was it day or night? Glimmer, Adora, and Catra approached the pyramid. Its entrance was open, though it probably had a door centuries ago. Cracks zigzagged along the arch, meeting the decaying hinges.

Despite being colored with age, the pyramid endured the sands of time. A statue stood guard, expression unreadable. Something about it was haunting. The building might have held some

significance to a former civilization. With a mix of hesitation and curiosity, the group stepped inside.

Upon entry, a hallway stretched into the churning fog. It gave off a strange odor. Dried blood? Dead, rotting bodies? Who knew what lurked in here? The stone floor was faded, as were the stairs. A few coffins stood upright.

"The inside gives me the creeps," Catra said.

Glimmer shrugged. The coffins were what made the place weird. Was it meant to be a tomb? Would there be undead creatures? The trio explored more hallways. Featureless carvings lined the walls. This dimension and its locations were the very definitions of ruin. Glimmer's light spell ate away at the blackness.

"Did you hear it?" Catra asked.

Glimmer's gaze flitted among the walls and arches. "No. What is it?"

"I'm not sure."

Adora gestured to an odd stone on the wall. "It could lead to a passageway."

Glimmer strode to a door. "Or we could leave it alone."

Adora turned her attention both ways before following Glimmer. Catra, however, was investigating the stone. The shapeshifter's fingers met it. A rumble echoed, and the floor beneath her vanished. It was a trap door. It slammed shut, giving the trio little time to react.

"Catra!" Glimmer and Adora shouted in unison.

Silence hung in the air. A demonic roar ripped through the pyramid. It was an unnatural sound. Either the monsters heard the shout, or they ambushed Catra. Both were definite possibilities. Glimmer and Adora attempted to open the trap door.

A crash made their struggle frantic. They resorted to retracing their steps through the hallways.

Catra thought there was nothing worse than falling into quicksand. The trap door had proven her wrong. The cramped passageways were monotonous and dingy. She figured it was an underground maze. What were Adora and Glimmer doing right now? Were they fighting whatever made that disturbing noise? The corridor opened into a chamber. She could be getting somewhere at last. But where were the other two women?

A silhouette materialized. Was it a ghost stuck in the pyramid? Was it a demon? Catra maintained her distance while observing the spirit. Something in her urged her to fight. Her muscles tensed. This thing stood there. Why wasn't it attacking?

"What are you?" Catra asked.

In response, the creature spoke in an unfamiliar language. Catra couldn't understand what it was saying. Then, it transformed into a feline. Like her, it was a shapeshifter. She shifted into her panther form. At least they would communicate through body language. It walked closer, meowing. The vocalizations suggested that it didn't view her as a threat.

Considering the hostility of many creatures in this realm, the shapeshifter was gentle. Their voices imitated the words anyone would speak in human form. Upon mentioning Horde Prime, the spirit let out a hiss. It referred to him as the 'one who corrupted the land.'

Back in the day, Horde Prime's influence was beginning to spread. Individuals who supported him transformed into demonic minions. Any animal, such as wolves, became a monster. Every semblance of light and life was snuffed out. A group once revolted against Horde Prime. He ended their lives. The survivors went into hiding, only to be maimed by beasts later.

Catra took in the story as she listened. Horde Prime was serious when it came to wiping out resistance. The same fate could befall Grayskull. Such a notion chilled her. At the end of the story, the feline spirit referred to itself as Melog. The name sounded rather unique. She shifted into her human form.

"I'll go look for Adora and Glimmer. They were with me," Catra said.

Melog tilted its head. The vocalizations conveyed a message. It had been alone for some time, wandering the dark realm. A pang of sympathy ached in Catra's heart. Being alone, searching for dead friends in an empty dimension... Releasing a soft exhale, she maintained eye contact. A smile tugged at the corners of her lips.

"You could join us if you want to. You don't have to be alone," Catra said. "Anyway, do you know a way out of the maze?"

Melog answered with a meow. It led the way through twisted corridors and empty rooms. At times, unintelligible writings caught Catra's attention. They might have darkened the stones, but their message was unclear.

Catra recalled the tale of the dark realm. What were the people's final thoughts in their last moments? Were they scared? Did they cling to hope of things changing? Did they accept their fate? If so, was it out of resignation and hopelessness?

Catra's mind drifted to her friends and acquaintances in Grayskull. How long would they hold to their determination and strong will? Would their courage be unwavering?

Catra followed Melog to a stairway. How long had they been walking? Thirty minutes or more? As they ascended the steps, she sensed someone watching them. The hairs on her neck and arms bristled. A peek over her shoulder told her there was nothing here. Was it a figment of her imagination?

Catra and Melog made their way to a dim hallway. Vague apparitions stood by the arches, holding weapons. Their faces

were hidden underneath helmets. Were they soldiers? Did they retreat when Horde Prime corrupted the dark realm? They appeared to stand sentinel over the hallway. It seemed as if they were frozen in time. It was a haunting sight to behold.

Due to having a sixth sense, it was easy to pick up on their emotions. Defiant resignation. Feelings of restlessness. And... melancholy? Catra suspected there was unfinished business. Even in the afterlife, they hadn't moved on.

Catra moved faster, intending to meet up with her friends and leave this creepy tomb. Melog kept up the pace. Familiar voices repeated her name. She could be getting closer to wherever Adora and Glimmer were. They strode around a corner and stepped into an adjacent room. She glanced at a pair of figures in the darkness. Then, it registered in her mind. They were Adora and Glimmer.

"Catra, you're okay," Adora said. Her gaze drifted to Melog. "And who's your new friend?"

"Melog. A feline shapeshifter. It told me a story about the dark realm," Catra said. She proceeded to repeat the tale to Adora and Glimmer.

Adora shrugged. "I'm not surprised. Horde Prime's power could corrupt anything. I don't want that happening to the Kingdom of Grayskull."

Glimmer gestured at Melog. "Catra, is it coming with us?"

Catra nodded. "Of course. Let's start looking for Bow. We need to stick together."

"Yeah, definitely. We thought something happened to you."

"I was in an underground maze the entire time."

The trio, along with Melog, proceeded into a winding passage. Did an ancient civilization create the layout of the tomb on purpose?

What was the reason behind it? Was it to confuse intruders and make them stumble into traps?

A series of stairs, chambers, and corridors later, they found a towering door. It was round, secured by a rusty lock. Growls drifted from the opposite side. Whatever their foe was, it sounded big. They'd most likely encounter a skeleton beast or something undead. With the help of levitation magic, Glimmer plunged a key into the lock. A clicking, whirring noise echoed.

They all entered a spacious chamber. A stench flooded Catra's nose. It reeked of death. What died in here? In the center, a skull the size of a building idled. A shadow blocked the view of the ceiling.

Catra shifted into her panther form and honed in on her senses. There seemed to be more to the silhouette. Its details were sharper. The sickly green eyes gleamed in the blackness.

Growling and ready to pounce, Catra approached the skull. A light swirled within the eye sockets. The snout resembled a dragon's nose. It emitted a guttural snarl as it levitated. Something was supporting the skull. It came into view.

A spine? The limbs emerged, revealing sharp claws on both ends. The skeletal beast glared down at Catra and the others. A fireball ripped from its mouth.

"Watch out!" Glimmer shouted as she pushed Adora out of the way.

Catra leaped in the opposite direction. The beast's clawed hand grasped empty air. Its palm collided against her body, sending her skidding across the stone floor. Hissing in pain, she got on all fours. She wouldn't go down without a fight. And neither would the others.

Glimmer shot spells at the monster's skull, bombarding it. On the other hand, Adora was keeping a bit of a distance. Glimmer slashed at the spine after one spell paralyzed the beast.

The spine was somewhat formidable, as it didn't shatter easily. With a single flick of the wrist, Glimmer made the spine explode. Catra recalled Glimmer saying something about manipulating matter. The skeleton might have been immune to sword slashes. But one matter manipulation spell and its spine would crumble.

Glimmer repeated the spell until the skull landed on the floor. Then, the knight approached. She poked at the skull with the sword's tip. Catra advanced, remaining alert. Her ears swiveled, and her nose twitched.

Something about the defeat was too easy. Disembodied laughter sent a chill down Catra's spine. A demon must have been possessing the skeleton. Glimmer widened her stance.

Mummies emerged from the coffins, staggering and moaning. The skull rose into the air. A shadow, the shape of a dragon, began controlling the skull and clawed hands. Was it the specter that once had this skeleton? A shuffle interrupted Catra's thoughts. The mummies surrounded the group.

Glimmer sliced each foe with every sword swing. Catra and Melog attacked the mummies using claws and fangs. They pinned some enemies to the ground and dug into their chests. The skeletal dragon expelled fire from its mouth. Adora dodged the blast.

Catra noticed a glow in the neck area. Was it a part of the specter? Glimmer unleashed a rune at the orb, bringing down the skeleton. A few mummies tried to grab Adora. Catra lunged at them, forcing them to leave Adora alone.

The battle raged on. Glimmer was fighting the skeleton beast. Catra and Melog slayed dozens of mummies. It was a conflict between the living and the undead. The dark creatures were desperate to take down the group.

Catra, Melog, and Glimmer were pushing back. With a final blow, Glimmer plunged the sword into the skeleton's skull. Her magical aura ran along the blade and reached the glow. The orb vanished.

Catra shifted into her human form, panting. Adora expressed admiration toward Glimmer, saying the knight was brave. Catra walked up to them. She asked Melog where Bow was being held. She described his appearance to the feline. Melog meowed before leading the way. They left the chamber, discussing the battle. Adora was still shaking.

The hallway widened into a room with a cell. Upon taking a closer look, the girls recognized him. Bow glanced back at them. He seemed relieved and tired. Catra and Glimmer searched for a way to unlock the cell. A stone lever idled in the corner, waiting to be pulled. Adora stood by the exit, watching for any enemies.

With combined effort, Catra and Glimmer pulled the lever. Metallic clicks echoed. There was a whir of invisible mechanisms accompanied by creaks. It was probably advanced for a distant era. The cell bars retracted into the ceiling and floor.

"Let's get out of here," Catra said.

The girls hugged Bow, then helped him stand. Glimmer summoned her magic, preparing to teleport everyone. Catra couldn't wait to leave the creepy tomb. A glow enveloped everyone. She braced herself for the effect of zipping from one location to another within seconds.

Adora opened her eyes once the teleportation spell was done. They stood in the middle of a deserted town. Glimmer and Catra mentioned something about being here before. Horde Prime's footsoldiers emerged from the fog. Did Horde Prime mess with the spell or something? Catra transformed into a panther. One of the footsoldiers held a woman captive. It was Teela.

"What happened?" Adora blurted out.

"She was traipsing around after you escaped the fortress," the footsoldier said.

"Let Teela go."

"First, I will relay Horde Prime's message to you. Do not attack, or Teela will lose her life."

Adora's heart ached as she frowned at Teela. The woman was barely conscious, with injuries from a fight. She steeled herself. Next to her, Glimmer unsheathed the sword. Catra's panther body was tense. Melog was snarling.

"What did you do to her?" Glimmer demanded.

"We used force," the footsoldier said. "Do not move if you want Teela to live."

"Go ahead and tell us what Horde Prime wanted us to hear."

"Queen Adora cannot run from Horde Prime forever. The Kingdom of Grayskull remains under Horde Prime's rule. Prince Adam and his band of rebels now wait in prison beneath the castle. Anyone who doesn't want to perish must submit. Defiance will bring death."

Adora's lungs tightened as she listened. Her legs shook beneath her weight. Her heart thumped as she leaned against Glimmer for support. Horde Prime was giving an ultimatum. She couldn't bear to lose her kingdom, to fail her royal legacy. Her brother was imprisoned. Their friends were in danger. The kingdom could receive the same fate as the dark realm.

Resistance would mean risking everyone's lives. Surrender would mean tyranny. Adora steadied herself and straightened her spine. Silence wasn't an option. There could be another way to fight for Adam, their friends, and the kingdom. As much as she hated to consider it, she would do it.

"Is Horde Prime in Grayskull now?" Adora asked.

"Yes. Have you decided yet?" The footsoldier replied.

"Sure."

Catra and Glimmer stepped forward, as tense as ever. Adora held up a hand. The other two gawked at her as though curious. She lowered her hand to her side.

"I'll go to Horde Prime," Adora said. "Let Teela go. Don't hurt the others." She closed the distance between herself and the footsoldier. Then, she peeked over her shoulder.

"Teela will go free," the footsoldier said, releasing Teela. "You will come with us, Queen Adora. Horde Prime will be ready for you."

Teela limped over to the group. Bow helped her maintain her balance. Catra and Glimmer observed Adora and the footsoldier. Next to the footsoldier, a portal materialized. Adora's gaze met Glimmer's for a moment. Knowing her, the knight would storm the castle in Grayskull. Glimmer would do anything for her.

Adora followed the footsoldier through the portal. Within seconds, she found herself in the Kingdom of Grayskull. The castle's interior. Silence blanketed the hallway. Demonic sentries patrolled the corridors. Some rooms were infested with monsters. Adora made her way to the throne room. Upon entering, she froze at the sight of Horde Prime sitting on the throne. He wore a sinister grin.

"Ah, the queen is here to confront me, huh?" Horde Prime said.

"You imprisoned my brother and our friends," Adora said. "What do you plan to do to them?"

"They are a bunch of cowards, assuming they can stop me. As for my plan? I will see if they accept my rule. If not, they will have wasted their lives on foolish rebellion."

"Don't hurt them. I will trade my freedom and life for theirs if I have to."

Horde Prime chuckled, shaking his head. "Oh, the queen is willing to give up the throne easily? And yet her brother is even weaker."

Adora gritted her teeth. Adam might be in captivity, but it didn't make him weak. As she prepared to respond, Horde Prime kept talking. He didn't give her the chance to reply. She clenched her fists.

"Shut up!" Adora said. "You haven't won - and you're not going to."

"There's no way you can fight me. I imprisoned you the last time we met." Horde Prime began approaching. "It won't be different."

"Nothing you do will discourage or break me."

Horde Prime loomed over Adora, making her feel small. She refused to give him the satisfaction of intimidating her. He touched her cheek, making her shudder.

"You are in my grasp, with no way out," Horde Prime said. "You delude yourself into believing you have a choice."

Horde Prime's palms emitted dark magic, seeping into Adora's body. Her consciousness ebbed away. A fog obscured her thoughts. What was he doing? Just as she could say anything, everything went black.

Swords and Showdowns

After the confrontation, Glimmer unleashed a spell to transport the group from the dark realm to Mystacor Village. Castaspella's residence was empty. There were signs of struggle in parts of the home.

Other than demonic sentries outside, Glimmer didn't see much activity. They must have terrified the locals. Bow and Catra helped Teela sit down. Melog watched the windows and exits, meowing to itself.

"Maybe someone could stay with Teela," Catra said.

"Or she could stay at my parents' house," Bow replied.

Glimmer leaned against the window. "While we're discussing Teela, Adora is waiting for us. Horde Prime is in power. We need to act!"

Bow made eye contact. "Right. However, we can't rush into things. We didn't leave the dark realm unscathed."

"I'm a knight. I'm supposed to protect Adora. It wouldn't make sense for me to let Horde Prime hurt her!"

Catra strode to the window. "Bow has a point. Have you forgotten how close we came to losing our lives multiple times?"

Glimmer pinched the bridge of her nose. "We're still here, aren't we? We battled monsters. Anyone else would cower and accept death!"

"We only survived because we worked together."

"And I'm the person who can wield a sword and advanced magic. All you do is turn into a panther and pounce on enemies! And sometimes you used your sword."

Catra sighed. "Because I've improved on using my panther form. And remember how hard it was fighting the dragon? We had to strategize. Now we're facing an enemy who once corrupted the dark realm."

Glimmer paced to the door and gripped the doorknob. "We can't lose anyone else. Adora needs me. So does the kingdom. Unlike the rest of you, I won't hide in fear!"

"It's not about hiding. The legendary heroine didn't defeat Horde Prime by herself. The sorcerers helped."

"I'll find a way."

Catra stood in front of the door. "So, you're heading off on your own? Think about the consequences. Adora wouldn't want you storming into danger without a plan."

Glimmer crossed her arms. "You can't stop me from doing it. I'm a fighter."

"It doesn't make you invincible."

"I can hold my own."

"You'll get hurt. Or worse."

Glimmer considered replying with a statement about not needing protection. The harsh, biting words lingered on the tip of the knight's tongue. A part of her wanted to agree. Acting in the heat of the moment would bring fatal consequences. However, it was tempting to try and charge off on her own. She swallowed a lump in her throat and sat on the stairs.

"I know you're trying to be a hero for Adora," Catra said. She sat next to Glimmer. "I don't want to lose Adora, either. She and I made a promise to have each other's backs. Anyway, we can't do anything rash at the moment. Horde Prime's minions would do anything to hinder us. He won't go easy on us."

Glimmer rested her elbows on her knees and propped her chin against her palms. Her eyebrows drew together as she mumbled under her breath. The lingering silence weighed on her. She looked up at Catra, who hadn't uttered another word.

The gravity of the situation wasn't lost on either woman. Bow was still tending to Teela in the adjacent room. Adam and the others were either imprisoned or injured.

Worst of all, they had no idea what fate befell Adora after she left the group. Glimmer and Catra made eye contact. One minute, Glimmer had insisted on running off on a solo mission. And the next minute - she stayed behind. As if sensing her thoughts, Catra put a hand on her shoulder. Despite the brave front, there was a flicker of worry in Catra's expression.

"We'll figure it out together," Catra said.

"We better do it as soon as possible," Glimmer replied. "I understand that we can't do anything rash, though."

"At least you're not being reckless." Catra turned her attention to the door. "We'll have to devise a plan. Remember doing it when storming the castle last time?"

This time, Glimmer didn't object. She recalled how the group's plan worked when Shadow Weaver held Adora captive. A memory of the castle layout surfaced. Bow and Teela approached the two women. Glimmer and Catra rose.

"So, have you decided?" Catra asked.

"She'll stay at my parents' house for now," Bow said.

Glimmer noticed a silhouette lurking outside the window. Its eyes glowed. It could be one of those sentries. The others peeked in the same direction.

"They could be watching us," Glimmer said.

"What do we do? Sneak and teleport?" Catra replied.

Glimmer led her friends upstairs. "I have a collection of cloaks that we could move around in. As for teleporting, I don't want to teleport us right into an ambush."

They entered Glimmer's old room and rummaged through the wardrobe. She hadn't been here for a long time. The furniture had collected dust in her absence. The blankets and pillows were untouched, as though someone never slept in the bed. Glimmer, Catra, Bow, and Teela pulled out cloaks and began wearing them.

"What about Melog?" Glimmer asked upon seeing Melog in the doorway. "Wouldn't it be visible?"

"Melog may have the ability to turn invisible," Catra said.

"Good to know. Everyone ready?"

The others nodded. All of them left Castaspella's residence. They crept through the streets of Mystacor Village. Sometimes, they hid in alleyways and behind crates to evade detection.

Occasionally, two or three sentries would attack. They reached the wooded part of the village. Willow trees swayed in the breeze. Birds flitted around branches. Next to the library, Glimmer glimpsed a small cottage.

"After dropping Teela off, are you coming to the castle with us?" Catra asked Bow.

"I will. I need to get extra arrows first," Bow said.

The group made their way into the cottage. It was a humble abode with a small dining area and a decent-sized living room. A pair of dark-skinned men sat at the table. They looked up. One of them was holding a book. Bow helped Teela walk into the living room. The two men accompanied them.

"I'm guessing they're his parents," Catra said.

"Yeah. I haven't seen those two before," Glimmer said. "Bow wasn't exaggerating when he told me his parents were busy often. They both run the library."

"Wasn't Bow your childhood friend?"

"He is. We act like siblings."

"That's true, considering."

Snatches of the other conversation drifted into Glimmer's ears. Bow's fathers mentioned the legendary heroine. They brought up Horde Prime's name. The couple's expressions were a mix of worry and hope.

"You're going with your friends to fight Horde Prime?" The shorter man asked.

"Yes," Bow said.

"Be careful. We don't want to lose you, dear son. Lance and I will help Teela heal from her injuries while you're away."

Lance sat next to his husband. "George, I'm sure he'll be fine. He has his arrows. Someone's there to watch his back."

George took Lance's hand. "It still doesn't make our son any more safe."

Bow glanced at George. "I'm a warrior and an adventurer. I have no desire to be a librarian, as much as I like reading books."

George rested his hands on his lap. "I was a warrior, once. A part of the resistance that abhorred Shadow Weaver's tyranny. When Angella and Micah lost their lives, the rest of us went our separate ways. We didn't want to involve family or friends in any of it."

"Their group might have dissolved, but ours is strong together. We didn't let Shadow Weaver intimidate us when we fought her. Ultimately, Glimmer's the one who stopped her. Glimmer cast a

spell to knock Shadow Weaver unconscious. The wicked woman is now at Executioner's Grounds, imprisoned."

Glimmer continued listening to the conversation. At some point, Lance said the legendary heroine wielded a special sword to slay Horde Prime. The blade had gone missing after Horde Prime was sealed away. Glimmer arched her brows. Supposedly, the sword offered a significant advantage.

"Guess we'll have to search for the sword," Catra whispered to Glimmer.

"In that case, the location spell will be useful," Glimmer replied. "As soon as we find the sword, we're rescuing Adora."

Once everyone left Mystacor Village, they began the search for the ancient heroine's sword. The location spell informed them of its whereabouts. It was deep within a cave. The underground passages were used as shelter when the heroine was alive. Her sword had been waiting in a spacious chamber after she died.

Catra followed Glimmer, Melog, and Bow, ducking low-hanging vines as she walked. She swatted branches away from herself. The underbrush rustled beneath their feet. The crisp scent of the woods enveloped her. Rays of sunlight illuminated the dew on the blades of grass. Light and shadow danced along the trail and greenery. Later, the trail transitioned to uneven ground.

The sun made its way toward the horizon the longer everyone's journey lasted. A clearing came into view. Catra and her companions settled by the stream. They needed the energy for cave exploration. Who knew what dangerous creatures lurked in the underground passages? Several paces away, Catra glimpsed the cave entrance. Part of it was covered by vines.

"We're going in there first thing in the morning," Glimmer said. "We'll search the cave for the sword. No matter what dangers the passages throw at us, we'll push through."

"Yes. We'll do it for Adora and for Grayskull," Catra replied.

Bow nodded. "We won't give up until the kingdom is safe."

For the rest of the evening, the group continued their conversation. They bantered, exchanged stories, and made jokes. Even during the kingdom's dark times, they clung to hope. The moon ascended into the sky, and the trio reclined on the grass. Catra rolled to her side, drifting into dreamland...

Catra was standing in the middle of a darkened throne room. A pair of figures stood, their backs facing her. A flash of lightning penetrated the windows. Chilly air enveloped her body. The tall silhouette turned to face her, eyes glowing green. His mouth broadened into a sinister, cold grin.

"I have Adora now," he said. "No one dares oppose me and gets away unharmed. I, Horde Prime, will reign supreme." He reached out to touch the shorter figure. "I will do with her however I will."

"What are you doing to her?" Catra asked.

"You will see. Adora now follows my orders."

Adora glanced in Catra's direction, her expression blank. Then, she flashed a smile resembling Horde Prime's. She held a sword. The blade's hilt was twisted.

"I serve Horde Prime..." Adora said. "I have now surrendered to him."

"This can't be..." Catra murmured.

Catra's eyes fluttered open. The first rays of light spilled into the horizon. Was the dream warning her about Adora? Sitting up, she stretched her stiff limbs. A yawn escaped her lips. Glimmer, Melog, and Bow stirred.

"Hey, how did you guys sleep?" Catra asked as her companions opened their eyes.

Glimmer smoothed her messy hair. "I've had better nights. It doesn't beat sleeping in a bed."

Bow rubbed his face. "I got some sleep, too. How about you, Catra?"

Catra peeked at the stream. "I had a nightmare about Horde Prime and Adora."

Glimmer cleared her throat. "What happened in the nightmare?"

"Horde Prime said he would rule supreme. And he told me he would do whatever he could with Adora. Toward the end, Adora acted strange. The way she spoke, she sounded brainwashed."

"What did she say?"

"Adora mentioned serving Horde Prime and surrendering to him."

Glimmer rose to her height. "We've got to get moving. We can't let Horde Prime get away with whatever he'll do to Adora."

Catra and Bow shot up. The group gathered their things and walked through the cave entrance. They strode into a room dotted with stalagmites and stalactites. Glimmer unsheathed her sword and widened her stance. Melog, standing next to Catra, sniffed the air. Bow nocked an arrow. Skeleton warriors emerged from the shadows.

Glimmer charged at them, slashing them and unleashing a barrage of spells. Catra transformed into a panther and lunged at other skeletons. Bow's arrows flew through the air and met several targets. More of their enemies kept coming.

Once the last skeleton fell, the group proceeded downstairs into the next room. Again, they battled dozens of monsters. Glimmer continued leading the way. The closer they got to the spacious chamber, the more challenging the fights became. At some point in a passageway, they took a break. Catra, Glimmer, and Bow leaned against the cave wall. Melog reclined on the floor.

"This place is testing our endurance, isn't it?" Glimmer said.

Catra sipped from her canteen. "Ugh, tell me about it. It's like the cave is trying us."

"It'll be worth it when I get my hands on that sword."

The group chatted for an hour or so. Without the sun, it wasn't easy to discern the passage of time. Soon, they proceeded to battle more enemies. Upon arriving at their destination, they glimpsed a sword in the center. A pedestal held it in place. Behind it, a statue idled, hands touching its chest.

"Is it the statue of the legendary heroine?" Glimmer stepped closer. "Wait, there's an inscription below the hands. It says... Seraphina. Her name wasn't mentioned in the tale."

"Interesting. Seraphina's friends weren't referred to by their names, either," Catra said.

"There could be a reason for it."

"Are you going to pull out the sword, or?"

Glimmer approached the pedestal, hands wrapping around the sword's hilt. One pull and Horde Prime would fall at her feet during battle. Catra, Bow, and Melog watched in anticipation. Letting out a grunt, Glimmer tried to pull the blade from the pedestal. Within seconds, it slipped up and out. There was a soft scrape of metal against stone as Glimmer yanked the sword.

"Whoa." Glimmer let out a chuckle. The knight swung the sword around. She glanced at Catra and Bow. "Now, let's go save Adora."

An ethereal silhouette materialized, garnering everyone's attention. It was a woman, about the same height as the statue. Catra could make out the crescent moon shape on the chestplate. It was next to Grayskull's emblem. The woman's face bore a faint

resemblance to Glimmer's. Was she one of Glimmer's deceased relatives?

"I am Seraphina, the heroine who once wielded the very sword you're holding. You are the current champion of Grayskull, chosen by Her Grace, the goddess She-Ra. Like the others before you, you will defend the kingdom," the woman said.

The specter vanished as soon as she finished talking. For a moment, Catra wondered about the other sword. What would Glimmer do with the one she had always used? Would she take it to Castaspella's residence?

"I'll teleport us out of here," Glimmer said, approaching Catra and Bow.

"What would you do with the other sword?" Catra asked.

"I'll take it to my old room in Castaspella's home."

After taking her family's sword to Castaspella's residence, Glimmer teleported the group to Gray Haven. She led Catra, Bow, and Melog into the castle. An ominous silence enveloped them. They snuck past the demonic sentries and slayed monsters. Some creatures resembled the ones from the dark realm.

Upon entering the throne room, the sight of Horde Prime on the throne halted everyone's steps. Glimmer drew the sword, scowling. The throne belonged to Adora, not Horde Prime. She stepped forward. The others did, too.

"Horde Prime... what have you done?" Glimmer spat.

Horde Prime snickered, flashing a cold grin. "You came here to find your queen? The woman you swore loyalty to? You and your friends are playing 'hero' at this point. It is amusing. I will crush you all. For those who fear death, I have ways of persuading people." He rose from the chair, towering over the group.

"You mean manipulation. Or mind-control spells." Glimmer straightened her spine. "We don't fear you. Where is Adora?"

"You seek to speak with the queen? She will not be receptive." Horde Prime beckoned a hooded figure forward. "Ah, Queen Adora. Those are the people who defy me."

Adora gently pushed the hood off her head. She turned to face Glimmer and the others. Catra and Bow whispered something unintelligible. They murmured Adora's name. Horde Prime smirked at everyone's reactions as he gripped her shoulder.

Glimmer gritted her teeth. She wanted to yank that massive hand off Adora's shoulder. Her grip tightened around the hilt.

"Adora, don't let him control you!" Glimmer said. "I'll save you. Horde Prime will pay!"

Horde Prime let go of Adora's shoulder. "You are a fool to assume the queen would listen. She had hoped you would come for her. In the end, she considered you a failure and a coward."

"Adora has never seen me as either. She believes in me." Glimmer closed the distance between herself and Adora. "It's me, Glimmer."

Horde Prime lifted his hand upward, his palm facing the group. "I shall make it clear. Nothing will convince the queen to turn against me!" An orb of lightning ripped from his palm.

Upon impact, Bow, Catra, and Melog flew toward the grand doors. They became unconscious. Glimmer raced to them. A magical barrier emerged from the floor, blocking her from reaching them. Footsteps advanced. She whirled around. Adora no longer wore the cloak. The queen pointed the tip of a sword at Glimmer.

"You fools who dare to oppose Horde Prime's reign... there will be no peace for you!" Adora said in a cold voice.

It sounded nothing like the Adora Glimmer knew and loved. Parrying the strikes, the knight anticipated an opening. Whenever she thought there was, an immediate strike caught her off-guard. She tried to devise a strategy while holding a mind-controlled Adora off. Then, she unleashed a spell to reach Adora telepathically.

"Adora, I won't let Horde Prime get away with this. And you want Grayskull to be safe and at peace. Don't you want to resist him? He'll destroy the kingdom. Think about the damage he is causing," Glimmer said.

At first, Glimmer didn't receive a response. Within a minute, the words came through. Adora's voice sounded small and vulnerable. It broke her heart. Anger at Horde Prime washed over her.

Adora's body trembled. "Glimmer... help..."

Glimmer sensed the queen straining to regain control. Horde Prime's spell maintained a tight hold. Tears streamed down Adora's face. Glimmer conjured a rune, unleashing her energy to break Horde Prime's hold.

"Adora, come back to yourself..." Glimmer whispered.

Horde Prime stormed forward, approaching them. "Not so fast!" He shot a blast at Glimmer, giving her no time to react.

The impact sent Glimmer ramming against the magical barrier. Groaning, she forced herself up. Catra's panther form leaped down from an inner balcony. She must have found a passageway to the ledge.

Catra lunged at Horde Prime, tackling him to the floor. He let out a furious roar and shoved her off. Glimmer poured all her energy into a spell to free Adora from his control. By the time she was done, Adora fell unconscious.

Glimmer sat next to her and drew her into her arms. While her left arm supported Adora's head, her other arm draped over the

queen's waist. Behind them, Horde Prime and Catra exchanged blows.

"How dare you brats wrest her from my grasp?" Horde Prime spat.

Catra dodged, then sunk her fangs into Horde Prime's ankle. He let out a bellow of agony as he shook his leg free. In a swift motion, he kicked her with his unaffected leg. She skidded across the floor.

Glimmer looked down at Adora. The queen's eyes fluttered open, and she seemed dazed. Stroking her blonde strands, Glimmer allowed her to rest. The commotion continued in the throne room, reminding her of the situation. She could teleport Adora to safety.

"Glimmer..."

Glimmer was sure she imagined it. But Adora kept speaking in a tired voice. Before she could respond, a roar shook the throne room. Adora's eyes widened, her face paling.

"Of course, Horde Prime would resort to transforming into a literal monster," Glimmer whispered, peeking over her shoulder.

The hulking boar stood in place of Horde Prime, baring its teeth. Its appearance was the same as the illustration in the legendary heroine's tale.

Catra's entire body tensed, ready to pounce. Her ears flattened against her head. Her tail thrashed back and forth. Glimmer moved Adora toward the magical barrier in case Horde Prime would try anything rash.

Glimmer glowered at Horde Prime as she shielded Adora with her body. He charged, his hooves pounding the floor. Slicing the sword through the air, she aimed for his snout. He dodged. Lunging at Catra, he let out a roar. Catra outsmarted him with her panther agility and quick reflexes. After one high jump, she landed on his back and clawed him.

Horde Prime reared up, flinging Catra off with the sudden movement. His front hooves descended, leaving a dent in the floor. Whirling around, he stormed in Glimmer's direction. A stasis spell, and he froze in place. She levitated him. With a flick of the wrist, she flung him across the room. Glimmer and Catra proceeded to attack his abdomen. Each gash from the sword and Catra's claws drew blood.

Horde Prime recovered, rolled away, and jumped into a portal. He reappeared on the opposite side of the throne room. Then, he spewed electrical spheres from his mouth. Every time Glimmer and Catra dodged, more came. Glimmer resorted to deflecting each orb at Horde Prime. Some collided against him, slowing his movements.

Fueled by determination, Glimmer and Catra gained the upper hand in the battle. Each slash, blow, and dodge brought them closer to victory. They didn't notice the soreness and exhaustion in their bodies. Glimmer added a finishing blow, panting as she plunged the blade deeper.

"As long as I live, I'll protect my queen and the Kingdom of Grayskull!" Glimmer shouted. Her magic raced along the sword and surged into Horde Prime.

Horde Prime's body disintegrated into thin air. His voice, however, echoed. "I will rise from the ashes. And when I do, I will destroy all of you. There is nothing you can do to stop me from returning. I will have my revenge."

"No. It won't happen. And even if you come back, I will be ready." As Glimmer spoke, she cast a sealing spell. "This is what you deserve for your crimes against Adora and the kingdom."

The magical barrier vanished. Bow, Melog, Catra, and Adora came forward. Adora embraced Glimmer, trembling. Glimmer stroked Adora's back.

"Thank you, Glimmer..." Adora said. "You saved us all."

"You're welcome. Catra helped, though," Glimmer replied.

Adora pulled away and glanced at Bow. "Go release Adam and our friends from the dungeon. As the kingdom recovers, I shall deal with the Horde Clan and their sorcerers. They shall be punished accordingly."

Bow strode to the door. "I'll go find Adam and the others right now."

Catra transformed into her human form. "I could try to round up the Horde Clan."

Adora sighed. "You won't be going alone. I will send some soldiers to accompany you. The Horde Clan may try to attack you."

Bow, Melog, and Catra left the throne room. Adora turned to Glimmer, seeming drained. A smile tugged at the corners of her lips. Glimmer mirrored her grin. Everything would be okay. They didn't lose anyone, and the kingdom remained intact.

Dawn of a Peaceful Era

The Kingdom of Grayskull took weeks to recover from Horde Prime's temporal reign. Many soldiers cracked down on the Horde Clan, rounding them up. Catra, Teela, and other experienced fighters led the charge. It hadn't taken long to capture Hordak and other leaders of the Horde Clan. Hordak and the sorcerers had been tried for their crimes at Executioner's Grounds.

Castaspella and the good sorcerers had strengthened the sealing spell, ensuring Horde Prime wouldn't escape. Throughout the kingdom, people couldn't stop talking about Glimmer's heroism. A few speculated about her being the current incarnation of Seraphina, the heroine from centuries past.

Despite the peace within the kingdom, Adora's worries lingered. Sometimes, her thoughts manifested in nightmares. However, she put on a brave front whenever fulfilling royal duties. The silence of the night would emphasize her anxious thoughts. Even if her girlfriend comforted her, she hadn't stopped fretting.

One night, the nightmares came in full force. Adora tossed and turned, hyperventilating. Her eyebrows shot up and down, sometimes furrowing. A whimper escaped her lips. Sweat moistened her forehead and hairline...

Adora dashed through a dark village. All around her, darkness churned. Something was chasing her, and she couldn't tell what it was. Its presence was ominous. She'd rather be in the comfort of her room. However, home seemed far away. There was no way back, as she was lost. Her heart thudded, and her throat constricted.

A towering silhouette loomed over Adora. Everything in her body froze. The green eyes were familiar. Horde Prime couldn't be here - Glimmer defeated him. He gripped Adora's shoulders. His palms were cold to the touch. She shivered due to him violating her personal space.

"I will be back. You will regret letting that girl wrest you from my hold," Horde Prime said.

"Don't touch me," Adora said in a wavering tone.

Horde Prime smirked as his hands slid from Adora's shoulders to her neck. She let out a gasp as he began squeezing. Everything went black. Memories of her time as queen blurred by. The images mingled into one distorted entity. A word repeated itself...

"Failure..."

The fragmented scenes from the nightmare faded as Adora sat up, shaking. Her eyes adjusted to the darkness, though the shadows stretched across the room. Moonlight trickled into the window, casting a silvery glow. Next to her, Glimmer stirred awake. The shorter woman wrapped her arms around Adora.

"Nightmare?" Glimmer asked.

"Yeah," Adora said. "It's about Horde Prime. I know you defeated him, but his presence still scared me."

"You're safe with me, princess. Nothing's going to happen as long as I'm here."

Adora rested her head on Glimmer's shoulder. "I wish the nightmares would stop. They're getting in the way of my sleep."

Glimmer stroked Adora's hair. "You're not the only one having those dreams. They can be disturbing."

"You have them, too?"

"Yeah. I understand how it feels. What matters now is that we're here for each other."

Both women reclined, limbs intertwining beneath the covers. Adora buried her face in Glimmer's chest. Her entire body relaxed.

Taking deep breaths, she let her eyes drift shut. There was faint humming. She assumed it was Glimmer's voice.

The pull toward slumber strengthened over time. A part of Adora feared the return of disturbing dreams. So far, however, there wasn't any hint of such visions.

Glimmer couldn't help but observe the sleeping blonde in her arms. Moonlight washed over Adora, illuminating her facial features and braided hair. She seemed peaceful, as there was no tension in her face. Glimmer tucked a strand behind her ear.

Earlier, Glimmer had awakened to Adora whimpering. Though the nightmares weren't as frequent, the queen still had them. She recalled the tumultuous night after Horde Prime's defeat. Adora had been unable to sleep the entire time. As a result, she had awakened with dark circles under her eyes and messy hair.

Adora had gone through the day making more mistakes and acting irritable. The advisors had to help her remember some things. Glimmer had to comfort her during sleepless nights. Adora would take time to heal. So would the others. On some days, she spiraled into panic attacks. She would take a break from royal duties each time.

Glimmer planted a kiss on Adora's forehead. Her girlfriend had endured so much. Being raised by an abusive woman, surviving dangerous situations, and dealing with Horde Prime. It must have been rough. No, the word 'rough' was an understatement.

Glimmer wanted to protect Adora from the darkness in the world. Adora deserved a peaceful life free of dangers. But real life would bring challenges no matter what. It wouldn't make sense to shelter her from the world. There could be wars, conflicts, and any other difficult situations. Being a ruler meant making tough choices.

During the wee hours, Glimmer gave in to the call of slumber. Darkness claimed her, and the time sped by. The next thing she knew was a shuffling noise and a light feeling on the bed. Her eyes sensed sunlight behind her eyelids.

With a yawn and a stretch, Glimmer sat up, rubbing her eyes. Adora was already dashing around the room, getting dressed. A servant helped secure the laces on the corset. Another one threaded a ribbon through Adora's loose braid.

The servants left. Glimmer slid out of bed and changed into her usual tunic and leggings. The chainmail beneath her lavender tunic glinted in the sunlight. A leather belt encircled her waist.

"Glimmer, how did you sleep?" Adora asked.

Glimmer looked up. "I slept fine. And you?"

"Same. It wasn't my intention to wake you up with my nightmares. I shouldn't be having them at all."

"It's okay." Glimmer placed a hand on Adora's shoulder. "You're not wrong for dealing with the aftereffects of such a distressing situation."

Adora shrugged. "Maybe, but it's hard. I still panic, and I have sleep problems."

Glimmer caressed Adora's cheek. "Anytime you want to talk, I'll listen."

"Thank you..."

They shared a brief kiss before Adora went to the throne room. Glimmer made her way to the courtyard. Catra was holding a conversation with Teela, Adam, and Bow.

Judging by snippets of the discussion, Glimmer assumed they were mentioning the safety of Grayskull. They talked about how they could defend the kingdom from future threats.

Glimmer approached. "How's everyone doing?"

"We're doing good," Catra said. "Just discussing our strategies for defending the kingdom from future danger. Did Adora sleep okay?"

"She did after I comforted her. I'm supporting Adora during the healing process."

"I'm sure she appreciates that."

"She does. Adora and I care about each other."

Catra nodded, then glanced away. "It must be nice."

"Hey, maybe you'll meet the right person someday." Glimmer wore a soft smile. "Regardless of that, you're not alone. You have friends."

Catra's gaze met Glimmer's. "I know. Are there single girls we know, by the way?"

"There's Scorpia, Starla, and Tallstar."

"I know Scorpia. I could give her a chance."

"What do you think of her as a person?"

Catra twisted a brunette strand around her finger. "Scorpia's kind and loyal. She can be helpful, like when she got me, Bow, and the others out of captivity."

Glimmer put her hands on her hips. "She's certainly a good person."

"True." Catra turned her attention to the others. "Anyway, I've been wondering if we can continue referring to our group as the Rebellion. We're not under tyranny, and Adora is the queen."

Adam crossed his arms. "I suppose. Yet there's nothing to rebel against. My sister is ruling the kingdom. Not Shadow Weaver or

anyone like that."

Bow shifted his weight from one foot to the other. "You have a point. Also, we have Glimmer protecting the kingdom as its champion. She saved the land a few times."

Teela clasped her hands together. "Rebellion or not, we'll keep the kingdom safe."

Glimmer took a deep breath. "I agree. We all have our roles. Some of us are warriors. Others don't fight as much. They rely on strategy. And Adora, she makes decisions for the Kingdom of Grayskull."

Catra adjusted her belt. "She also dealt with threats to her reign."

"If it happens again, I'll do whatever it takes to protect Adora. I hope Horde Prime doesn't return."

"He was despicable. I'm glad he's gone. Horde Prime didn't stand a chance against your sword and magic anyway. You were so brave during the battle."

"So were you."

Catra tucked a lock of hair behind her ear. "Still, you wielded the sword Seraphina once used."

Glimmer traced her finger along the lines of the sheath. "By the way, I'm keeping the sword."

"It looks cool - especially the hilt. The crossguard reminds me of wings."

"Some people did say it was a special sword." Glimmer unsheathed the blade and examined its form. There were intricate designs on the metal and the hilt. A ray of sunlight glinted off the blade. "I wonder what the story behind the sword is."

"Who knows?" Catra replied. "Perhaps the goddess blessed the sword with great power."

Glimmer sheathed the sword. "The goddess might have."

After the conversation ended, Glimmer strode into the castle. She entered the throne room. Once inside, she stood by a stone pillar. Adora was speaking with various civilians. The queen seemed so regal, even when communicating with rude subjects. There were occasional reports of bandits, though the Horde Clan didn't arise. They mentioned ex-members who defected a while ago.

By noon, everyone left. Glimmer and Adora walked into the hallway. Adora's hand slipped into Glimmer's. For a moment, neither woman spoke. Sometimes, they exchanged glances.

"Is there anything new?" Glimmer asked.

"Just the usual updates on farming and other things," Adora said. "Some people were unsure about the future, considering everything that happened during Horde Prime's reign. Several individuals questioned my competence. They told me I was unfit to rule."

"Why would they bring it up?"

"They thought I was weak."

Glimmer huffed. Those idiots had no idea what her girlfriend went through. If she saw them, she wouldn't hesitate to deck them. Her queen was far from weak. Adora was compassionate and strong-willed.

"Don't listen to them," Glimmer said at last. "Anyone would be a fool to view you as a wimp. If they disrespect you again, I'll get them."

Adora smiled, chuckling. "That's my knight. Loyal, brave, heroic." She composed herself with an exhale. "To be honest, I believe I handled the naysayers well."

"Yeah, I could tell. Earlier, you put up an unbothered front when someone yelled at you."

"It wasn't easy, but I stood my ground."

Glimmer snaked an arm around Adora's. "It was inspiring to watch you become a confident woman. You're not the scared, insecure girl from months ago."

Adora's cheeks flushed. "I came a long way, didn't I?"

"You did." Glimmer gazed into Adora's eyes. "I was there to see the personal growth. Our friends saw your inner transformation, too. Despite what people say, you'll be an amazing queen."

"You think so?"

Glimmer held Adora's hands. "I know so."

Adora leaned closer. Their faces were mere inches apart. Glimmer closed the gap between them, claiming Adora's mouth in a passionate kiss. She wrapped her arms around Adora's neck. Soon, both women pulled away.

"I love you, my queen," Glimmer said.

"I love you too, my knight," Adora replied.

They made their way to the royal office. Adora began working on paperwork. Glimmer grabbed a book and started reading to pass the time. Later on, she peeked at Adora. The queen was now resting her head and arms on the desk. The paperwork must have worn her out.

Glimmer shut the book and put it on the bookshelf. Then, the knight nudged Adora's shoulder. She watched as Adora sat up.

"How long did I sleep? I didn't intend to fall asleep here, by the way," Adora said.

"It was a brief nap. Would you be fine taking a break?" Glimmer replied.

"No. I'm the queen. I shouldn't slack off."

"There's nothing wrong with needing rest."

Adora gathered the papers. "I don't want to let my people down."

Glimmer took Adora's free hand. "I understand that you're trying your best. However, you wouldn't do any good if you were always exhausted. We could go walk in the courtyard."

"Sounds nice. I was considering going outside anyway."

Both women strode to the courtyard and plopped onto a bench. Their fingers intertwined. Glimmer pulled Adora into an embrace. For a second, she imagined themselves spending the rest of their lives together. Breaking away, she prepared to ask. The words came out before she could think about it.

"Adora, I've been in love with you for months. You're the best thing that's ever happened to me," Glimmer said.

Adora grinned, nodding. "Okay, and?"

"I want to spend the rest of my life with you. So... Queen Adora of Grayskull, will you marry me?"

"Glim, are you proposing?"

"Of course. You don't have to accept if you don't feel ready. But the fact remains that I love you as a partner. I couldn't imagine life without you."

Tears glistened in Adora's eyes. "I... I accept. I want to marry you."

Glimmer's heart fluttered at the response. "My queen, I'll do anything to make you happy. I'll keep you safe and stand by your

side."

"I'll be loyal to you, too. And I intend to keep the promise."

Glimmer and Adora fell silent, basking in each other's company. She couldn't believe Adora said yes. Yet it happened. It was a dream come true. In marriage, she would strive to be the most loving partner ever. She would protect Adora, fight for her, and never leave her.

Later in the week, Catra traveled to the Crimson Desert and visited Executioner's Grounds. She went inside during daylight, as the ghosts would haunt the place at night. Walking through the corridors, she scrutinized the cells. In a dim hallway, she glimpsed a figure behind steel bars.

Catra approached, peering into the cell. Shadow Weaver's hair was tangled, and there were signs of exhaustion. The older woman's face was set in a seemingly permanent scowl. Such an expression aged her appearance. Shadow Weaver was the walking definition of 'bitter and hateful.'

"Have you come to gloat over my lack of power?" Shadow Weaver muttered. Her tone dripped with venom.

"I'm here to ask questions regarding how you raised me and Adora," Catra said.

"It's in the past. How are you still hung up over it?"

"Don't dismiss me. Your mind games won't work on me." Catra squared her shoulders. "Why did you drive a wedge between me and Adora by playing favorites?"

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes. "Adora is meant for greatness. She can't have anyone drag her down. I intended for her to follow my example. Softness has no place in the heart of a ruler. And any attachment would drag her down. No wonder she was absent when Horde Prime took over."

"Adora has never wanted to be ruthless. And as for 'attachments,' she wouldn't do any better as a lone wolf. It's normal to have family connections and friendships. Something you don't understand. All you craved was power. And look where you are now. About the Horde Prime issue, Glimmer took care of it."

"I'm aware of her supposed glory. Glimmer is a ridiculous combination of Angella and Micah."

"They're Glimmer's parents. And she didn't save the kingdom for self-glorification purposes." Catra massaged her temples. "I'm not here to listen to you gripe about Adora, Glimmer, and everything else."

"You are persistent, Catra. But I have my reasons for how I raised you and Adora." Shadow Weaver leaned against the wall. The chains from her cuffs rattled with her movements. "Don't expect any apologies."

Catra shook her head. How typical. She wondered how Shadow Weaver slept at night, knowing what the sorceress did. A part of her wanted to scream at her former guardian. However, it could be the reaction Shadow Weaver sought.

"What have Adora and I done to deserve the pain you put us through?" Catra asked. "Why were you so cruel?"

"I thought I told you!" Shadow Weaver spat.

Catra paced back and forth, inhaling deeply. She knew she had to be strong-willed. Shadow Weaver was trying to anger her. If she caved in, she would be giving her the satisfaction.

Catra crossed her arms. "I don't appreciate your refusal to cooperate. There is no excuse for your actions. I don't like how you're speaking to me. If you're going to disrespect me, then the conversation is over."

"Says the girl who ran off shortly after Adora did!" Shadow Weaver replied. "The two of you never listened."

"We left because we couldn't tolerate the abuse." Catra scrutinized Shadow Weaver's body language. She could tell the older woman was hostile. "I'm done, Shadow Weaver. I won't stand here and take your crap. You made excuses and deflected."

"So you'll have me rot in here for the rest of my life? I pleaded guilty during the trial. I haven't attacked the guards so far. What more do you want?"

"Your actions have consequences. You've hurt me, Adora, and everyone else." Catra turned to leave. "This will be the last time we talked. Your choices brought you here."

"If I ever escape, I'll make your lives miserable. You'll beg me to spare you. And I won't."

"Glimmer won't let you succeed. Besides, you're unable to escape, so get over it."

"You underestimate me. I am more clever than you give me credit for."

"As usual, you're threatening revenge. You won't get out anytime."

"I will curse you all. It'll be your worst nightmare."

Catra scoffed. "The patrol is tight around here. Grayskull's sorcerers won't let you regain your magical power."

Shadow Weaver shuffled closer to the bars. "Mark my words. I will come back stronger."

Catra rolled her eyes and proceeded through the hallways. The guards gave acknowledging nods upon noticing her presence. Once outside, she saw Scorpia waiting by the steps. The sun hovered above the horizon.

"How was the conversation with Shadow Weaver?" Scorpia asked.

"She was being her manipulative self. The old witch thought she could get away with her mind games," Catra said.

"And how did it make you feel?"

"I was getting fed up. Shadow Weaver has no remorse for her cruelty. She's heartless." Catra closed the distance between herself and Scorpia. "All she did was make excuses and threats. I'll tell Adora that Shadow Weaver is uncooperative. She won't find it surprising at this point."

They began wandering to a neighboring village. Catra and Scorpia entered the inn, where they would stay for the night. When both women stepped into the room, Catra plopped onto a chair. She pushed her hand into her pocket for a magical gem she'd been carrying. Then, she pulled it out. The gem emitted a soft chime.

Also called 'charms,' the sorcerers handcrafted those gems. They were used for communication purposes. Catra waited for Adora to begin speaking. The queen's voice came through.

"Have you talked to Shadow Weaver?" Adora asked.

"Yes." Catra rehashed the exchange to Adora. They continued the conversation into the night.

"We could get used to the peace in our kingdom," Adora said at some point in the conversation.

"How is your engagement going so far?"

"It's exciting. Someday, Glimmer and I will exchange vows. It'll be like something out of a fairy tale. Besides, when are you coming home?"

"Within a week or so. There's nothing like the feeling of adventure, though."

"Glimmer and I are going to bed soon. Have a good night, Catra."

"'Night, sis."

The gem's glow dimmed. Catra took off her armor. Now, she only wore her nightshirt and leggings. She reclined on the bed, smiling as she closed her eyes. Even in a peaceful kingdom, she would have many more adventures. Any future danger would be no match for Grayskull's warriors.

Glimmer would rise up whenever someone or something endangered the kingdom. Adora would marry the love of her life soon. And Catra now had a companion to travel with. After a year of facing enemies, external or internal, the future seemed bright.

End Notes

Comments / Kudos appreciated 🙂

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